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PIONEER IN SHORT

VIJAYPAT SINGHANIA PASSES AWAY

Former Raymond chairman Vijaypat Singhania died on Saturday evening, his family said. He was 87. His son Gautam Singhania, the group's current chairman and managing director, announced the death on the microblogging platform 'X'. Singhania passed away "peacefully" in Mumbai, and the last rites will be performed on Sunday, a Raymond Group spokesperson said. Vijaypat Singhania, a recipient of the Padma Bhushan, was also a keen aviator and held a world record for the highest altitude gained in a hot air balloon. He led Raymond as chairman for two decades till 2000. After handing over the reins of the company to Gautam, Vijaypat also transferred his entire 37% stake to his son.

23-year Jewar journey now a reality

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ Noida

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday inaugurated Phase I of the Noida International Airport in Jewar: a project approved in 2003 that survived three Governments, four postponements, and over two decades of political blame before a plane could taxi on its runway.

Standing before a crowd of thousands, Modi did something unusual for an airport inauguration. After pulling the ceremonial curtain, he declared the job only "half done." He asked every person present to switch on their mobile phone flashlights and raise their hands, effectively handing the inauguration over to the public.

"This is your property, this is your future, this is your hard work, and therefore, its inauguration is also being done by your hands," Modi said, as a sea of glowing screens lit up the venue. The moment was captured in a single image, revealing the political messaging behind the event: that the airport belongs to the people, not just the Government.

The Atal Bihari Vajpayee

Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Uttar Pradesh Governor Anandiben Patel, Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, Deputy CM Brajesh Pathak and others during the inauguration of the first phase of the Noida International Airport at Jewar

Government first approved the airport in 2003. It remained buried there for over a decade. Modi was pointed in his attack on the Congress and the Samajwadi Party. "From 2004 to 2014, this project remained hidden in files," he said. "Even when our Government was formed in Delhi, the SP Government in UP blocked it for the first two to three years."

Even after the BJP came to power in Lucknow, the airport's opening was pushed back repeatedly from December 1, 2024, to April 2025, then September 2025, and finally to early 2026.

The DGCA issued the aerodrome licence only on March 6, 2026, barely three weeks before the inauguration. Domestic and cargo flights are

expected to begin within 45-60 days, somewhere between mid-April and May 2026. International flights are likely to start from September this year, said Civil Aviation Minister K Ram Mohan Naidu.

PM Modi further cautioned all Opposition parties against "harmful rhetoric" during the ongoing West Asia war and warned that citizens will

never forgive those who damage national interest in times of crisis.

"We have to face this crisis with a calm mind, with patience, with unity. Those who do wrong rhetoric for politics will get some numbers in political debate, but the people of the country never forgive actions that harm the country," Modi said in his speech during the inauguration of the Noida International Airport in Jewar near Greater Noida.

PM's remarks were pointed. He drew a direct line to the Covid pandemic, when, he said, some political forces spread rumours and lied about vaccines to make governance difficult. "What was the result? The public rejected such politics during elections," he said.

He then issued an appeal framed as a request to all political parties. "Avoid saying such things in this kind of crisis, which are harmful for the country. Whatever is in the favour of Indians, whatever is in the interest of India, that should be the policy and strategy of the Government of India."

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Bengal principal corridor for infiltration: Amit Shah

Union Home Minister Amit Shah addressing the media after releasing a 'charge sheet' against the TMC Government in Kolkata

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Saturday sharpened the BJP's campaign pitch for the West Bengal Assembly polls, releasing a "charge sheet" against the TMC Government and framing the election as a battle not merely for Bengal, but for the country's security.

Launching a scathing attack against the Mamata Banerjee Government, Shah alleged that after 15 years of the TMC rule, West Bengal had become the country's "principal corridor" for infiltration due to "TMC's appeasement politics, cor-

ruption and political violence". "Mamata didi has always played the politics of the victim card. Sometimes she talks about her injury, sometimes she abuses the Election Commission. But the people of Bengal now understand Mamata didi's victim card politics very well," Shah said at a press conference.

In its reaction, Trinamool Congress slammed Amit Shah with a counter to his "charge sheet", accusing the BJP of trying to polarise the people of poll-bound West Bengal and evade accountability for its own record on a host of issues, including women's safety.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Oli's arrest sparks protests in Kathmandu

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kathmandu

Protests erupted across Nepal's Capital after former Prime Minister Khadga Prasad Sharma Oli was arrested, triggering unrest among his supporters just a day after Balendra Shah assumed office.

Demonstrators gathered at multiple locations in Kathmandu, voicing their opposition to Oli's detention. In a show of anger, protesters burned copies of the commission report that investigated the controversial "Gen Z" protest movement, while some

groups also set tyres ablaze near key party offices. Oli was taken into custody early on Saturday in connection with a culpable homicide case tied to the violent crackdown on protests in September 2025. The demonstrations had ultimately led to his ouster from power. Authorities also detained Ramesh Lekhak as part of the same investigation.

The probe, conducted by a commission formed under an interim Government, recommended legal action against Oli and other officials. Its findings held him accountable for failing to

Ex-Prime Minister Khadga Prasad Oli is taken for procedural medical checkup after he was arrested by police in Kathmandu on Saturday

prevent the use of force that resulted in the deaths of at least 19 protesters on the first day of unrest.

Following his arrest, the 74-year-old leader — who has a

history of serious health issues, including kidney transplants — was admitted to a hospital in Kathmandu for medical evaluation.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

PM Modi holds talks with Saudi Crown Prince

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday held a telephonic conversation with the Crown Prince and Prime Minister of Saudi Arabia, Mohammed bin Salman, discussing the ongoing conflict in the Middle East.

In a social media post on X, PM Modi said he reiterated India's condemnation of attacks on regional energy infrastructure and emphasised the need to ensure freedom of navigation and secure shipping lines.

"Spoke with Crown Prince and PM of Saudi Arabia, HRH Prince Mohammed bin Salman, and discussed the ongoing conflict in West Asia. I reiterated India's condemnation of attacks on regional energy infrastructure. We agreed on the need to ensure freedom of navigation and keep shipping lines open and secure. Thanked him for his continued support for the welfare of the Indian community in Saudi Arabia," PM mentioned.

This marks the second telephonic conversation between PM and the Crown Prince since the outbreak of the Middle East conflict on February 28. The crisis has involved strikes by the US and Israel on Iran.

MEA denies Musk joined Modi-Trump phone call

ASHOKE RAJ
■ New Delhi

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) on Saturday clarified that a recent phone conversation on the West Asia situation took place solely between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Donald Trump, dismissing speculation that tech entrepreneur Elon Musk was part of the discussion.

Responding to media reports, the MEA stated that the March 24 call involved only the two leaders and served as an opportunity to exchange views on the ongoing tensions in West Asia. The clarification comes after a report suggested that Musk had unusually joined the high-level diplomatic conversation.

According to officials, the

dialogue focused on the evolving geopolitical situation in the region, with both leaders highlighting the importance of maintaining stability. A key point of discussion was ensuring that the Strait of Hormuz remains open and secure. The passage is a critical global energy route, handling a significant portion of the world's oil shipments.

The conversation took place shortly after President Trump announced a temporary pause in potential military action against Iran, a move seen as opening a window for de-escalation. Around the same time, there were indications that Washington might explore diplomatic outreach in the region, including possible engagement with Pakistan in relation to Iran.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

INDIGO FLIGHT LANDS SAFELY AT IGIA AFTER ENGINE FAILURE

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 15-year-old Boeing 737 with about 160 people on board, operating IndiGo flight 6E 579 from Visakhapatnam to Delhi, made a safe emergency landing following an engine failure. A full emergency was declared at Delhi's Indira Gandhi International Airport (IGIA) at 10:39 am on Saturday following reports of one engine failure, according to sources.

The Delhi Fire Services said it received information about the situation at around 10:53 am, following which fire tenders were rushed to the airport. "A flight made an emergency landing at Delhi Airport. According to the fire department, everyone is safe, and no damage has been reported. The fire department received information about the emergency landing at 10:53 am and immediately dispatched fire tenders. The flight landed safely," the Delhi Fire Services (DFS) said in a statement.

The flight landed at 10:59 am as per the flight tracking website flightradar24.com. IndiGo has wet-leased (hired with an operating crew) the aircraft (TC-COR) from Corendon Airlines of Turkey. IndiGo has five of Corendon Airlines' wet-leased aircraft, intended to operate on a short-term basis.

IndiGo, in a statement, said that the technical snag was detected shortly before landing. "As a precautionary step and in accordance with the standard operating procedure, the pilots requested for priority landing, and the aircraft arrived safely at Indira Gandhi International Airport, Delhi. All relevant authorities were promptly informed, and the aircraft is undergoing necessary checks and maintenance.

₹7 cr for a ticket: Congress faces heat over alleged bribery

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police has registered an FIR in connection with an alleged "cash for party ticket" case involving persons linked to the Congress, following a complaint by a Haryana-based man who claimed he paid around ₹7 crore to secure an election ticket for his wife. Police said the case is under investigation and involves allegations that large sums were collected through bank transfers and

cash payments over time. The complainant, Gaurav Kumar from Sonapat, along with his wife Suchitra, approached investigators with documents and details of the transactions.

According to the complaint, Kumar alleged that he was asked to make payments to secure a Congress ticket for his wife, whom he described as a State general secretary of Haryana Mahila Congress. He claimed that the money was paid in installments through multiple bank accounts as well as in cash.

Acting on the complaint, Delhi Police registered FIR No 11/2026 at North Avenue police station under relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita

(BNS), 2023, including Sections 61(2), 318(4), and 316(2). The FIR also names Ansh Ali, said to be associated with KC Venugopal.

In his written complaint addressed to the Commissioner of Police, Kumar named several individuals, including political functionaries and their associates, alleging they collected money in a structured manner through intermediaries, personal assistants, and multiple bank accounts.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

No leash, no mercy: ₹1,000 fine for dog owners

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The fine for letting a dog roam in a public street without a leash, which currently is ₹50 under the Delhi Municipal Corporation Act, 1957, will increase to ₹1,000 if the Parliament passes the Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2025. This change is part of the Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2026, which was introduced by Minister of State for Commerce and Industry Jitin Prasad in the Lok Sabha on Friday. The bill proposes several amendments to the Delhi Municipal Corporation Act of 1957.

Under the proposed

amendments, the fine for tethering cattle on a public road will also rise from ₹100 to ₹1,000. Additionally, defacing or destroying a house number, which currently incurs a ₹50 fine, will be increased to ₹1,000. Other fines are set to increase as well. For instance,

discharging fireworks that may cause danger will go from ₹50 to ₹500.

Preventing a municipal official from entering premises, which also carries a fine of ₹50, will increase to ₹500. In terms of sanitation, failing to arrange for garbage collection, current-

ly fined at ₹50, will be raised to ₹500. Allowing filth to flow into the street and dumping rubbish on the street, both currently fined at ₹50, will each attract a fine of ₹200 under the new legislation.

Regarding buildings, the fine for failing to vacate a dangerous structure when ordered will increase from ₹200 to ₹1,000. Similarly, occupying a building without a completion certificate will also rise from ₹200 to ₹1,000.

The general penalty under Section 465 for violations that do not have a specific fine prescribed will increase from ₹100 to ₹500, with the daily continuing penalty going up from ₹20 to ₹50.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Illuminated India Gate before and after its lights were turned off during Earth Hour on Saturday. Earth Hour, organised globally by the World Wildlife Fund (WWF), is a worldwide movement that raises awareness about climate change, biodiversity loss and the urgent need for environmental sustainability

PANKAJ KUMAR

CM Rekha urges youth to build Dehi 2.0

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Saturday called on young innovators to help build “Delhi 2.0” as she addressed thousands of participants at the ‘India Innovates 2026’ hackathon held at Bharat Mandapam.

Speaking at what was described as the world’s biggest hackathon, the Chief Minister said youth-led innovation will play a key role in shaping governance, cities, and society.

The event brought together over 5,000 selected participants from across the country, chosen from more than one crore applicants. “The energy, skills, and determination of our young people are India’s greatest strength,” the Chief Minister said. She added that India’s large youth population gives it a strong advantage in driving global progress.

The hackathon focused on themes such as artificial intelligence, robotics, and civic innovation.

Participants worked on



solutions aimed at improving urban systems, strengthening democratic processes, and making public services more inclusive.

The Chief Minister said the young innovators present at the event were not just discussing ideas but actively building solutions. “This generation can turn ideas into innovation and innovation into real impact,” she said. Highlighting the scale of participation, she said the selected candidates

represent the future of India’s digital ecosystem.

“Their thinking will shape governance, society, and the economy in the coming years,” she said.

The Chief Minister outlined her vision of “Delhi 2.0” as a city driven by innovation and inclusion. She said technology must go hand in hand with trust and accessibility in governance. She also emphasised the need to connect innovation with real-world governance chal-

lenges. According to the Chief Minister, the Delhi Government is working towards integrating ideas generated by young innovators into its systems.

“The Government is committed to making public services more accessible, transparent, and effective by adopting innovation,” she said.

Officials said the hackathon serves as a platform for collaboration between young minds, pol-

icymakers, and industry experts. The solutions developed during the event are expected to address challenges in urban infrastructure, service delivery, and digital governance.

The Chief Minister encouraged participants to think beyond technology and focus on impact. She said innovation should aim to improve everyday life for citizens and strengthen institutions. She also highlighted the importance of inclusivity in innovation. She said solutions must benefit all sections of society and ensure equal access to opportunities.

Participants at the event included students, developers, researchers, and entrepreneurs from different parts of the country. Many projects focused on using AI and automation to improve public systems such as transport, healthcare, and education. Officials said the large number of applicants reflects growing interest among youth in solving civic and governance issues through technology.

Government working with Centre to minimise burdens on residents: CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government is working in coordination with the Centre to ensure that no additional burden emerging from global circumstances falls on residents, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said on Saturday.

The chief minister was part of the high-level meeting of States and Union Territories chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday, where discussions focused on maintaining economic momentum and ensuring uninterrupted access to essential resources amid global challenges.

“With the unbreakable spirit of ‘Team India’, under the guidance of the prime minister, we are fully committed to ensuring that no additional burden of global circumstances falls on common citizens,” the Chief Minister said in an X post in Hindi.

She said the Delhi Government, in coordination with the Centre, is fully prepared to provide contin-



uous convenience and maintain smooth arrangements for citizens.

“In the current global scenario, maintaining the country’s economic dynamism and ensuring uninterrupted availability of essential resources is our shared priority,” she said.

The chief minister said the Centre has taken “effective and far-reaching steps” to strengthen supply chains, keeping public interest at the forefront, and these measures are helping India remain resilient despite external uncertainties.

On Friday, Prime Minister Narendra Modi chaired a

virtual meeting with chief ministers and lieutenant governors to discuss preparedness amid the “dynamic” global situation arising out of the West Asia conflict.

He said the situation necessitates continuous monitoring and adaptive strategies and called for constant communication between the Centre and the States, along with timely sharing of information and joint decision-making, so that the responses are swift and well-aligned.

This comes amid reports from several states about people resorting to panic buying amid fuel shortage fears.

Police bust illegal arms manufacturing unit

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Police has busted an illegal arms manufacturing unit operating out of Uttar Pradesh’s Meerut and arrested two key accused, including the main supplier who has previously been booked by the NIA under the stringent UAPA.

The case came to light after police received specific intelligence about the bulk supply of illegal firearms from Meerut to Delhi, an official said on Saturday.

Acting on the input, a 25-year-old arms supplier, identified as Hasir alias Shooter, was apprehended near Badli Railway Station in north Delhi on March 19, police said.

Two semi-automatic



pistols, a pen pistol and six live cartridges of 7.65 mm calibre were recovered from his possession, following which a case was registered.

During sustained interrogation, Hasir disclosed that he was sourcing weapons from Parvez alias Farru, a resident of Meerut. Based on the information, the police obtained his custody and formed a team to trace the supply chain, police said.

On March 26, the team raided Parvez’s residence in

Meerut. The accused attempted to flee on spotting the police but was chased and apprehended, they said.

A search of the premises led to the recovery of a large cache of illegal arms and manufacturing equipment, including 24 pen pistols, 78 magazines, multiple barrels, slides and pistol bodies, along with various firearm components and machinery such as a drill machine used in fabrication.

Police said the recovery also included a total of 25 pen pistols — a concealed and highly dangerous category of firearms that resemble ordinary pens, are easy to carry in crowded places and are difficult to detect during routine frisking. These weapons are capable of firing

7.65 mm cartridges at close range. Parvez (37) is a habitual offender with over a dozen cases related to illegal arms manufacturing and has a history of involvement in serious offences.

He was arrested by the NIA in 2017 under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act in connection with the supply of weapons used in targeted killings by Khalistani terrorists and had remained in jail for around five years, police said. He was also arrested earlier by Meerut Police in similar cases, officials added.

Hasir, who studied till Class 7, was earlier involved in a theft case and is allegedly linked to around 10 criminal cases, including an incident of firing at a police team in Uttar Pradesh, police said.

Police, iLive Connect join hands to combat cardiac disease

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

To raise awareness among Delhi Police personnel, iLive Connect partnered with Delhi Police to organise a Cardiac Health Awareness Camp on Saturday at the IT Park in Shastri Park.

The camp included heart health check-ups, awareness sessions on cardiac diseases, and discussions on preventive measures as well as modern technologies.

The event was attended by joint CP Milind Mahadev, DCP (Metro & Railway) Bharat Reddy, and Dr Rahul Chandola-Founder of iLive Connect, Chairman of the Institute of Heart and Lung Diseases, and a senior cardiothoracic and vascular



surgeon. More than 30 police personnel underwent health check-ups during the camp.

Addressing the gathering, Mahadev said that the simple and practical way in which Dr Chandola explained heart health was highly valuable. He emphasised that following these guidelines can significantly reduce heart risks.

“If we take care of our

heart, it will take care of us. Maintaining balance in life is essential. Amid the daily rush, we must take out time for ourselves,” he added.

According to available data, 34,539 people died of heart attacks in Delhi in 2024, compared to 22,385 in 2023. The steadily rising numbers are a cause for concern. DCP Bharat Reddy also praised

the initiative, calling it a positive step toward awareness.

Dr Rahul Chandola informed that this collaboration between Delhi Police and iLive Connect is not limited to a single event, and more such programmes are planned in the future to ensure the well-being of those who protect the city.

While addressing the personnel, Dr Chandola highlighted key concerns: stressful work environments, lack of sleep, poor diet, and insufficient exercise—all of which negatively impact heart health. He advised at least 150 minutes of exercise per week.

During the programme, iLive Connect devices were also provided to several police personnel, including senior officers.

Two arrested for brawl over music at Faridabad club

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Faridabad

After two groups clashed over music played in a club at Omaxe World Street, Greater Faridabad, police arrested two people, including the son of the owner of the establishment, officials said on Saturday.

A woman was allegedly dragged by her hair and beaten up, while her father received serious injuries in the

scuffle, they said. An FIR was registered at the BPTP police station, and police made the arrests on Saturday, they added. A video of the brawl went viral on social media.

According to the complaint lodged by the woman’s father, she was celebrating her birthday at the club late Thursday night and at one point asked the DJ to change the music. One, Simmi Arora, got into an argument with her and slapped her.

Arora then allegedly called her friends and relatives — around 10-12 people — who attacked the woman, Mehak, her friends, and her father, Raman Grover. They are also alleged to have snatched Mehak’s diamond ring, Grover said in his complaint.

On Saturday, police arrested Rishit Chitkara (25), the son of the club’s owner and Dhruv (30), both Faridabad residents, for allegedly hitting the woman and her friends.

Five apprehended for killing 17-year-old boy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Five people, including four minors, have been apprehended for allegedly killing a 17-year-old boy and injuring another when the duo tried to pacify two groups quarrelling at a wedding over food arrangements in outer Delhi’s Rani Bagh area, police said on Saturday.

The incident took place around 11.15 pm on Friday, they said. The deceased was identified as Nikhil Yadav, a bike mechanic, while the injured, Sunny, is undergoing treatment and is stated to be stable. Both were residents of Rohini.

According to the police, an argument broke out between two groups over food arrangements at a wedding function, which



quickly escalated into violence. Eyewitnesses told the police that Nikhil and Sunny tried to intervene and pacify the groups when they were attacked with a knife by another minor.

Both sustained serious injuries and were rushed to a nearby hospital, where Nikhil was declared “brought dead”, police said.

Nikhil’s family claimed

that he was attacked after being mistaken for being involved in a fight while trying to intervene in a scuffle among children.

“Last night, my younger brother went to attend a wedding in Rani Bagh. Some children were fighting among themselves, and he went there to intervene and resolve the matter. There were six or seven boys who

were drunk; they misunderstood the situation and thought he was fighting with the children,” Nikhil’s brother, Vikash Yadav, said.

He alleged that the situation escalated when the group began assaulting Nikhil. “One of them took out a knife and stabbed him in the stomach. He died on the spot,” he added.

Friends of the victim said they were informed about the incident over the phone and rushed to the spot.

“We were at home. Our friend had gone to someone’s wedding, where he might have had a fight with someone. Someone informed us over the phone that Nikhil had died. Another person, Sunny, was stabbed and admitted to Mahavir Hospital in Rani Bagh,” Nikhil’s friend Rahul said.

Will keep close vigil during SIR, says Delhi Congress

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Congress on Saturday said it will keep a close watch at the booth level during the upcoming Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in the national Capital, reiterating that no eligible voter should be deprived of their right to vote.

At a meeting held in Badli village, Delhi Congress president Devender Yadav, who is serving as a booth level agent (BLA-2) for booth number 50 in the Badli Assembly constituency, interacted with booth-level agents ahead of the revision exercise scheduled to begin next month.

The assistant electoral registration officer (AERO) was also present at the meeting and held discussions with booth-level agents of various political parties regarding the process.

Yadav said the party has instructed its booth-level workers to ensure the smooth and fair conduct of the revision exercise. “We will not let any single voter be deprived of their vote and will keep a close vigil in our respective booths,” he said. Referring to a preliminary scrutiny carried out by booth level officers (BLOs), Yadav claimed that several voters were wrongly marked for deletion.

“During cross-verification, we found that many voters who should have remained on the rolls were proposed for removal. We have submitted these cases to the electoral registration officer and the sub-divisional magistrate for re-verification,” he said.

Yadav added that the party has made it clear that any wrongful deletion or inclusion of voters will not be tolerated.

The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Shambhavi, D/o Satendra Singh, resident of 303, A-5, Olive County, Sector-5, Vasundhara, Ghaziabad (U.P.) - 201012 have changed my name from Shambhavi to Shambhavi Phalswal. Henceforth I would be known by the name of Shambhavi Phalswal for all future purposes.

PD(688)C

I, Mrs. Munni, wife of Late Shri Shyama, resident of House No. 1043, Mohalla Chandi Wala, Village Ashora, Tehsil & District Hapur, state that Munni and Premwati are my two names, and both belong to the same person. In future, I should be known and identified as Munni.

PD(689)C

I, Sadia Sulatana, W/o Syed Azhar Hasan, R/o A-5, Second Floor, Khajoori Road, Jogabai Extn., Jamia Nagar, Okhla, New Delhi-110025, have changed my name to Sadia Azhar for all future purposes.

PD(690)C

I, Taqui Hasan, S/o Syed Azhar Hasan, R/o A-5, Second Floor, Khajoori Road, Joga Bai, Okhla, Jamia Nagar, New Delhi-110025, have changed my name to Taqui Hassan for all future purposes.

PD(691)C

I, V Nagaraja, Father of- No.15225622H Nk (OPR) V Naresh, R/o-Thumbakuppam (V) & (P), Bangarupalyam (Mandal), Chittoor(D), Andhra Pradesh- 517416, declare that in my son's service record my D.O.B is wrongly mentioned as 13/03/1967 whereas my correct DOB is 01/01/1958 which may be amended accordingly.

PD(697)C

I, Sushila Gupta, W/o- JC-708205W Nb/sub(Nur Asst) Vinod Kumar Gupta, Unit-Army Hospital R&R Delhi Cantt-110010, have changed my name from Sushila Gupta to Susheela Gupta, vide affidavit dated 28/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(698)C

I, Indrajit Singh, Father No.16021227K Hav Pramod Kumar Singh, R/o- Vill-Bada Kachhar, PO- Surauli Bujurg, Thana- Sumerpur, Teh/Dist- Hamirpur, U.P.-210301, have changed my name from Indrajit Singh to Indrajeet Singh, vide affidavit dated 28/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(699)C

I, Indubai, Mother of- No.16024911X Hav/Clk(SD) Gaikwad Nilesh Sahadu, R/o- Vill- Lahavit, Teh & Dist- Nashik, Maharashtra, have changed my name from Indubai to Indubai Sahadu Gaikwad, vide affidavit dated 28/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(703)C

I, Bhanwar Dan Palawat, Father of TJ007025P Sub Shaitan Dan Palawat, R/o-Vill- Charanwas, PO- Aleesar, Teh- Chomu, Distt- Jaipur, Rajasthan- 303801, have changed my name from Bhanwar Dan Palawat to Bhanwar Dan, vide affidavit dated 28/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(700)C

I, Manohar Kanwar, Mother of TJ007025P Sub Shaitan Dan Palawat, R/o-Vill- Charanwas, PO- Aleesar, Teh- Chomu, Distt- Jaipur, Rajasthan- 303801, have changed my name from Manohar Kanwar to Manohar Kanwar, vide affidavit dated 28/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(701)C

I, No.14658259P Hav Sunil Kumar Basumatary, R/o-Somorpur, PO- Bishmuri, Dist- Kokrajhar, Assam-783370, have changed my daughter's name from Rwishmwi Basumatary to Rwisumwi Basumatary, vide affidavit dated 28/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(702)C

I, Indubai, Mother of- No.16024911X Hav/Clk(SD) Gaikwad Nilesh Sahadu, R/o- Vill- Lahavit, Teh & Dist- Nashik, Maharashtra, have changed my name from Indubai to Indubai Sahadu Gaikwad, vide affidavit dated 28/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(703)C

PUBLIC NOTICE

The original GPA duly registered as Doc. No. 6471, Book No. 4, Vol. No. 2773, at pages 179 to 181, dated 07/07/1992, in the office of Sub-Registrar IV, Delhi and WILL DEED duly registered as Doc. No. 21032, Book No. 3, Vol. No. 608, at pages 66 to 67, dated 07/07/1992, in the office of Sub-Registrar IV, Delhi, in respect of Property No. 35, First Floor, Shreshtha Vihar, Delhi-110092, lost founder may inform:- Basanti Agarwal, Ganshyam Prasad Agarwal, SBI Building, S.R. Lohia road, State Bank of India, Tinsukia, Assam-786125.

HEREDITARY DECLARATION

This is to declare that my client Gauri Shankar R/o-42 C, 2nd floor, Block-D, Tilak Vihar, New Delhi-110018 is the only legal heir of his late father Shyam Sunder as well late Mother Sarla Devi after their death on 30/9/2025 and 03/12/2025. He stands legally valid heir to own the said property as well bank Accounts balance of his late parents.

Any objection to this declaration can be addressed to the Contact No-9891043528/7982711629-Adv. Rajesh Kumar within 15 days of this edition.

Delhi Dated Mar 25, 2026

Rajesh Kumar Advocate.

Mo no. 9891043528/7982711629

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the General Public on behalf of our client i.e. ICICI Bank Ltd. that Girish Narayan Rai & Madhubala Rai were joint owners of Residential Plot No.-51, Area Measuring 230 Sq. Mtrs. Pocket-B, Sector-01/01-01, Greater Noida "the said property", vide Transfer deed dated 27.05.2023, registration No. 19635, whereas Mrs. Madhubala Rai is claiming to be owner of 1/4 undivided share of above property vide mutation letter dt. 19.08.2025 in the record of GNDA after demise of Girish Narayan Rai. All Persons are hereby informed that above owner want to sale the said property to Mr. Samar Pal Singh & his nominee who is taking a Home loan facility from our client against the said property. If anybody has any objections upon the ownership of above owner its title, mortgage, Charge etc., kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 07 days of the present.

Kumar & Associates (Advocates & Consultants) 200, 1Ind Flr. 23, Shivaji Marg, Moti Nagar, N.Delhi-15 legal@kmalgaup.com Ph: 011-41112527-28

PUBLIC NOTICE

Public at large hereby informed that Khandelwal Hospital & Urology Centre, B-16, East Krishna Nagar, Delhi-51, is going to destroy all IPD/OPD and other papers prior to 1st January 2021. Anybody interested may please contact within 7 days.

Khandelwal Hospital & Urology Centre, B-16, East Krishna Nagar, Delhi-110051 Ph. No. - 011 42408561

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that my clients Lokesh Kumar and Ekta Gupta are in process to purchase the 3rd Floor with roof rights built up property no. G-34, admeasuring 200 sqyds i.e. 167.22 sq.mtrs, situated at Radhey Puri, Delhi (availing loan from HDFC Bank Ltd.) from Tarundeep Singh (50% share) and Akanksha Saxena, Reena Jain & Gareem Devi (50% share), having acquired the said property by virtue Sale Deed dated 29/4/2023 Doc no.3586 executed by Neelam Sawhney and Rama Mallhotra. All persons having any claim against or in respect of the said Property, or any part thereof, by way of sale, exchange, mortgage (equitable/registered or otherwise), gift, trust, inheritance, family arrangement, maintenance, bequest, partnership, possession, lease, sublease, tenancy, license, lien, charge, pledge, easement or otherwise howsoever, are hereby requested to notify the same in writing to us with supporting documentary evidence at the address mentioned below within 15 days from the date hereof, failing which the claim or claims, if any, of such person or persons will be considered to have been waived and/or abandoned.

Kamal Kant Gupta (Advocate) Unit No. FF-2, First Floor, Mahamukti Metro Tower Sec-4, Vaishali, Gzb., U.P., Mob. 9810603351

Unit No. FF-2, First Floor, Mahamukti Metro Tower Sec-4, Vaishali, Gzb., U.P., Mob. 9810603351

NORTHERN RAILWAY

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

Name of work and its location	68-SRDEE-G-DLI-2025-26
Approx. cost of the works in	Rs. 33205048.00/-
Address of the office	Sr. Div. Elect. Engineer/General, New Delhi.
Earnest Money	Rs. 664200.00/-
Last Date & time of submission of tender	20.04.2026, 16.00 Hrs.
Opening of tender	20.04.2026, 16.00 Hrs.
Website & notice board	www.irops.gov.in & Sr. Divl. Elect. Engineer/General, New Delhi

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PM Modi inaugurates Phase I of Noida International Airport

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday inaugurated Phase I of the Noida International Airport in Jewar: a project first approved in 2003 that survived three Governments, four postponements, and over two decades of political blame before a plane could taxi on its runway.

Standing before a crowd of thousands, Modi did something unusual for an airport inauguration. After pulling the ceremonial curtain, he declared the job only “half done.” He asked every person present to switch on their mobile phone flashlights and raise their hands, effectively handing the inauguration over to the public.

“This is your property, this is your future, this is your hard work, and therefore, its inauguration is also being done by your hands,” Modi

said, as a sea of glowing screens lit up the venue. The moment was captured in a single image, revealing the political messaging behind the event: that the airport belongs to the people, not just the Government.

The Atal Bihari Vajpayee Government first approved the airport in files in 2003. It remained buried there for over a decade. Modi was pointed in his attack on the Congress and the Samajwadi Party. “From 2004 to 2014, this project remained hidden in files,” he said. “Even when our government was formed in Delhi, the SP Government in UP blocked it for the first two to three years.”

Even after the BJP came to power in Lucknow, the airport’s opening was pushed back repeatedly from December 1, 2024, to April 2025, then September 2025, and finally to early 2026.

The DGCA issued the aerodrome licence only on March

6, 2026, barely three weeks before the inauguration. Domestic and cargo flights are expected to begin within 45 days, somewhere between mid-April and May 2026. International flights are likely to start from September this year.

Developed at a total investment of around ₹11,200 crore under the Public-Private Partnership model, the Noida International Airport is set to become the second international airport serving the Delhi-NCR region, after Indira Gandhi International Airport.

The two airports, the Government said, will function as an integrated aviation system, easing congestion and expanding passenger capacity.

The airport will serve as a primary international airport for cities including Noida, Meerut, Ghaziabad, Mathura, and Agra and will also double as a gateway to pilgrimage and tourist destinations in



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, Deputy CM Keshav Prasad Maurya, Governor Anandiben Patel and others during inauguration of the Noida International Airport in Jewar

the region. Modi listed the cities set to benefit: “Agra, Mathura, Aligarh, Ghaziabad, Meerut, Etawah, Bulandshahr, Faridabad — this entire region

is going to benefit greatly.”

Alongside the airport inauguration, Modi also laid the foundation stone of a main-tenance, repair, and over-

haul (MRO) facility at Jewar. He pointed out that currently, 85 per cent of India’s air-craft have to be sent abroad for maintenance work.

Noida airport will boost UP’s economy: CM Yogi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Noida



UP Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath addressing during inauguration of Noida International Airport in Jewar, Gautam Buddha Nagar district

“visionary leadership” over the past decade.

Adityanath stated that the airport is part of a broader vision to transform India into a developed nation, noting that such infrastructure projects are driving growth across various sectors.

“This new airport will place Uttar Pradesh firmly on the global aviation map and represents a new chapter of development,” he said.

Highlighting future expansion plans, he said the airport is currently starting operations with one runway and

will soon have a second, while in the long term it is envisioned to have up to five runways, establishing itself as a major global aviation hub.

Taking a swipe at previous governments of Congress and the Samajwadi Party, he alleged that Uttar Pradesh had long suffered due to “policy paralysis and mis-governance”, but had now emerged as a “breakthrough state” under the double-engine government over the past few years.

The chief minister noted that the foundation stone of the airport was laid by Modi on November 25, 2021, and the inauguration of its first phase within a few years reflects the pace of development. “When determination is strong and confidence is unwavering, no goal is unattainable. Jewar airport is a result of that resolve turning into reality,” he said.

He said the airport’s runway would not only boost the State’s economy but also serve as a gateway to a brighter future, accelerating investment and creating large-scale employment opportunities.

Adityanath highlighted the airport’s strategic connectivity through the Yamuna Expressway and its integration with major upcoming infrastructure projects, including the Delhi-Mumbai Expressway, Eastern Peripheral Expressway, Ganga Expressway, Regional Rapid Transit System (RRTS) and the proposed Delhi-Varanasi high-speed rail corridor.

He said the project would generate employment for lakhs of youth, both directly and indirectly, while also attracting investment in sectors such as manufacturing and logistics.

Noida airport’s Sarus-inspired logo reflects UP’s cultural heritage

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Noida



The Noida International Airport, inaugurated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday, has adopted a Sarus-inspired logo that reflects Uttar Pradesh’s cultural heritage along with its aspirations for modern, sustainable development.

According to a statement issued by the State Government, the airport’s logo features the Sarus crane — the state bird — as its central motif, symbolising tradition, ecological balance and regional identity.

The Government said the logo has been designed with sleek and unified lines to represent speed, connectivity and world-class infrastruc-

ture, in line with the airport’s positioning as a major global aviation hub. A blue-green gradient in the design reflects a blend of technology and environmental consciousness, underscoring the state’s emphasis on sustainable and green development.

“The flying Sarus in the logo symbolises progress, confidence and an Uttar Pradesh moving towards new heights,” the statement said, adding that it aligns with the

project, asking the crowd to applaud them. He also linked the airport to wider agricultural opportunity, saying the expansion of modern connectivity would boost food processing in Western UP and allow agricultural products to reach world markets.

He also credited sugarcane farmers for helping reduce India’s dependence on crude oil through ethanol blending, saying it had saved foreign exchange worth approximately ₹1.5 lakh crore.

The event was attended by UP Governor Anandiben Patel, Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, Deputy Chief Ministers Keshav Prasad Maurya and Brajesh Pathak, Union Civil Aviation Minister Ram Mohan Naidu, and Joseph Felder, Chairman of Zurich Airport.

Tight security and a traffic advisory were in force from 7 am to 11 pm across Gautam Buddh Nagar ahead of Modi’s visit.

CM Rekha distributes laptops to 1,200 students

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



work, and success,” she said.

She stressed that the Government is committed to providing equal opportunities in both education and sports. “Our aim is to ensure that every young person gets the right platform to realise their aspirations,” she said.

Highlighting infrastructure improvements, the Chief Minister said nearly 9,000 classrooms have been equipped with smart boards in the 2025-26 period.

She added that computer labs have been set up in 275 schools, while digital

libraries have been introduced in 100 schools.

The Chief Minister said the government is working to make schools fully equipped with modern facilities such as smart classrooms, language labs, and updated libraries. “We are building a digital learning ecosystem so that students can compete at national and global levels,” she said.

Referring to the National Education Policy 2020, she said it has made the system more inclusive and future-ready. She added that initia-

tives like laptop distribution will help students engage with technology and expand their learning opportunities.

On sports, the Chief Minister said the Delhi Khel Mahakumbh has created opportunities for over 25,000 athletes. She said the event has helped promote a sporting culture and identify talent across the city.

The Chief Minister said financial support is also being extended to athletes. Under the Mukhyamantri Khel Protsahan Yojana, ₹50 crore has been released so far, including ₹15 crore in the latest tranche, to support training and resources.

Education Minister Ashish Sood, who was also present, said the government’s budget reflects its commitment to education. He noted that out of the ₹1.03 lakh crore budget, nearly ₹19,000 crore has been allocated to the education sector. “Education and sports are not tools of politics, but pillars of nation-building,” Sood said.

Capital emerging as creative, media hub: Mishra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



Delhi Tourism Minister Kapil Mishra on Saturday said the national Capital is steadily emerging as a creative and media hub as he visited the International Film Festival of Delhi (IFFD) at Bharat Mandapam and reviewed a major exhibition tracing the journey of Indian cinema.

The Minister said the festival has attracted participation from filmmakers, artists, and young talent from across the country, positioning Delhi as a growing centre for cinema, culture, and media engagement.

During his visit, Mishra explored an exhibition that presents the evolution of Indian cinema from its early years to the present day. The exhibition also highlights the global reach of Indian films and their role as a cultural soft power.

Curated by art collector Neville Tuli of TRIS, the exhibition is divided into 12 the-

matic sections. It showcases the works and contributions of legendary artists across generations. It also presents insights into both Indian and global cinema, including their achievements and challenges over time.

“The exhibition is a significant step towards establishing Delhi as a global hub for cinema and cultural research,” Mishra said. He added that it creates a platform where cinema, education, and culture come

together, while also strengthening dialogue between the Indian and international film industries.

The Minister interacted with visitors, including students and cinema enthusiasts, and gathered feedback on the festival. He noted that IFFD is witnessing strong engagement and is currently at its peak, with active participation from youth and industry professionals.

Mishra said the festival is not only a celebration of

cinema but also a platform for nurturing talent.

He highlighted that masterclasses, workshops, and script pitching sessions are being organised as part of the event, offering opportunities for young filmmakers and artists to learn and showcase their work.

He further said that Delhi is moving beyond its identity as an administrative capital and is developing into a hub for the creative and entertainment industries.

Efforts are being made in collaboration with the Delhi Government, Government of India and Prasar Bharati to strengthen media and technology infrastructure in the city. An MoU has also been signed in this regard.

Referring to upcoming events, Mishra said a special “Night of Honours” will be held on March 30. The event will feature a live performance by internationally acclaimed composer Ricky Kej, which is expected to be a major attraction.

Traffic crackdown near India Gate ahead of summer rush

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



ensure smooth traffic flow, proper parking, and strict adherence to traffic rules.

As part of the plan, the traffic police is also installing 10 Red-Light Violation Detection (RLVD) cameras at key intersections. These include Mathura Road-Bhairon Marg, Ring Road-Bhairon Road, and Janpath-Tolstoy Marg.

The cameras will automatically capture and penalise vehicles that jump red lights. Officials said the RLVD system

will help reduce manual enforcement and improve compliance. “Visitors are advised to follow traffic signals and rules to avoid penalties and ensure a smooth travel experience,” an officer said.

The department has also operationalised the Violation on Camera (VOCa) system in the area. Under this system, traffic personnel can issue challans digitally if a vehicle is found parked in a no-parking zone or abandoned.

Small eateries struggle as LPG cost soars in black-market

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Small eateries, long the backbone of the bustling food streets of the national Capital, are losing their spark. Pushed by dwindling LPG and soaring black-market prices, many are being forced to reshape menus, reduce staff, and return to cooking on coal and wood.

For Neeraj Chawla, who has been running Vaishno Rasoi in Rajouri Garden for the past year after stepping away from a joint family setup, the struggle is both financial and personal.

Shutting shop would make sense, he confides, but it is the fear of “beizatti” (shame) that keeps his stoves — now largely running on coal and wood — alight, even as hope begins to flicker.

“Beizatti nahi ho ke band karke baith gaya hai, isiliye chala raha hoon (I keep it running to avoid the shame of shutting down),” Chawla

said, explaining why he continues despite high operational costs and mounting losses.

Amid the West Asia crisis, the Government has revised the priority order for allocating domestically produced natural gas, placing LPG production alongside CNG and piped cooking gas at the top. This has led to an alleged supply crunch for hotels and restaurants which use market-priced commercial LPG.

With daily sales, which once hovered around ₹12,000 on a good day, slipping further as coal and wood double cooking time and reduce efficiency, Chawla has already had to lay off two staff members.

From neighbourhood staples like KK Da Dhaba in Tagore Garden, a stone’s throw from Chawla’s eatery, to Khadak Singh Da Dhaba in Malviya Nagar, further across the city, small eateries are facing the same struggle.



People queue up to avail LPG cylinders amid ongoing supply crunch in Dilshad Colony, New Delhi

Pankaj Dawar at KK Da Dhaba has turned to coal and slashed fried items from the menu.

Disappointment was written large on his face as he said, “No layoffs yet. But LPG prices in the black market are crazy, beyond the reach of most people.”

People familiar with the situation said that a cylinder, typically priced between ₹1,000 and ₹1,500, is now being sold for anywhere

between ₹3,000 and ₹4,500. The situation is more worrisome for Rajinder Singh Bhandari, owner of Khadak Singh Da Dhaba, who hasn’t had LPG for a week.

“No non-veg, only a temporary stove on the tandoor. LPG mil hi nahi raha (can’t find LPG anywhere),” he says, adding that daily sales have fallen from ₹30,000 to half.

To think that only small eateries are bearing the brunt of the situation would

be misleading. Franchise chains and plush cafes alike are in the same boat, scrambling for quick fixes to minimise losses and keep their kitchens afloat.

The sudden LPG shortage has forced restaurants to rethink how they cook, and Secret Ingredient, a consultancy that advises restaurants, has been fielding nonstop calls.

“We’ve been actively working with brands to identify credible induction and electric equipment partners, including solutions that can handle high-intensity formats like woks and bulk cooking.”

“Alongside this, we’re helping teams rethink menu design and prep structures to reduce unnecessary gas dependency, whether through smarter batching, sequencing, or reallocating certain processes to alternative heat source,” said Sid Mathur, founder-director of Secret Ingredient.

IN FOCUS



Tulips bloom at the Indira Gandhi Memorial Tulip Garden, Asia's largest tulip garden on the Banks of Dal Lake in Srinagar

PTI

6 newly opened airports shut in UP: Akhilesh

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Lucknow

Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav on Saturday accused the BJP-led state Government of undertaking large-scale infrastructure projects to primarily benefit select contractors, pointing out that six of the seven airports inaugurated in recent years were non-functional on the day the Noida International Airport commenced operations.

"See the BJP's corrupt management: six out of seven new airports are shut," Yadav said on X.

He also questioned the condition of the remaining airports, and shared a news video from last year, which alleged that scheduled flight operations at several newly opened airports have been discontinued.

Among the airports mentioned in the video are those in Chitrakoot, Azamgarh, Shravasti, Moradabad, Aligarh and Kushinagar, which was opened as an international airport but has not seen any



to and fro regular service abroad. Yadav alleged that the BJP Government is spending billions on construction only to hand out contracts to their cronies and share the profits.

"They have no intention of actually running any airport, nor flying planes under the UDAN scheme — they're in it only to make money," he alleged. Meanwhile, the Uttar Pradesh Government said that the state has 16 operational airports and eight under construction.

In another post on X, Yadav responded to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's remarks while inaugurating the Noida International Airport in Jewar, where he accused the Samajwadi Party of turning Noida into an "ATM for loot" during its tenure.

US report shows Pak as main base of terror groups

RAJESH KUMAR

■ New Delhi

The US has identified Pakistan as a base of operations and/or target for numerous armed, non-state militant groups, some of which have existed since the 1980s.

A new US Congressional Research Service (CRS) report has again spotlighted Pakistan as a main base for a wide spectrum of terror organisations, from globally oriented groups including Al Qaeda to India-focused outfits such as Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT), Jaish-e-Mohammed (JeM), Harakat-ul Jihad Islami (HUJI), Harakat ul-Mujahidin (HUM) and Hizbul Mujahideen (HM).

The CRS "In Focus" report, updated on March 25, 2026, identifies Pakistan as a base of operations and a target location for numerous armed non-state militant groups, some of which have existed since the 1980s. The report underscores that outfits long associated with attacks in India remain active despite years of military operations and counter-terror measures.

The report notes that Pakistan continues to serve as an operational ground for numerous armed non-state actors, many active since the 1980s, broadly classified into five categories: global, Afghanistan-



oriented, India and Kashmir-focused, domestic, and sectarian terror outfits (anti-Shia). Of the 15 outfits identified, 12 are designated as Foreign Terrorist Organisations (FTOs) under US law, with most driven by Islamist extremist ideology.

According to the CRS brief, Lashkar-e-Taiba (LET) was formed in the late 1980s in Pakistan and designated as an FTO in 2001. Led by now-incarcerated Hafiz Saeed and based in Pakistan's Punjab province and in Pakistan-administered (Azad) Kashmir, it has changed its name to Jamaat-ud-Dawa to circumvent sanctions. With several thousand fighters, LET was responsible for the mass-scale 2008 terrorist assault on Mumbai, India, as well as several other high-profile attacks.

As per the brief, Jaish-e-

Mohammed (JEM) was founded in 2000 by Kashmiri militant leader Masood Azhar and designated as an FTO in 2001. Along with LET, it was responsible for a 2001 attack on the Indian Parliament, among numerous others. Based in both Punjab and in Azad Kashmir, JEM's roughly 500 armed supporters operate in India, Afghanistan, and Pakistan while seeking annexation of Indian-administered Kashmir into Pakistan. JEM has openly declared war on the United States.

The CRS noted that Harakat-ul Jihad Islami (HUJI) was formed in 1980 in Afghanistan to fight the Soviet army. After 1989, HUJI redirected its efforts toward India, although it did supply fighters to the Afghan Taliban, and it was designated as an FTO in 2010. With an unknown strength, HUJI operates in Afghanistan, Pakistan, Bangladesh, and India, and seeks annexation of Indian-administered Kashmir into Pakistan.

It said Harakat ul-Mujahidin (HUM) was designated as an FTO in 1997 and operates mainly from Azad Kashmir and from some Pakistani cities. It was responsible for the 1999 hijacking of an Indian airliner that led to the release from an Indian prison of JEM's future founder; most HUM cadres

subsequently defected to that group.

Hizbul Mujahideen (HM) was formed in 1989 — reportedly as the militant wing of Pakistan's largest Islamist political party — and designated as an FTO in 2017. It is one of the largest and oldest militant groups operating in Indian-administered Kashmir. HM's cadre of up to 1,500 is composed primarily of ethnic Kashmiris who seek independence for Kashmir or annexation of Indian-administered Kashmir into Pakistan.

Despite facing severe domestic terrorism, Pakistan has struggled to dismantle these networks.

Terror-related fatalities, which had declined to 365 in 2019, have surged sharply in recent years, reaching 4,001 in 2025, the highest in over a decade.

The violence is largely concentrated in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and Balochistan, particularly along the Afghanistan border.

The report highlights that multiple military offensives and intelligence-based operations by Islamabad have failed to eliminate several US- and UN-designated terrorist groups operating within its borders. While Pakistan has taken "some steps" to curb terror activities, as noted in the US State Department's Country Reports on

Terrorism 2023, concerns remain over radicalisation, including teachings in certain madrassas that may foster extremist ideology.

Islamabad, meanwhile, continues to deny allegations of harbouring militant groups and has accused India of supporting insurgent activities in its western provinces, claims New Delhi has consistently rejected.

The CRS assessment also traces the presence of major global terror outfits such as Al Qaeda and Islamic State-Khorasan Province (ISKP), alongside regionally focused groups like the Afghan Taliban and the Haqqani Network, many of which have operated from or maintained links to Pakistani territory. Pakistan's counterterror financing record has also drawn scrutiny in recent years.

The Financial Action Task Force (FATF) placed the country on its "gray list" in 2018 over deficiencies in tackling terror financing, before removing it in 2022 after Islamabad completed mandated reforms. The report underscores that, despite periodic crackdowns and international pressure, Pakistan remains one of the countries most affected by terrorism while simultaneously being a key hub for multiple militant organisations with regional and global reach.

Several B teams were formed to break AIADMK: says Palaniswami

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Chennai

AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami on Saturday alleged that several "B teams" were formed and many tried to "break" the AIADMK by filing cases in court, but all that has been smashed and shattered into pieces.

Without naming expelled AIADMK leader O Panneerselvam, Palaniswami, while garnering votes in North Chennai for the April 23 Assembly polls, said, "Several internal problems were created in the party and now see where they (Panneerselvam) have gone."

"The true face (of Panneerselvam) has come out. The cat is out of the bag. After Amma's (As Jayalalithaa is fondly called, meaning mother) demise, many tried to capture this movement intentionally. But with the



help of you all and party supporters, we stopped and have proven that AIADMK is a strong movement," he said.

"After Amma passed away (on December 5, 2016) they thought the party would break. They tried so much to break this party by creating some B teams. But, along with the support of the people and party cadres, all that has been smashed and shattered into pieces," he said.

Stressing that the party had been started for the welfare of the poor by the late Chief Minister M G Ramachandran, Palaniswami said after his demise the movement got split. "But Amma (Jayalalithaa) united them and fulfilled the dreams of our revolutionary leader (M G Ramachandran)," he said amid thunderous applause from the audience. The only party to have ruled Tamil Nadu for 31 years is the AIADMK and because of it, the state secured top rank among other states in India, he claimed.

Observing that the party follows democracy, he said in the DMK it is not so, as no matter how much one toils hard for the party's growth they would not get any recognition. The ruling DMK's objective was to only "loot," he said, and asked the people whether such a party should come to power again.

FROM PAGE - 1

₹7 cr for a ticket: Congress faces heat...

He claimed that payments were split into smaller amounts and routed through different individuals to avoid detection. He specifically alleged that funds were collected in connection with KC Venugopal through accounts linked to aides, including transactions in the names of individuals such as Nazma, Asiya, and Unais Khan on various dates in 2022 and 2023. He also claimed that payments were made directly into accounts linked to the political functionary on multiple occasions. Kumar stated that he paid ₹75 lakh in cash at the Delhi residence of Venugopal after being introduced there for discussions regarding the MLA ticket. He said he had submitted biodata and held meetings as part of the process.

The complaint further alleged that Kodikunnil Suresh received money through his own account, his son's account, and through his personal assistant, along with around Rs 90 lakh in cash. Kumar claimed these payments were made in expectation of securing a ticket. In another allegation, Kumar said money was paid through Sahab Khan, the personal assistant of Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, for arranging meetings and facilitating the process. He claimed that ₹25 lakh was handed over at Priyanka Gandhi's 10 Janpath residence office, and an additional ₹10 lakh was paid later. Kumar added that after that, one more MP told me to give ₹25 lakh each to Priyanka Gandhi's four staff members. I paid everyone, but she betrayed me. He further said that despite making payments running into several crores, he claimed the promised ticket was never granted.

The complainant stated that he possesses supporting material, including WhatsApp chats and a voice recording, to substantiate his claims. He also alleged that payments were made partly through bank transactions and largely in cash. Kumar said his family has had long-standing links with the Congress but accused certain leaders of misleading party workers. He also expressed concern for his safety, stating in the complaint that he feared possible retaliation after filing the case. Police officials confirmed that an FIR has been registered under relevant sections and that the investigation will focus on verifying the claims.

"We are examining the complaint, financial transactions, and any supporting evidence provided. The money trail, including bank accounts and cash components, will be investigated," an officer said. Investigators are expected to scrutinise bank records, transaction details, and communication records mentioned in the complaint. Statements of those named may also be recorded as part of the probe. Congress, however, has strongly rejected the allegations. Haryana Congress President Rao Dan Singh had earlier dismissed the charges as "baseless and politically motivated," question-

ing the timing of the accusations and asking why such claims were being raised nearly a year after the purported transactions.

Bengal principal corridor for infiltration...

Hours after Shah's Press conference, the ruling TMC questioned the BJP-led Centre over the prolonged violence in Manipur, women's safety in BJP-ruled States and the Centre's handling of illegal immigration. Hitting out at West Bengal CM over her opposition to the Election Commission's SIR exercise, Shah accused her of manufacturing outrage to protect the TMC's "minority vote bank".

"The Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls has taken place in other States too, but nowhere has it been made such an issue. It has been made an issue in Bengal only because Mamata Banerjee wants to protect her vote bank. Abusing constitutional bodies like the Election Commission is not part of Bengali culture," Amit Shah said. Claiming that infiltration through Assam had "almost come to an end" after the BJP came to power there, Shah alleged that West Bengal has now emerged as the "last remaining route through which infiltrators enter India and disperse across States".

"The Bengal election is important not only for Bengal but for the entire country. The security of the entire country is, in a way, linked to the Bengal election," Shah said. In one of his sharpest attacks, Shah said the security of the strategically crucial Siliguri corridor — the narrow strip linking the Northeast to the rest of India — was being endangered "because of the TMC Government's appeasement politics". The home minister alleged that despite repeated requests by the Centre, the Mamata Banerjee Government had not provided the land required for fencing along the Bangladesh border. Shah said that if the BJP comes to power in Bengal, it would hand over the required land to the Centre within 45 days for fencing.

"In the coming elections, Bengal has to choose between fear and trust. For the last 15 years, the rule of fear, corruption and appeasement politics has been going on in the state. Mamata Banerjee has created a new way of politics by using lies and violence to move her politics forward. The basis of TMC coming to power lies in lies, fear and violence. But since 2011, the BJP has been fighting against these," Shah said. Senior TMC leaders Mahua Moitra, Bratya Basu and Kirti Azad held a joint press conference where they targeted the Union Home Minister over his criticism of the TMC Government on women's safety. "Amit Shah is talking about women's security. What is the condition of women's safety in BJP-ruled States?"

Rejecting the allegation, the TMC noted that the BJP has been in power at the Centre for over a decade and has been ruling several border States.

"BJP rules at the Centre. It rules 15 states and

Rahul claims UDF united, set for 100-seat landslide in Kerala

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Saturday said the United Democratic Front (UDF) in Kerala is "united and strong" and on course for a landslide victory, projecting 100 seats in the upcoming Assembly polls.

Gandhi met senior party leader and Kannur Lok Sabha MP K Sudhakaran and his family members ahead of the April 9 election. Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge was also present during the meeting.

Sudhakaran, a former Kerala Cabinet minister and ex-state Congress chief, was reportedly keen to contest the assembly elections but was persuaded by the party leadership to stay out of the fray.

Sources indicated that he was reportedly miffed with the party over the decision.

In a post on X, Gandhi said, "Met Sudhakaran ji and his family today, along with Congress President



Mallikarjun Kharge and KC Venugopal. K Sudhakaran ji has spent a lifetime fighting for the people of Kerala — through every storm, every challenge, every test. He has the strength and loyalty of a true Congress soldier".

"The UDF is united and strong. We are heading towards a landslide victory with 100 seats in Keralam," the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha claimed.

The Congress-led UDF has been out of power in Kerala for a decade now and is seeking to wrest the state back from the CPI(M)-led Left.

most border States through which infiltration is happening. Amit Shah himself is the Union Home Minister. So what exactly has he been waiting for?" senior TMC leader and West Bengal Education Minister Bratya Basu said. Questioning the Centre's claims on infiltration, Basu asked why the Union Home Ministry had "failed" to identify and deport illegal immigrants. In a separate statement, Basu alleged that the BJP was using the issue of infiltration to create divisions in Bengal. Moitra said, "It is pathetic that he is standing before cameras to declare filing of chargesheet when there are cases against him by central agencies."

"When a clown sits on a throne, he doesn't become a king, but it becomes a circus," she said, describing Shah as a "clown". TMC Lok Sabha MP Kirti Azad said the BJP Government withheld Rs one lakh crore dues of the State and blocked money for all development and social welfare projects, which did not happen for Maharashtra, Gujarat, and Rajasthan. Azad described Shah as the only Union Home Minister having "cases against him" in history.

No leash, no mercy: ₹1,000 fine for dog...

The bill will also eliminate several provisions. For instance, the highest fine in the Act, which is currently ₹10,000 plus ₹500 per day for commencing building work without notice under Section 337(4), will be removed completely.

Penalties for keeping a market open without a licence will be set at ₹2,000, while the fine for damaging street lamps will be ₹100, and the penalty for failing to notify births and deaths, currently ₹50, will also be dropped by the proposed legislation. Section 387, which allowed for a municipal sweeper to be imprisoned for up to one month for being absent without notice, will be decriminalised and replaced with a civil penalty of ₹500.

Conversely, several offences that currently attract modest fines will be upgraded to criminal liability. For example, depositing items in the streets will change from an ₹100 fine to potential imprisonment of up to six months and/or a fine of ₹5,000. Erecting structures that obstruct streets and opening roads without permission will attract the same penalties, the proposed legislation States.

Additionally, the bill proposes to shift the adjudication of most violations from criminal courts to a municipal officer at least of the rank of assistant commissioner. This will include a 30-day appeal window and a six-month deadline for disposal, governed under proposed Section 461A.

The Bill has proposed to amend the Motor Vehicle Act to allow a 30-day grace period after the expiry of a driving licence, during which it will continue to remain valid.

The bill proposes to amend Section-11 of the Public Premises (Eviction of Unauthorised Occupants) Act that at present provides for six months' jail or with ₹5,000 penalty or both.

MEA denies Musk joined Modi-Trump phone call

This marked the first direct interaction between Modi and Trump since early February, when both sides had discussed strengthening trade ties, including a reduction in tariffs on Indian goods.

In a public statement following the call, Prime Minister Modi emphasised India's support for reducing tensions and restoring peace at the earliest. He also underscored that uninterrupted access through the Strait of Hormuz is vital for global economic stability and energy security. Separately, External Affairs Minister (EAM) S Jaishankar held discussions with Marco Rubio earlier in the week, focusing on the broader implications of the conflict, particularly its impact on global markets and India's energy needs.

The MEA's clarification aims to put to rest speculation surrounding the high-level call, reiterating that sensitive diplomatic exchanges remain strictly between official representatives of Governments.

Oli's arrest sparks protests in Kathmandu

Oli's party, Communist Party of Nepal (Unified Marxist-Leninist), has strongly criticised the move, calling it politically motivated. Senior leaders within the party convened an emergency meeting and announced plans for nationwide protests, demanding his immediate release.

Tensions have been heightened by Nepal's recent political transition. Shah, a former rapper-turned-politician popularly known as "Balen," was sworn in as the country's youngest prime minister after leading the Rastriya Swatantra Party to a majority in the House of Representatives. He had earlier defeated Oli in the Jhapa-5 constituency during the general elections. Reacting to the developments, Prime Minister Narendra Modi congratulated Shah on his appointment and expressed optimism about strengthening ties between India and Nepal.

Meanwhile, political voices across the spectrum have weighed in on the arrest. UML leaders have described it as an act of "political revenge," while others, including Arjun Narsingha KC, have called for a fair and transparent investigation. Leaders such as Ganesh Shah emphasised adherence to due process, and Kamal Thapa cautioned against escalating tensions. With protests intensifying and legal proceedings underway, Nepal finds itself navigating a sensitive political moment amid a broader shift in its leadership landscape.

23-year Jewar journey now a reality

Modi acknowledged the severity of the global dis-

Over 3,000 *kanals* of Kashmiri Pandits’ land retrieved: Omar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

The Jammu and Kashmir Government on Saturday said it has retrieved and restored over 3,000 *kanals* of encroached land belonging to Kashmiri Pandits in the Valley.

Replying to a question by BJP MLA Yudhvir Sethi in the Assembly, Chief Minister Omar Abdullah said, “Land measuring 3,729 *kanals* and 4 *marlas* belonging to Kashmiri migrants has been retrieved and restored in the Kashmir Valley.”

Since November 2024, 844 *kanals* and 4 *marlas* of land belonging to Kashmiri Pandits have been retrieved and restored, Abdullah said.

Data indicates that land worth crores of rupees

belonging to Kashmiri Pandits, who were forced to flee due to targeted killings after the emergence of terrorism in J&K in 1990, was illegally occupied.

Abdullah, who oversees the Department of Disaster Management, Relief, Rehabilitation and Reconstruction, said the retrieval process is being carried out under the provisions of the Jammu and Kashmir Migrant Immovable Property (Preservation, Protection and Restraint on Distress Sales) Act.

The district administrations, led by deputy commissioners acting as custodians of migrant properties, have made efforts to restore land to the owners, he said.

Sharing district-wise details, Abdullah said land



J&K CM Omar Abdullah during the Budget session of the State Legislative Assembly in Jammu on Saturday PTI

has been restored in Shopian (283 *kanals*), Baramulla (225 *kanals*) and Ganderbal (146 *kanals*), among others, while smaller portions were

restored in Anantnag, Bandipora, Budgam, Kulgam, Kupwara, Pulwama and Srinagar districts.

Additional deputy com-

missioners have been designated as nodal officers for expeditious case disposal, while a steering committee constituted in January is overseeing implementation and streamlining the restoration process, the chief minister said.

Abdullah also said that an online grievance redressal portal is operational, with 10,173 applications received, of which 9,713 have been disposed of and 7,829 approved, with just 24 cases pending.

The chief minister said he has directed the deputy commissioners to register FIRs in encroachment cases, create geo-tagged inventories, ensure transparent property handover, and regularly update revenue records and monitor distress sales.

The administration has also planned outreach camps in Jammu from April 1 to April 28 for on-the-spot grievance redressal.

Tiger poisoned to death near Satpura Reserve in MP, 5 held

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bhopal

A radio-collared tiger was allegedly poisoned to death, following which five persons were arrested on Saturday, Madhya Pradesh police said.

The tiger’s body was found buried in a pit in West Chhindwara division revenue area on Friday, the official said.

lodged a formal complaint in the matter with Secretary, Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC), Member Secretary, National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA), Principal Secretary (Forest), MP, among others.

In his complaint, Dubey alleged that no movement was seen in the radio-collar monitor since March 3, but



“The tiger was brought from Bandhavgarh Tiger Reserve in Umaria in December 2004. It had formed its territory outside the reserve. Five persons have been arrested for poisoning the animal. They have been remanded in judicial custody,” STR field director Rakhi Nanda told PTI.

The accused, who laced tiger kill with poison, allegedly took this step as the big cat had killed their cattle, Nanda added.

The accused are also involved in illegal opium cultivation, the official said.

Meanwhile, wildlife activist Ajay Dubey on Saturday

the forest department ignored the development.

“The tigress was poisoned by poachers and her carcass was found buried in a pit in Sanga Kheda village area under Chhindwara South Forest Division. It is not merely a case of poaching, but a glaring example of administrative and monitoring failure,” Dubey said while seeking immediate intervention from higher authorities.

He also sought the removal of STR field director Nanda “for free and fair investigation into the glaring incident”.

A total of 14 tigers have died in MP since January this year, he pointed out.

Teamwork key to space missions: Astronaut Shukla

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Astronaut Shubhanshu Shukla, who is part of India’s Gaganyaan programme, on Saturday said that teamwork is the single most important factor in executing a space mission, as he briefly detailed his experience at the ISS and his journey to and from it.

Addressing students at the Government Model High School here, Shukla said he conducted several experiments on the International Space Station, including a study on rice seeds carried from Kerala.

He told the students that in space, everything floats, and the planet feels like



Indian astronaut and IAF Group Captain Shubhanshu Shukla taking a selfie with students during an event at a school in Kerala on Saturday PTI

home from up there.

Shukla, a Group Captain in the Indian Air Force and a test pilot, said he grew 5 to 6 centimetres while at the ISS, but upon returning to

Earth, his spine was “compressed” by gravity.

“When I came back, I found it very difficult to sit down. I couldn’t even walk a step. It took me about eight

days to clear medical check-ups,” he said.

Shukla said he was proud to have had the opportunity to represent India on an international platform.

He added that it is now his endeavour to ensure that more children from India get similar opportunities.

The astronaut said he wanted to share his journey and the lessons learned during his space mission.

“It is an endeavour to talk about the mission, explain the complexity of human space missions, and inspire the next generation to pursue these challenging careers, which will benefit both them and the country,” he told reporters outside the school.

Punjab to toughen sacrilege law; life sentence for ‘beadbi’ of Guru Granth Sahib: CM Mann

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Fatehgarh Sahib

Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Saturday said that the State will toughen the sacrilege law and anyone committing “*beadbi*” (sacrilege) of Guru Granth Sahib will face punishment up to life imprisonment.

The Mann Government will be convening a special session of the Vidhan Sabha on April 13 to amend the Jagat Jot Sri Guru Granth Sahib Satkar Act, 2008 for stricter punishment against sacrilege of Guru Granth Sahib and other religious texts.



Asserting a zero-tolerance stance, the Government said no one guilty of ‘beadbi’ (sacrilege) will be spared.

“On April 13, we will amend the ‘Beadbi’ law; anyone committing ‘*beadbi*’ of Sri Guru Granth Sahib will face 10 years to life imprisonment,” Mann said while addressing a gathering at an event here.

Mann launched a sharp attack on the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) over past ‘*beadbi*’ (sacrilege) incidents which took place during their Government’s time, while asserting that the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) Government is taking decisive steps to ensure justice by strengthening laws and enforcing strict punishment.

“They have forgotten these ‘beadbi’ incidents and

believe that people will forget them too, but people will not forget,” he said.

“On the occasion of Baisakhi, we have called a special Assembly session to amend the Jagat Jot Sri Guru Granth Sahib Satkar Act, 2008. Anyone attempting ‘*beadbi*’ will face the strictest punishment, with a minimum of 10 years and up to life imprisonment.

“No one should dare to disrespect Sri Guru Granth Sahib. We are also consulting the Sant Samaj.

This is something only we can and must do, and it cannot be expected from any other Government,” he said.

SC deprecates disclosure of identity of minor girl in rape case

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court has deprecated in “strongest terms” the disclosure of identity of a girl in a rape case and directed all high courts to ensure that names of survivors and their family members are not mentioned in court orders.

In its 2018 judgement in the Nipun Saxena case, the top court had said, “No person can print or publish in print, electronic, social media, etc. the name of the victim or even in a remote manner disclose any facts which can lead to the victim being identified and which should make her identity known to the public at large.”

A bench of Justices Sanjay

Karol and N Kotiswar Singh attributed lapses in following the ruling to the general indifference of the courts and “possibly even” the lack of awareness of the deep stigma that follows such offences.

The top court said that the legislature in 1983 introduced a provision to the IPC seeking to protect the identity of the victim of the offence under Section 376 Indian Penal Code.

The amendment, it said, was made apparently to address a specific mischief that emerged starkly from the way sexual offence cases were handled: the public disclosure of a survivor’s identity.

The bench thus directed that a copy of the judgment be sent to all the high court



registrars general. It also mentioned Section 228A of the Indian Penal Code, 1860, which prohibits the disclosure of the identity of victims of sexual offences, including rape, to prevent social stigma.

“This has been the long-standing position in law, but it has not been followed. The primary reason there amongst, one supposes, is the general indifference of the courts below and possibly even the lack of awareness of the deep stigma that follows such offences,” the bench said.

The observations came while setting aside an order of the Himachal Pradesh High Court, which reversed the conviction of a man in the rape of a nine-year-old girl, saying courts must not

give undue importance to minor discrepancies.

The top court said that before 1983, there was no statutory bar on publishing the name or particulars of a female sexual assault victim, alleged or proven, and court reporting and media coverage could expose survivors to social stigma, ostracism, and lifelong reputational harm.

“Clearly, the intent of this section has been given a miss in these proceedings. The name of the victim is treated like that of any other witness and is freely used throughout the record. This must be deprecated in the strongest terms. In fact, this court has noticed earlier also that the mandate of this provision is not being followed,” the bench said.

Nation Focus



Srinagar–Leh highway shut after avalanche strike

Avalanche-struck Srinagar–Leh National Highway was closed for traffic on Saturday as authorities cleared snow. Seven people were killed and several vehicles were buried in an avalanche on Friday at the Zojila Pass. A ten-year-old child was among those killed.

“The highway is closed for traffic, and snow clearance operations are underway,” officials said.

Traffic will be allowed once the road is cleared of avalanche debris, they added.

J-K police, army, CRPF, Ladakh Police, SDRF and civil administration are looking for the missing, they said.



Fire breaks out after Abhishek Banerjee rally in West Bengal

A fire broke out at a corner of a dais just after the completion of an election rally by senior TMC leader Abhishek Banerjee in West Bengal’s Birbhum district on Saturday, officials said. Banerjee and other leaders had come down from the podium in Labhpur and were on their way out of the venue when flames were seen emanating from one of the pillars of the stage, they said.

Adani Defence delivers first batch of 2,000 Prahar light machine guns

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Gwalior

In a boost to the Army’s firepower, a defence major on Saturday delivered the first batch of 2,000 ‘Prahar’ light machine guns (LMGs) manufactured under the ‘Make in India’ initiative.

The 7.62 mm-calibre weapon has been manufactured by Adani Defence and Aerospace at its Small Arms Complex located on the out-

Defence and Aerospace, and other senior officials of the company.

Anbarasu and others later flagged off a series of trucks carrying the first batch of the LMGs.

Interacting with reporters after the flag-off, Rajvanshi said, “The journey that has begun today took us six years, starting from bid submission, and we have delivered the first batch, 11 months ahead of schedule.”



skirts of Gwalior.

With India seeking to maintain robust defence deployment along its borders, particularly the Line of Actual Control (LAC) and the Line of Control (LoC), the new weaponry will further enhance the Army’s firepower and its overall operational capability.

‘Prahar’ has a barrel length of 508 mm (20 inches), while the light machine gun weighs 8 kg and is 1,100 mm long. It has an effective range of 1,000 m, according to data shared by a spokesperson of the private firm.

A ceremony was held on the premises of the Gwalior facility on Saturday to hand over the LMGs to the Army, which was attended by A Anbarasu, DG Acquisition, Ministry of Defence, Ashish Rajvanshi, CEO of Adani

“The original timeline (for complete delivery), which was given to us by the customer, was over seven years, but I can assure you that in the next three years, the full order will be delivered,” he added.

The company spokesperson said the total order for the LMGs stands at around 40,000.

Anbarasu, in his address at the event, praised the firm for saving several months by delivering ahead of schedule, and said it shows there is the ability to “race and fire” against time in turning contracts into deliveries.

He said the Government stands shoulder-to-shoulder with its defence industry partners, asserting that “scale” and “speed” are the twin pillars of defence acquisition that guide the entire procurement process.

Loco pilots’ union holds mass protest, convention for adequate allowances, rest

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

All India Loco Running Staff Association held a day-long protest, followed by a Rights Proclamation Convention on Saturday to press for their demands, including enhancement of the income tax exemption ceiling on running allowances and limit on outstation duty, along with adequate rest, among many others.

The Union members, during the protest on Friday, said that 70 per cent of their running allowance falls under income tax exemption,

subject to a ceiling of ₹10,000 per month fixed in 2010.

They added that running allowance rates were revised multiple times between 2012 and 2024, resulting in a three-fold increase; however, the exemption ceiling stays at ₹10,000.

“This has resulted in substantial financial loss to the running staff. Employees of equivalent rank engaged in office work receive a travelling allowance, which has been increased from ₹300 to ₹1000 per day over the years. As the exemption ceiling on TA has been revised, we also demand relief on similar

lines. It must be revised to ₹30,000 per month,” KC James, Secretary General, All India Loco Running Staff Association (AILRSA), said.

The Association has welcomed the Railway Ministry’s recent decision to revise Running Allowance rates after 2.5 years.

However, it Stated that the Ministry didn’t do full justice as there are anomalies in the Kilometrage Allowance rates.

The Association also sought revision of other benefits, such as allowance for running room facilities, shunting duty and trip.



In a day-long convention, attended by Rajya Sabha MP John Brittas and the eminent human rights lawyer Colin Gonsalves, among others, the Association raised issues related to daily working hours and adequate weekly rest.

“The Railway Ministry should ensure 16 hours of headquarters rest along with 30 hours of periodical rest, limit continuous night duties to two, restrict maximum duty hours to 8 hours per day and also limit outstation duty to 36 hours,” James said.

The union officer bearers

Stated that the arduous nature of running staff duties was recognised by the Rajadhyaksha Committee (1947) and reaffirmed by the High Power Committee (2012).

“Despite this, loco pilots are denied 16 hours of daily rest along with weekly rest, even after directions from statutory authorities (Labour Commissioner) and the Hon’ble High Courts,” James said.

He added that loco pilots are subjected to duty hours extending up to 12 hours, and often beyond that.

“They are compelled to

work four continuous night duties, despite safety recommendations limiting it to two and are detained at outstations for more than three days, unlike other categories of staff,” James complained.

The union maintained that over a period of time, various factors such as longer trains (over 3.5 km), dense traffic on parallel tracks and increased signalling have significantly increased their workload.

Additionally, duties of other departments, such as train examination, engineering, and traffic, are increasingly being shifted to the running staff, they claimed.



States Focus



VETERAN PUNJAB CONGRESS LEADER LAL SINGH DIES AT 84

Veteran Congress leader and former Punjab Minister Lal Singh passed away on Saturday, according to family sources. Known as the “Bhishma Pitamah” of the Punjab Congress, the 84-year-old leader breathed his last at a private hospital in Mohali, they said. He complained of breathing difficulties at his Chandigarh residence earlier in the day and was rushed to a hospital, where he died, they said. A towering figure in Punjab politics, his career spanned nearly five decades. In the 1990s, he emerged as a powerful and influential minister in the Cabinet of the then Chief Minister Beant Singh, playing a key role in governance during a transformative period in the State’s history.



143 BORDER VILLAGES TO GET BETTER INFRA: MANIPUR CM

Manipur Chief Minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh on Saturday said that infrastructure, connectivity and service delivery will be improved in 143 border villages in the State under the Centre’s Vibrant Villages Programme-II. Singh was addressing a gathering during a day-long State-level workshop here on the scheme. The CM said the Vibrant Villages Programme-II is a central initiative for the development of villages along international borders.

PM Modi to interact with NDA workers of Assam, Puducherry on March 30



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will virtually interact with NDA workers of Assam and Puducherry on Monday as part of the ‘Mera Booth, Sabse Mazboot Samvaad’ initiative aiming to give messages directly to them ahead of Assembly elections there. Modi said people of Assam and Puducherry are going to bless the NDA Governments again in the State and the Union Territory (UT) respectively. Assembly elections in Assam and Puducherry will be held on April 9. “Assam’s progress in the last decade is for everyone to see. The State is known for its developmental strides across sectors. “That is why, Assam is clear — it’s NDA all the way. People are all set for five more years of the double-engine NDA Government,” Modi said.

CEO, ECI officials colluding with CPI(M), Govt over seal row, alleges Kerala BJP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Thiruvananthapuram

BJP’s Kerala unit on Saturday alleged that Election Commission of India (ECI) officials, including the State Chief Electoral Officer (CEO), were colluding with the Government and the ruling CPI(M) to “undermine” free and fair polls in the State. Addressing a press conference here, BJP Kerala State general secretary S Suresh referred to a recent row in which a BJP seal was found on a document issued by the ECI to political parties, leading to the suspension of an official. Suresh identified the suspended officer as Jaisal B Aziz, alleging that he is associated with an NGO union in the State secretariat. He claimed that the officer, who had recently joined the service, was deputed to the ECI due to his alleged links with organisations such as the Democratic Youth Federation of India and the



BJP State president Rajeev Chandrasekhar during roadshow

FILE PHOTO

Students’ Federation of India. “The BJP is concerned and suspects that ECI officials, including the Chief Electoral Officer, have become part of a ploy by the State Government and the CPI(M) to derail free and fair elections in the State,” Suresh said. Suresh alleged that recent developments indicate a conspiracy against his party and that there was a “deal”

DMK to contest in 164 out of 234 seats in Tamil Nadu

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Chennai

The ruling DMK on Saturday named its candidates for 164 constituencies for the April 23 Assembly polls, renominating Chief Minister MK Stalin and his son and deputy Udhayanidhi from their existing city seats and setting up a direct fight with archrival AIADMK in a number of constituencies.

Winding up days of seat-sharing talks with allies, including Congress and Left, the DMK identified the constituencies for them. Minutes later, at a press conference at DMK headquarters Anna Arivalayam, Stalin released the names of 164 candidates of his party.

Stalin denied any “delay” in seat-sharing parleys, saying the “patient discussions” have ensured everybody is satisfied. Also, he was making efforts to ensure unity in the bloc.

AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami has been mocking the DMK, claiming it suffered from delay in seat-sharing talks, claiming that his party has taken the lead and got on to the campaign mode by finalising everything.

Besides DMK’s 164 seats, 11 alliance party candidates, including those from Vaiko-led MDMK, will contest on the ruling party’s Rising Sun symbol, effectively making it 175 constituencies for the party. Election to 234 Assembly seats in the State will be held on April 23.

On Saturday, Stalin retained all but three of his 33 cabinet colleagues and some senior MLAs. He fielded over



Tamil Nadu CM and DMK President MK Stalin, addressing a press conference announcing the party’s candidates for the upcoming State Assembly elections at the party’s headquarters Anna Arivalayam in Chennai on Saturday

PTI

60 persons for their maiden electoral battle, even as the candidates’ composition included doctors, engineers and PhD holders. Besides, 18 women are in fray on behalf of the ruling party.

Stalin, the ruling DMK president, said he would contest once again from Kolathur. Udhayanidhi is seeking re-election from Chepauk-Triplicane, also in the city.

Ministers Durai Murugan (DMK general secretary), KN Nehru, Anbil Mahesh Poyyamozhi, Thangam Thennarasu, Ma Subramanian, and EV Velu have been retained. Interestingly, expelled AIADMK leader O Panneerselvam, who recently joined DMK, has been fielded from Bodinayakanur, the seat he represented in the outgoing Assembly. He had resigned as MLA after joining DMK.

Two of Panneerselvam’s colleagues, Paul Manoj Pandian and R Vaithilingam, who had joined the DMK earlier, have also been given poll tickets.

Another interesting move is

shifting former Electricity minister V Senthil Balaji from his stronghold Karur to Coimbatore South. The move is seen as a strategic shift by the DMK to strengthen itself in Coimbatore and surrounding regions that are generally a bastion of the AIADMK. The AIADMK is in the fray in this city segment, currently represented by BJP Mahila Morcha chief Vanathi Srinivasan.

Earlier in the day, DMK completed the seat-sharing process with its allies, identifying the constituencies to be contested by the Congress, Left parties, VCK and DMDK, among others. DMK leads the Secular Progressive Alliance (SPA) in the State.

Principal ally Congress’ 28 seats include Ponneri, Erode East, Vilavankode, Sivakasi and Karaikudi.

DMDK, led by Premalatha Vijayakanth has been allotted 10 seats, and they include Vriddhachalam and Pallavaram. Vriddhachalam was represented by the party founder, late Vijayakanth, in the past.

Siddaramaiah reiterates high command’s call on CM post

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mysuru (Karnataka)

Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah on Saturday reiterated that the Congress high command’s decision will be final on his continuation in office, and said he would present two more State budgets if permitted.

Expressing confidence that the Congress will win both Assembly bypolls in the State, he said their outcome has no bearing on his tenure as the CM.

“We will win the bypolls in both constituencies. I will begin campaigning on March 30. On March 30–31, I will be in Bagalkot; April 1–2 in Davanagere South; April 3–4 again in Bagalkot. I will go to Kerala for campaigning on April 5, and on April 6, either Bagalkot or Davanagere South,” Siddaramaiah told reporters in response to a question.

When asked whether the bypoll results could be seen as a verdict on his Government’s 2.5 years in office, he said Congress would win both the bypolls and the 2028 Assembly elections in the State.

“In earlier by-elections to three seats (Sandur, Shiggaon and Channapatta in November 2024), the Opposition BJP-JD(S) lost all of them. They earlier held two of those seats. Wasn’t that a signal that people want Congress? The polls are yet to be held, and the results are yet to come. In any election, Congress will certainly win. We will also win in 2028,” he said.

Asked whether the bypoll

results would put an end to speculation about a change in CM, Siddaramaiah said the two issues were unrelated.

On his recent remark that he would present two more budgets if permitted by the high command, he said, “Let them give permission; we will see. Ours is a high command party, and everyone should abide by its decisions.”

Siddaramaiah, who also holds the Finance portfolio, presented his record 17th Budget on March 6.

Speculation over a leadership change within the ruling party has intensified after the Congress Government completed the halfway mark of its five-year term on November 20, 2025.

The buzz has been fuelled by a reported power-sharing arrangement between Siddaramaiah and Deputy Chief Minister DK Shivakumar at the time of Government formation in 2023.

Bypolls to the Bagalkot and Davanagere South Assembly constituencies will be held on April 9.

The elections were

necessitated following the deaths of senior Congress MLAs HY Meti and Shamanur Shivashankarappa, respectively. The CM also said there was no dissent in the Davanagere South party unit and that all issues had been resolved.

He said Sadiq Pailwan, who had entered the fray as a rebel candidate, had “retired” from the contest.

Siddaramaiah also defended the Government’s decision to replace the marks system for the third language in the SSLC (Class 10) examination with a grading system that will not affect a student’s overall result, from the current academic year.

“No decision has been taken on a two-language policy in education. What we have decided is that the third language, such as Hindi, should not be compulsory for marks,” he said.

“Earlier, exams were for a total of 625 marks, including 100 marks for the third language. Following this decision, the total will be 525 marks from this academic year,” he added.



Leaders across parties seek probe into Farooq Abdullah attack

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

Cutting across party lines, several legislators on Saturday demanded a judicial probe by a sitting High Court judge to unravel the plot behind targeting Farooq Abdullah at a marriage function in Jammu on March 11, 2026.

88-year-old Dr Abdullah had a miraculous escape at a marriage function when a 63-year-old resident from the walled city area of Jammu attempted to assassinate him from a very close range. The attacker was overpowered and arrested with a revolver. Police have constituted a special

investigation team (SIT) under the supervision of a deputy inspector general of Police (DIG) to probe the attack.

Meanwhile, members belonging to both the treasury and Opposition benches voiced serious concerns during the discussion, highlighting the absence of adequate security arrangements at the venue.

Demanding accountability to be fixed by the UT administration, several legislators questioned how an attacker managed to come dangerously close to 88-year-old Abdullah after sneaking inside the venue with a pistol.



Jammu and Kashmir National Conference MLAs during the Budget session of the State Legislative Assembly in Jammu on Saturday

PTI

Winding up a two-hour-long discussion, speaker Abdul Rahim Rather said Home Minister Amit Shah and J&K Lt Governor Manoj Sinha had interacted with Abdullah following the incident and expressed confidence that the investigation would be taken to its logical conclusion, with the culprit receiving exemplary punishment. “What we have discussed today must be strongly conveyed and amplified. Those responsible for law and order must clearly understand that this is not an ordinary incident; it is a serious matter connected to broader concerns. Abdullah is not an ordinary indi-

vidual; he is a nationally and internationally recognised personality who has served the country during difficult times,” Rather said.

He said the House had collectively expressed concern and assured that the matter would be pursued and that necessary steps should be taken to prevent recurrence.

“There are also concerns about the conduct and mindset of the individual involved. Reports suggest that he showed no remorse and behaved in a manner that indicates deeper issues, which need thorough investigation,” the speaker said.

Kharge to release Congress’s Assam polls manifesto

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Guwahati

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge will on Sunday release the party’s manifesto for the April 9 Assam Assembly elections, AICC general secretary Jitendra Singh said.

The manifesto is based on several months of work, during which our leaders and members reached out to people across the State, Singh, who is the All India Congress Committee (AICC) in-charge of Assam, said at a press conference here.

“The manifesto will be released by Kharge ji in Lakhimpur,” he added.

The Congress chief is scheduled to visit Lakhimpur district on Sunday and address an election campaign meeting.

Singh also took a swipe at the BJP-led State Government and said, “People are in fear everywhere. If someone is to even make a social media post critical of the Government, the police will reach their doorsteps before the end of the day.”

“Media showing corruption of the Government



is being threatened,” he claimed.

Hitting out at Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, the Congress leader said, “We have seen that

whenever he is speaking to the media, he focusses more on our party than his own BJP. I suggest that he also takes a look within, as the BJP has already been divided

into two camps — one is the BJP (Himanta Biswa Sarma faction) and the other, the ‘original’ BJP.”

Singh also claimed that senior BJP leaders like former CM and Union Minister Sarbananda Sonowal have been sidelined within the BJP.

He asserted that the Congress-led Opposition will sweep to power in the State.

Elections to the 126-member Assembly will be held on April 9, and votes will be counted on May 4.

The Congress has been out of power in the State since 2016.

NDA will win over 90 seats in Assam, says Amit Shah

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Saturday asserted that the BJP-led NDA will return to power in Assam for the third consecutive term by winning more than 90 seats in the 126-member Assembly. Shah made the statement as he kick-started his two-day visit to the poll-bound State with a roadshow in Guwahati.

“The people of Assam are excited to form the BJP and NDA Government in the State. We will form the Government again with more than 90 seats,” he said.

Shah said that under the leadership of PM Narendra Modi and Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, world-class infrastructure has been built in the State.

“In Assam, extremism, bomb blasts, and firing have stopped. Health infrastructure is being developed here. The State has become the hub of health and education in the entire

Northeast,” he said.

Shah said huge employment opportunities have been created, and modern industries like semiconductor manufacturing units are being set up.

Union Home Minister held the roadshow in support of Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, who is fighting the polls from the Jalukbari seat, Guwahati Central candidate Vijay Kumar Gupta, New Guwahati’s Dipu Ranjan Sarma, Dispur’s Pradyut Bordoloi, and AGP’s Dimoria nominee Tapan Das.

Except for Sarma, all candidates accompanied Shah during the roadshow, which was also attended by State BJP president Dilip Saikia. The roadshow began from the Arya Vidyapeeth College playground and concluded at the Nepali Mandir, covering around 2 km along the AK Azad Road. Polling is scheduled to be held on April 9, while the votes would be counted on May 4.



Union Home Minister Amit Shah at a road show in Guwahati on Saturday

PIONEER PHOTO

PROSPECT

PESB recommends Ashok K Panda for CMD post at SAIL



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Government head-hunter PESB has recommended Ashok Kumar Panda, Director (Finance) of SAIL, for the top post at India's largest public-sector steel-making entity. Panda was among the 10 shortlisted candidates interviewed for the post of Chairman and Managing Director (CMD) at Steel Authority of India Ltd (SAIL).

The top post will fall vacant after the term of the present CMD, Amarendu Prakash, ends on April 2, 2026. Prakash assumed the charge of SAIL Chairman on May 31, 2023.

In a notification dated March 28, the Public Enterprises Selection Board (PESB) said it has recommended Ashok Kumar Panda for the post of CMD SAIL. Panda currently holds the post of Director, Finance, in the company.

The Appointments Committee of the Cabinet (ACC), headed by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, is the final authority approving appointments to top-level positions at central PSUs.

Along with Panda,

several other senior SAIL employees appeared before the PESB for the interview.

Manish Raj Gupta, Director Mining at SAIL, Alok Verma, Director In Charge of SAIL's Rourkela Steel Plant, Bipin Kumar Giri, ED Mines Development and Anish Sengupta ED Projects were also interviewed for the post.

Besides, Krishna Gopal Agarwal, Director Finance at Rites, Anup Kumar Satpathy of South East Central Railway, Pui Hari Prasad and Chetan Prakash Jain were also interviewed.

PESB invited applications for the SAIL CMD post in the first week of February.

Panda is a seasoned finance professional with over three decades of experience in accounting, costing & budgeting, Annual Business Planning, Project Commercial Activities, Treasury Operations, superannuation trusts, Taxation and Strategic Management.

He started his career with SAIL as a Management Trainee after completing his BE in Electrical Engineering.



SANJAY LAZAR

"There is no such thing as a free lunch" a top airline executive told me yesterday, when we chatted about the DGCA's new diktat about '60% free seating on board'. It's the first time in a long time that I found myself agreeing with the DGCA and MoCA, whom I have otherwise been critical of.

The airline body, the Federation of Indian Airlines has written to the Government on behalf of all airlines to protest this, however, they are strangely absent and silent when it comes to passenger complaints against Airlines or abuse of dominance or high passenger fares.

There is no doubt that the FIA have some deep pain points, against the Government, like rampant taxation, varying ATF, lease costs etc and they need to resolve it with Government; but to flay passengers for it, is not the way forward. The Indigo crisis and its aftermath have shown that passengers have had enough. The reason why consumers have not supported Airlines against the Government, is that they feel hard done by the Airlines at every step.

Black swan & profits

"Why are you supporting this?" he asked me, and my mind rushed back to Covid in 2020 & 2021, Diwali of 2024, Russia-Ukraine war, 737 Max grounding, P & W groundings, Revenge travel surge pricing, the AI-171 tragedy and the Indigo crisis of 2025, the current Iran war, and other Black Swan events during the last 8 years. Sadly, the airline industry, of which I am a part, has not covered itself in glory, often swooping down to flay the poor passenger, reaping windfalls in last minute fare hikes and surcharges over the past 7 years. In some rare cases, fares going up to as high as 10x during the Indigo crisis and 4x during the AI-171 tragedy. Talking about Covid lockdown airfares, is too long and too painful for far too many people.

However, as if to counter balance the blow on FIA and its members, the DGCA also issued an order on March 20 lifting the fare-caps which were earlier imposed at the peak of the Indigo crisis. The irony would not be lost on Indian travelers, that caps introduced during a domestic crisis are being lifted at the peak of the Iran war, a global oil crisis the likes of which we have never seen since the 1970s rationing of oil, when some readers were not born.

Questions will be asked-whether this was the correct time to lift the fare caps? Or even whether the DGCA could have waited until the war ended? Moreover, was this the appropriate time to direct the "60% free seat selec-

AIRLINE	BASIC AVL	FARE	PAID SEATS	FREE SEATS	REMARKS
UNITED	BASIC		YES	YES	SEATS SELECTION IS FREE 24 HOURS BEFORE DEPARTURE
BRITISH AIRWAYS	BASIC		YES	YES	SEATS SELECTION IS FREE 24 HOURS BEFORE DEPARTURE
EMIRATES	BASIC		YES	YES	SEATS SELECTION IS FREE 48 HOURS BEFORE DEPARTURE
AIR FRANCE	LIGHT FARE		YES	YES	SEAT SELECTION IS PERMITTED FREE 30 HOURS BEFORE DEPARTURE EXCEPT FOR LIGHT FARES
AIR CANADA	LIGHT FARE		YES	YES	SEAT SELECTION IS PERMITTED FREE 24 HOURS BEFORE DEPARTURES
RYAN AIR	BASIC FARE		YES	YES	PREMIUM SEATS ARE CHARGED, BUT OFFERS RANDOM FREE SEAT ASSIGNMENT, 24 HOURS BEFORE DEPARTURES
LUFTHANSA	ECONOMY LIGHT		YES	YES	SEAT SELECTION IS CHARGED FOR ECONOMY LIGHT
SOUTHWEST			FREE SEATING UNTIL 2025	YES	50 YEARS OF FREE SEATING, NOW CHARGES FOR PREMIUM SEATING. ROWS 17 THRU 30 (14 ROWS) ARE FREE SEATING EVEN NOW [43% FREE]
EASYJET	STANDARD FARE		YES	YES	PREFERRED SEATING CHARGEABLE. CHECK-IN 30 DAYS PRIOR. RANDOM FREE SEATING AVAILABLE TO OTHERS ON CHECK IN.

tions" when airlines face an existential crisis?

Cold dark summer

The world is facing a grave threat, as if to add, Airlines are facing the prospects of a bleak summer of international travel, a cutback in operations, reduction in routes, burgeoning ATF fuel hikes and even possible layoffs. The Air India CEO has gone on record stating that they are operating 30% of the normal Middle East capacity. In our estimates, the aviation market will take a hit of at least 3-5% points on growth in the next two quarters, and operational costs are expected to rise at least 12%-16% more on an average with fuel, routes, layovers and landings. The Customer confidence has been dented and unless this war ends now, it will be a dry summer, and we will have to wait until Diwali before the green shoots of traffic recovery appear.

Supreme Court pil

Many missed the Public Interest litigation filed by S Laxminaryanan before the Supreme Court, seeking regulatory guidelines against sharp fare hikes and ancillary charges by Airlines, though it was detailed in the media. On 23/2/26, the bench granted the Centre four weeks' time to complete its deliberations and inform the Supreme court. The PIL sought judicial intervention, because of the States inaction in protecting the consumer. The MoCA & DGCA's actions were as a consequence of the Supreme Courts dicer, thus the FIA's plea of a HC order on lack of jurisdiction over ancillary charges, in my view, does not hold much water anymore. I would be surprised if any airlines had even impleaded themselves in that PIL, (though they may have lawyers observing) it would perhaps be worth the FIAs while to intervene in the matter.

Global practices

In order to gauge global practices, we surveyed many world airlines, FSC & LLCs and were surprised to find that many of them permitted free seat selection 24 hours prior. (See Table) Even Southwest the big daddy of global Low-Cost Carriers did not charge for seat

selection for 50 years until 2025, and was still hugely profitable. In 2025 they brought in paid seating, but still maintained 14 rows of seats as free seats for passengers on their aircraft.

The US Congressional committee completed an investigation in 2024/2025 on how the US aviation market had been overtaken by "Junk Fees" in American air travel, and how it was affecting the markets.

The committee investigated the Big 5 over two years, and made some findings that (1) The Big 5 are making more money from seat fees than ever before (\$12.4 Billion between 2018-2023) [This is despite allowing free seat selection 24 hours in advance] (2) The price of ancillary fees is not tied to each airline's cost of providing a service (3) The five airlines increasingly rely on algorithms to set the price of ancillary fees and they harvest customer data to determine their prices.

The recommendations of the Congressional Committee were (a) Congress should require airlines to provide more granular fee data to the DOT (b) strengthen fee disclosure requirements (c) The Department of Transportation should investigate potential abuses in the use of incentive-based collection of ancillary fees, (d) DOT should prohibit unfair and deceptive practices, and assess civil penalties if appropriate (e) The Department of the Treasury should examine whether current airline ancillary fee practices comply with rules about applying the transportation tax

Airfare deregulation in India began in 1994 and since then airfares have risen time and time again, every Oil / ATF price hike have made a new benchmark platform for fares. The unbundling of air fares began in 2007, with the advent of the LLCs in India, the DGCA allowed the gradual unbundling of fares and ancillary services.

The preferred seating modules entered Indian aviation as a norm by 2011/12, and DGCA's first guidelines on Seat selection came about in 2015, and then expanded into the drip pricing framework where everything else was part of revenue generation.

Circular no 3/2015 set out the framework

for ancillary seat revenue allocation, with an "opt-in" model and "regulatory oversight".

The DGCA did not cap seat selection prices, and therein perhaps lies the source of angst on all sides, passenger, Government and airlines. The DGCA in its wisdom retained the power to step in in case the charges were non-transparent, discriminatory and unfair, as they have appeared to have become in recent times. There are cases where the seat selection costs vary from ₹350 to ₹2000 on a ₹6000 fare, almost 20% of basic fare, which is absurd. The new norm of 60% free seats, is just the DGCA reverting its earlier permission, partially, that too on a suggestion of the apex court.

Price cap or seat cap ?

Has the time has come for the capping of seat selection? or is an overall fare cap required?

In our opinion, airlines must be free to charge their own fares, in the pursuit of profit, given the tough markets they operate within, however there has to be a bandwidth within which this freedom operates. Airlines & FIA have failed to self-regulate themselves, there needs to be a monitor or an Aviation Ombudsman, who will protect both Airline and passenger. India is a nation where the air passenger charter is not worth the paper it is written on, when compared to the EU - 261/2004 or the UK-261 rules, and there has been no Passenger body who has taken up cudgels on behalf of the passengers in the country, before the Government or the courts, most of them are self-serving groups. Passengers have to fight their own battles or rely on lone-wolf PILs. The time has come to restructure the passenger charter and the reframe the DGCA as an independent CAA style regulator.

The way forward

The way forward to resolve the "Free Seat" deadlock, is possibly reach a middle ground of 50% of seats for free and the balance to be charged, subject to 24 hours before the flight, where it must be open to all passengers to choose their seats.

There should be a cap on percentage of basic fare that can be charged as a "seat selection fare" which should not exceed 10% of the fare. The threat of fare hikes by the FIA will be counter-productive, since it could result in a three way face off with the Government, the Judiciary and the Regulator.

The consumer is the goose that lays the golden eggs, and the Airlines and Government must realise it and handle them with care. No corporate is running an airline for charity, yet airline operators bear the biggest burden to not only act responsibly, but seen to be acting transparently and fairly. It is after all, the ultimate customer facing hospitality industry.

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BYD India opens country's largest showroom in Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Bolstering its footprint in the national Capital's burgeoning Electric Vehicle (EV) market, BYD India, the world's leading manufacturer of New Energy Vehicles (NEVs), inaugurated its 48th national showroom in Moti Nagar on Friday. Launched in partnership with PPS Motors Pvt Ltd, the facility stands as the largest BYD showroom in India to date.

The expansive 9,000 sq ft outlet marks the brand's sixth touchpoint in the Delhi-NCR region. The facility is designed to house up to seven vehicles, offering an immersive retail experience where customers can engage with the brand's



latest sustainable mobility innovations and design philosophy.

Speaking at the inauguration, Rajeev Chauhan, Head of Electric Passenger Vehicles Business, BYD India, noted

that Delhi-NCR remains one of the most dynamic EV markets in the country. "The inauguration represents another important milestone in strengthening BYD India's retail footprint.

Supported by increasing consumer awareness, we look forward to contributing to India's transition towards cleaner transportation," he said.

With this launch, BYD India's network now spans 40 cities. The company's current Indian portfolio features a diverse range of premium electric offerings, including the BYD SEALION 7, the SEAL premium sedan, the ATTO 3 eSUV, and the eMAX 7 eMPV. Rajiv Sanghvi, Managing Director of PPS Motors Pvt Ltd, emphasised the strategic importance of the partnership.

"As the largest sales and after-sales partners for BYD with 10 touchpoints across India, this facility reflects our shared commitment to

accelerating EV adoption. We endeavour to provide a premium and seamless ownership experience for customers in the Delhi region," Sanghvi stated.

Globally, BYD continues to dominate the green energy sector, having sold over 15 million NEVs as of early 2026.

The company's environmental impact is estimated at a reduction of over 129 billion kilograms of carbon dioxide emissions, a feat equivalent to the carbon sequestration of approximately 2.14 billion trees.

The expansion comes at a time when BYD is rapidly climbing global rankings, recently securing the 91st spot in the 2025 Fortune Global 500 with a brand valuation of \$14.4 billion.

Fountainhead school expands in Surat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

Fountainhead School has marked a major milestone with the launch of its second campus, Fountainhead School Malgama (FSM), bringing its signature approach to holistic education closer to the city. Deputy Chief Minister Harshbhai Sanghavi led the ceremony as the Chief Guest alongside prominent dignitaries, education leaders, and members of the Fountainhead community. The foundation stone for the new campus was laid during a Bhumi Pujan (foundation stone laying) ceremony held on March 26, accompanied by a traditional Shanti Yagna to invoke blessings for a positive and auspicious beginning. The upcoming campus is in Malgama village, near Bhesan Village, just 16 minutes from Magdalla junction — making it more accessible for families across Surat.

Established in 2008, Fountainhead School has been a pioneer in introducing the International Baccalaureate (IB) curriculum in Surat. Known for its focus on inquiry-



based learning and student-centric education, the school has built a reputation for strong academic outcomes and excellent university placements.

The upcoming Malgama campus, scheduled to open in June 2027, promises to further enhance the educational experience. It will feature state-of-the-art infrastructure, modern learning environments designed for the 21st century, advanced sports facilities, and dedicated makerspaces. The campus is envisioned as a dynamic hub where students can explore, innovate, and engage with real-world challenges.

Ashwa Sparsh – healing through horses



TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Assam R&V Sqn NCC, under the aegis of NCC Group Headquarters, Guwahati, NER Directorate, successfully conducted Ashwa Sparsh, a unique initiative aimed at empowering specially-abled children through interaction with horses at the Veterinary Field, Khanapara.

The programme brought together specially-abled children from Asha School, Narangi Military Station, providing them an opportunity to experience the therapeutic and emotional benefits of equine interaction in a safe and encouraging environment.

Meaning "the healing touch of horses," Ashwa Sparsh is designed to promote confidence, emotional well-being, sensory development and social inclusion among children with special needs.

The event commenced with a welcome address by the Officer Commanding, 47 Assam R&V Sqn NCC, followed by an engaging entertainment session featuring horse show jumping, a jalebi race on horseback, and a bucket-and-ball race performed by NCC cadets from the College of Veterinary Science, Khanapara.

Subsequently, the children participated in assisted horse



riding, grooming activities and feeding of horses under the guidance and supervision of experienced PI staff and NCC cadets. The R&V NCC cadets actively volunteered as side walkers and facilitators, exemplifying the core values of service, empathy and community engagement, while also developing leadership qualities and a deeper sense of social responsibility.

The event was graced by Brigadier NC Khumman, Group Commander, NCC Group Headquarters, Guwahati, who highlighted that the programme embodies the true spirit of NCC by combining discipline with compassion and contributing

to nation-building through community outreach.

Parents and caregivers expressed their appreciation for the initiative, noting visible joy and increased confidence among the participating children.

47 Assam R&V Sqn NCC plans to conduct Ashwa Sparsh as a regular outreach activity to strengthen bonds between the armed forces community and society, while promoting inclusive opportunities for all.

The event concluded with the distribution of gift hampers to the children and an interactive session between cadets, instructors and participating families.

Consensus, MFN, special and differential treatment in WTO key for global trade balance: Piyush Goyal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

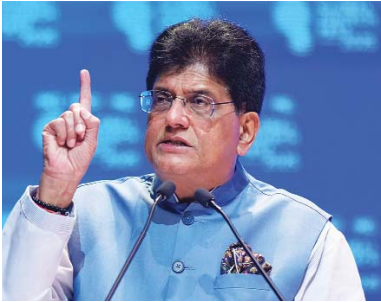
Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal on Saturday said consensus-based decision-making, Most Favoured Nation (MFN) rule-based trade, and special and differential treatment in the WTO are key to ensuring balance in global trade.

He also emphasised the need to uphold the World Trade Organisation's (WTO) foundational principles.

The minister stated this during his meeting with WTO Reform Minister-Facilitators Espen Barth Eide, Norway's Minister of Foreign Affairs and Chris Bryant, UK Minister of State for Trade Policy, on the margins of the ongoing 14th ministerial conference of the WTO at Yaounde in Cameroon.

"Reiterated India's full support for a reformed, relevant, and effective WTO. Emphasised the need to uphold the organisation's foundational principles, particularly consensus-based decision-making, MFN rule based trade, and Special and Differential Treatment, which are essential to ensuring equity and balance in global trade," Goyal said in a social media post.

The four-day ministerial conference (MC) will end on March 29. The MC is the



highest decision-making body, which meets once every two years.

WTO is a 166-member Geneva-based body which deals with global trade related issues. It also adjudicates disputes between the member countries. India is a member since 1995.

WTO reform is a key agenda being pushed by developed countries, particularly the US. India is supporting this but has stated that the core principle of the organisation should not be diluted. The WTO is run by its member Governments. All major decisions are made by the membership as a whole, either by ministers (who meet at least once every two years) or by their ambassadors or delegates (who meet regularly in Geneva). Decisions are normally taken by consensus.

The US is pushing for World reforms and has raised issues with regard to consensus-based decision making process. It has argued that this process slows down decision making. However, developing economies, including India, is of the view that it ensures equal voices to all members.

The most favoured nation (MFN) principle states that all member countries should be treated equally. Under the WTO agreements, member countries cannot normally discriminate between their trading partners. If a nation extends lower import duty benefits to one of its trading partners, that rate has to be granted to others also. Exceptions are allowed only under free trade agreement.

Special and differential treatment (S&DT) allows developing and poor (less developed) countries to enjoy certain benefits, including taking longer time for implementing agreements and binding commitments, and measures to increase trading opportunities for them. Currently, any WTO member can designate itself as a developing country and avail these benefits. Some developed nations have stated that self-declaration puts the WTO on a path to failed negotiations and it is also a path to institutional irrelevance.

FROM THE
WORLD

PAKISTAN

Militants held with arms

Law enforcement agencies in the past one month have arrested 36 militants belonging to various terrorist organisations in the Punjab province of Pakistan, a statement said on Saturday. Punjab Counter Terrorism Department (CTD) in a statement said the arrested terrorists, including those from the banned militant group Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP), planned to target important buildings in different cities of the province. "Major terror plots were averted in Faisalabad and Jhelum as two dangerous terrorists of Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan were arrested with heavy explosive material and weapons," the statement said. It said the CTD conducted 366 operations in different districts, questioned 338 suspects, and arrested 36 terrorists along with weapons, explosives.

US

Rubio denies Zelenskyy claim

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio rejected Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy's assertion that the Trump administration is demanding Kyiv hand over its eastern Donbas region to Russia to receive American security guarantees in any ceasefire plan. Speaking to reporters following a Group of Seven meeting in France, Rubio disputed Zelenskyy's recent comments and said the US has made no such stipulation in its talks with Ukraine. "That's a lie," Rubio said. "And I saw him say that. And it's unfortunate he would say that because he knows that's not true and that's not what he was told." In an interview published this week, Zelenskyy told Reuters the US was making its offer of security guarantees for Ukraine contingent on the ceding of the Donbas region, the industrial heartland long coveted by Russian President Vladimir Putin.

Houthis claim responsibility for missile attack on Israel

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Dubai

Iran-backed Houthi rebels have claimed responsibility for a missile attack on Israel. Brig Gen Yahya Saree, a military spokesman for the Houthis, issued a statement on Saturday on the rebel group's Al-Masirah satellite television network. Israel's military had earlier said it had intercepted a missile. The attack came after Saree signalled in a vague statement on Friday that the rebels would join the war that has shocked the region and rattled the global economy. It is the first time Israel has faced fire from Yemen since the start of the conflict last month. Houthi attacks on vessels during the Israel-Hamas war upended shipping in the Red Sea. Before the attack from Yemen, there appeared to be a breakthrough as Tehran agreed to allow humanitarian aid and agricultural shipments through the Strait of Hormuz.

Death toll rises in Abu Dhabi

The casualty toll from a missile attack early Saturday in Abu Dhabi has risen to six. The Abu Dhabi Media Office said an additional Pakistani national was injured by falling debris in the vicinity of Khalifa Economic Zones Abu Dhabi when air defence systems intercepted a ballistic missile. The attack caused



Residents carrying personal belongings as they leave a building damaged in a missile strike in Tel Aviv, Israel AP

three fires in the area which have been brought under control, it said. **Palestinian brothers killed in Israel strike** An Israeli airstrike killed two Palestinian brothers Saturday morning in the Gaza Strip, hospital authorities said. The strike hit the men close to the Showa roundabout in Gaza City's Shijaiyah neighborhood, according to the Al-Ahly hospital. The area is close to the so-called Yellow Line which separates Israeli-

were reported, it said.

controlled areas across the Gaza Strip from the rest of the enclave. Israel's military did not immediately respond to a request for comment. **Oman reports drone attack on Salalah port** Oman said the strike hit Salalah port Saturday morning, wounding a foreign worker. The Government media office said the two-drone attack also damaged a crane.

FM of Saudi, Egypt, Turkiye to visit Pak for talks on West Asia

SAJJAD HUSSAIN
Islamabad

Pakistan is set to host the foreign ministers of Saudi Arabia, Egypt and Turkiye for discussions on a wide-range of issues, including efforts to de-escalate tensions in West Asia amid the war in Iran, the Foreign Office said on Saturday. At the invitation of Pakistan's Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar, Saudi Arabia Foreign Minister Prince Faisal bin Farhan Al Saud, Turkiye Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan and Egyptian Foreign Minister Badr Abdelatty, will visit Islamabad on Sunday and Monday, the Foreign Office said. During the visit, the foreign



ministers will hold "in-depth discussions on a range of issues, including efforts to de-escalate tensions in the region", it added. The visiting leaders will also meet Prime Minister

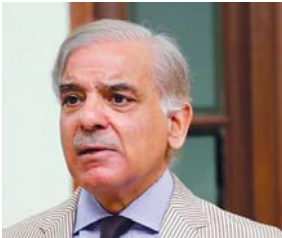
Shehbaz Sharif, the Foreign Office said. It added that Pakistan "highly values its relations with the brotherly countries of Saudi Arabia, Turkiye, and Egypt, and the visit will

provide an opportunity to further strengthen Pakistan's cooperation and coordination with these countries". Geo News reported that the meeting was earlier scheduled to be held in Turkiye but due to Dar's engagement, he requested the leaders to come to Islamabad. "The meeting was scheduled to be held in Turkiye but due to my engagement, I requested my brothers to instead meet in Islamabad tomorrow (Sunday)," Dar was quoted as saying. The deputy prime minister said that Pakistan is working with "honesty and sincerity" to resolve ongoing disputes. Dar said that talks with Iran are continuing, but due to the sensitive nature of the

Sharif condemns Israeli attacks on Iran

SAJJAD HUSSAIN
Islamabad

Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif on Saturday in a phone call with Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian held discussions regarding the ongoing hostilities in West Asia and condemned the continued Israeli attacks on Tehran. "During their detailed conversation that lasted over one hour, the two leaders held extensive discussions regarding the ongoing hostilities in the region and peace efforts," a statement by the Prime Minister's Office said. Sharif informed the Iranian president of the diplomatic outreach efforts being undertaken by him,



Pakistan PM Shehbaz Sharif

Deputy Prime Minister Ishaq Dar as well as Field Marshal Syed Asim Munir, it said. Pakistan was engaging the US, Gulf and Islamic countries, to create a conducive environment for peace talks, the statement said. The prime minister briefed the Iranian president on the strong endorsement of Pakistan's peace initiative and expressed the

hope that a viable path towards ending hostilities could be found collectively, it said. Sharif also reiterated Pakistan's strong condemnation of the continued Israeli attacks on Iran, including the latest attacks on civilian infrastructure on Friday. He reaffirmed "Pakistan's solidarity and support for the brave people of Iran, in these challenging times", as he also offered condolences on the loss of over 1,900 lives and prayed for recovery of the injured and displaced. The Iranian president, appreciating the prime minister's diplomatic efforts, shared his perspective on the ongoing hostilities perpetrated by Israel against Iran, the statement said. (PTI)

Drone strikes kill 5 in Ukraine

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Kyiv

Russia launched over 270 drones at Ukraine overnight, killing at least five people, Ukrainian authorities reported on Saturday. Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy, meanwhile, made an unannounced visit to the UAE as Kyiv seeks to use its drone defence expertise to help Arab states blunt Iran's attacks. Two people were killed and at least 11 more were injured in a nighttime Russian drone strike on Odesa, according to the head of the region, Serhii Lysak. According to his Telegram posts, the attack damaged a maternity hospital and private houses in the major Black Sea port city. Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said the "massive" strike involved more than 60 drones. "Last night, the Russians launched a massive strike on Odesa. There was no military purpose whatsoever - this was pure terror against ordinary civilian life," he said Saturday on X. He added that port and "critical" infrastructure was also damaged, as well as busi-



ness premises. Two men died and two more were injured early on Saturday in Kryvyi Rih, Zelenskyy's hometown in central Ukraine, after a Russian drone hit an industrial facility, regional head Oleksandr Gandzha said in a Telegram update. He did not specify what the industrial building was. One person was killed overnight in the Poltava region, also in central Ukraine, as Russia struck unspecified industrial sites there, regional authorities reported on Saturday.

Sectarian attacks rock Christian town in Syria

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Suqaylabiyah

An argument between two men in a Christian town in central Syria led to sectarian attacks that caused widespread damage to homes, shops and cars in a reminder of religious violence that fol-



lowed the fall of long-time leader Bashar Assad two years ago. The attacks in the predominantly Christian town of Suqaylabiyah in Hama province are the latest to target members of Syria's Christian minority, many of whom have left the country since the conflict began 15 years ago, leaving half-a-million people dead and the population deeply divided. There was no immediate word on casualties in the attacks that lasted until the early hours of Saturday, during which scores of men on motorcycles from the nearby Sunni town of Qalaat al-Madiq attacked the property of Christians. "We passed through a state of terror, fear, and panic," said Liyan Dweir, whose clothes shop was riddled with bullets and suffered heavy damage.

5 Indians injured in UAE by missile debris: Report

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Dubai

Five Indians were injured in the UAE by the fall of debris in the vicinity of the Khalifa Economic Zones Abu Dhabi (KEZAD) following interception of a ballistic missile by the country's air defence system, local media reported on Saturday. The Abu Dhabi Media Office in a social media post said the authorities confirmed that the incident resulted in injuries to five individuals of Indian nationality, ranging from moderate to minor. "The competent authorities urge the public to obtain information from official sources only, and to avoid circulating rumours or unver-



Smoke rising from a building following an Israeli airstrike in Dahiyeh, Beirut's southern suburbs, Lebanon AP

fied information," it said. Earlier, it reported that the authorities were respond-

ing to two fire incidents in the vicinity of KEZAD, caused by falling debris following the

successful interception of a ballistic missile by air defence systems. On Thursday, an Indian national was among two killed in the UAE when debris of missiles intercepted by the country's air defence system fell on a street. The Indian Embassy in the UAE expressed "deepest condolences" on the tragic demise of an Indian national in the incident. "The Embassy is closely coordinating with the UAE authorities to render all possible support and assistance," it posted on X. The second person killed in the incident was a Pakistani national, while the three injured also included an Indian, Abu Dhabi Media Office reported.

US: 2 students dead, 7 injured in Tennessee school bus crash

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Huntingdon (US)

Two students were killed and at least seven other people were injured Friday in a school bus crash in west Tennessee, officials said. The crash involving a Tennessee Department of Transportation dump truck, a Chevrolet Trailblazer and the school bus took place at about noon on Highway 70 in Carroll County, said Maj. Travis Plotzer, a spokesperson for the Tennessee Highway Patrol. Plotzer said there were a total of 25 students and five adults on the bus. The school bus was carrying



students and employees from Kenwood Middle School in Clarksville for a field trip to Jackson, Tennessee, the Clarksville-Montgomery County School System said in a statement. The cause of the crash was

under investigation.

Plotzer said during a news conference that two students died in the crash. Officials said at least seven other people were taken by air ambulance to hospitals in Tennessee. The nature of their injuries was not immediately disclosed. Four people were taken to Monroe Carrell Jr. Children's Hospital at Vanderbilt in Nashville and are in stable condition, according to a Vanderbilt Health spokesperson. It was not immediately known if other injured people were taken by ground ambulance to hospitals.

One month into war, Iranians wrestle with lost livelihoods, bombs and uncertainties

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Cairo

Iranians were already reeling from a shattered economy and mass killing of protesters when the first US-Israeli bombs slammed into Tehran a month ago. Now they are struggling to get by through a war with no end in sight, wrestling with lost livelihoods, damage to homes and the stress of explosions. Many wonder where it is leading - to the destruction of their homeland, the chaotic fall of the theocracy or its survival, wounded but more extreme. "I think we've experienced everything bad possible, from

the terrible atmosphere of January, the killings and arrests, to the war," said a 26-year-old designer in Tehran. Daily explosions, near and far and unpredictable, shake and damage homes. Businesses are struggling. An unprecedented internet blackout since January has largely cut people off from the outside world and made communication within Iran more difficult. The trauma of war comes on top of the shock from January, when hundreds of thousands across Iran marched in the biggest protests against the theocracy in decades - only to be met by security forces opening



Smoke rising from a building following an Israeli airstrike in Dahiyeh, Beirut's southern suburbs, Lebanon AP

fire, killing thousands. Tens of thousands were detained, and arrests have continued. The AP spoke to 10 people across Iran, most of whom spoke on condition of anonymity for their security. Businesses crumbling The designer, who with a partner runs a factory making leather fashion products, said her business was on the verge of closing. "When the economy gets bad, nonessential goods are the first thing to be removed from the shopping cart," she said. Much of her sales are online, and the internet blackout practically reduced "the small sales to zero." Since the January protests, she has had to live

off her meagre savings, and the violence of the crack-down upset her so much she has not been able to return to work. When the war began on February 28, she moved to her parents' house. A few days later, the blast from a nearby strike damaged her apartment that she had just left. Like most Iranians, she doesn't have home insurance, so she will have to pay for repairs herself. She only leaves her parents' house to buy necessities. Trying to track strikes The terrifying cadence of airstrikes shapes daily life in Tehran. An engineer living in Tehran tries to find a pattern

in strikes - are certain times safer? Recent nights saw explosions light up the skies. One evening, a blast shook his home as he had guests over. They climbed up on the roof and tried in vain to figure out where it hit. "We didn't see any visible fire," he said. He thinks the strikes are less frequent now, or maybe "our perception of it has changed," as everyone gets used to bombings. He feels anxious when family or friends go out on the streets, and struggles to sleep. He had a job offer before the war but does not know if it is still there. Soon, he says, many will struggle with rent and bills.



Eager to work closely with India, says Nepal PM

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kathmandu

Nepal's newly elected Prime Minister Balendra Shah on Saturday said he is "eager to work closely" with India while thanking PM Narendra Modi for his greetings after the oath-taking ceremony.

Prime Minister Modi greeted Shah shortly after the swearing-in ceremony on Friday and said he was looking forward to working closely with his Nepalese counterpart to take forward India-Nepal ties.

Replying to Modi's post, Nepal's Prime Minister's office posted on X, "Thank you, PM @narendramodi for your kind words and warm wishes. I am eager to work closely with you



Nepalese policemen clearing the street as former Prime Minister Khadga Prasad Oli is taken for procedural medical checkup

PTI

to advance the multifaceted relations between our two countries for the common prosperity of our people."

Nepal is important for India in the context of its overall strategic interests in the region.

Nepal relies heavily on India for the transportation of goods and services. Nepal's access to the sea is through India, and it imports a predominant proportion of its requirements from and through India. Balen is the first democratically elected prime minister to be sworn in since the coalition Government led by ex-PM Oli was ousted in September last year, following the youth-led Gen Z protest against corruption, nepotism, and a social media ban that escalated

into violence. Meanwhile Prime Minister Balendra Shah on Friday formed a 15-member Cabinet that includes five women ministers, marking 33 per cent female representation.

The newly appointed ministers took the oath of office and secrecy on Friday, administered by President Ram Chandra Paudel.

Nisha Mehta with the Health Ministry portfolio, Pratibha Rawal with the Federal Affairs General Administration and Cooperatives Ministry, Sobita Gautam with the Law and Justice portfolio, and Sita Badi with the Women and Children portfolio are the five women ministers inducted into the Balen cabinet.

Washington Airports halt flights due to chemical smell



GARY FIELDS ■ Washington

Airports serving Washington, D.C., Baltimore and some cities in Virginia briefly halted all flights Friday evening because of what federal authorities said was a strong chemical smell at the flight centre that controls traffic into the airports. According to a spokesperson with the Department of Transportation, the Federal Aviation Administration temporarily stopped traffic at at Ronald Reagan Washington National Airport, Washington Dulles International Airport, Baltimore-Washington International Airport, Charlottesville-Albemarle Airport and Richmond International Airport because of a chemical odor at the Potomac TRACON. The

TRACON is a terminal radar approach control facility that manages air traffic for those regions, according to the FAA website. FAA spokeswoman Kristen Alsop said Friday that controllers were coming back to work and normal flight operations should return to normal soon. It was the second time this month that airports in the region have had to halt flights because of a chemical smell at the Potomac facility. The previous ground stop, which lasted about an hour, was the result of a strong odor that was traced to a circuit, Transportation Secretary Sean Duffy said in an X posting. Operations resumed in that incident after firefighters confirmed there was no danger to air traffic controllers. (AP)

Indonesia implements ban on social media for minor

EDNA TARIGAN
■ Jakarta

Indonesia on Saturday began implementing a new Government regulation approved earlier this month that bans children younger than 16 from access to digital platforms that could expose them to pornography, cyberbullying, online scams and addiction.

With the move, Indonesia became the first country in Southeast Asia to ban children from having accounts on YouTube, TikTok, Facebook, Instagram, Threads, X, Bigo Live and Roblox. It follows measures that Australia took last year in a world-first social media ban for children as part of a push for families to take back power from tech giants and protect their teens.

Indonesia has said that the implementation of the restrictions would be carried out gradually, until all platforms comply with the measure. In announcing the new regulation earlier in March, Indonesia's Communication and Digital Affairs Minister Meutya Hafid said it would apply to around 70 million children in Indonesia - a country with a population of about 280 million.

Not an easy task Hafid said high-risk digital platforms are identified by factors such as how easy it is for children to become exposed to strangers, potential predators and harmful content in general, as well as the levels of risk of exploitation and data security scams. But she acknowl-



edged that implementing the new regulation - even gradually as planned - will be difficult. Getting digital platforms to comply and then making them report deactivations of under-16 accounts is difficult. "This is certainly a task. But we must take steps to save our children," Hafid said. "It's not easy. Nevertheless, we must see it through."

Maura Munthe, a 13-year-old who spends roughly four hours a day on her phone on social media, including playing games on Roblox with her friends, said she feels "kind of 50-50" about the new Government policy but mostly agrees with it.

Her peers in school, she says, worry they will miss out on all the fun and entertainment they now have access to. "There are always other games on my phone, not only the online ones," she said. "I will likely play more games alone or just hang out with my friends." Munthe's mother, Leni Sinuraya, 47, said she has for years trusted her daughter to use her phone wisely, both when studying and when playing online games. Still, she sees the Government's move as good for all children in Indonesia. (AP)

Pak, IMF strike deal over disbursement fund

SAJJAD HUSSAIN
■ Islamabad

Pakistan and the International Monetary Fund (IMF) have reached a staff-level agreement (SLA) for the disbursement of approximately \$1.2 billion under two separate arrangements.

The two sides successfully concluded the third review of the Extended Fund Facility (EFF) and the second review under the Resilience and Sustainability Facility (RSF), the IMF said on Saturday.

The IMF mission held talks with Pakistani officials in Karachi and Islamabad from February 25 to March 2, but left without an agreement. The talks continued in virtual



format, and an agreement was reached.

The fund confirmed the development through a statement, saying "IMF staff and the Pakistani authorities have reached a staff-level agreement on the third review under Pakistan's Extended Fund Facility (EFF) and the second review

under the Resilience and Sustainability Facility (RSF)." "IMF reaches Staff-Level Agreement on the Third Review for the 37-month Extended Arrangement under the Extended Fund Facility (EFF) and the Second Review for 28-month arrangement under the Resilience and Sustainability

Facility (RSF)," Pakistan's Ministry of Finance said on X.

IMF mission chief Iva Petrova said, subject to IMF board approval, Pakistan will have access to about USD 1.0 billion (SDR 760 million) under the EFF and about USD 210 million (SDR 154 million) under the RSF.

She said that Pakistan authorities remain committed to pursuing sound and prudent macroeconomic policies to preserve the recent gains in macro-financial stabilisation, while deepening structural reforms to accelerate growth and strengthening social protection to mitigate the impact of volatile energy prices on the most vulnerable. (PTI)

Love my legacy to be made as great peacemaker: Trump

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

US President Donald Trump has said he would love his legacy to be made as a great peacemaker as he stopped eight wars, including the one between India and Pakistan last year.

Addressing the Saudi-backed Future Investment Initiative (FII) Priority Summit in Miami, Trump also said reopening the Strait of Hormuz was a condition for any agreement with Iran and stressed that maritime access for oil shipments must be restored.

"We're negotiating now, and it would be great if we could do something, but they have to open it up," he



said. The US President reiterated his claim that he helped stop eight wars, including those between Armenia and Azerbaijan; the Democratic Republic of the Congo and Rwanda; Cambodia and Thailand; Egypt and Ethiopia; Serbia and Kosovo; Israel and Hamas.

"I would love my legacy to

be made as a great peacemaker because I really believe I am a peacemaker. It doesn't seem like it right now, but I think I am a peacemaker," Trump said.

"I even stopped India and Pakistan, and they were going at it for a week.. nine planes already shot down. They were in a war. I stopped them. How did I stop them? I said, if you keep fighting, I'm going to put a 250 per cent tariff on each one," the US President said.

"No, no, no, you cannot do that. I said, I'm doing it. All right, we won't fight anymore. That's how I stopped them." Trump said.

Trump jokingly referred to the Strait of Hormuz as the "Strait of Trump" during his

remarks before correcting himself, later saying the comment was not accidental. Trump described Iran as a longstanding force shaping instability in the Middle East but said its position had weakened under the US military operation Epic Fury.

"For 47 years, Iran has been known as the bully of the Middle East, but they are not the bully any longer. They're on the run," he said, adding that Iran's leadership, armed forces, and nuclear program had suffered damage during the operation.

Trump refused to refer to the attacks on Iran as "war" and chose to refer to it as a military operation. (PTI)

Trump signs order to pay TSA employees after Congress fails to agree on DHS funding

KEVIN FREKING/LISA MASCARO/JOEY CAPPELLETTI
■ Washington

President Donald Trump on Friday signed a promised executive action to pay Transportation Security Administration employees after a bid to end the shutdown of the Department of Homeland Security abruptly fell apart in Congress.

Trump signed the action with an eye toward easing long security lines at many of the nation's top airports.

"America's air travel system has reached its breaking point," Trump said in the memo authorizing the payments. He added, "I



have determined that these circumstances constitute an emergency situation compromising the Nation's security." Trump said his administration would use "funds that have a reasonable and logical nexus to TSA operations" for the payments. In a statement Friday, Homeland Security Secretary Markwayne Mullin said TSA workers "should begin

seeing paychecks as early as Monday."

While Trump's action could help ease the plight of air travelers, it does little to resolve the DHS shutdown that has jammed airports and imposed financial hardship on thousands of federal workers.

The House and Senate ended the week by passing vastly different bills, creating a new impasse as lawmakers leave Washington for a two-week recess. The shutdown of Homeland Security will reach 44 days on Sunday, eclipsing the record 43-day shutdown last fall that affected all of the federal Government. (AP)

West Asia conflict worsens African economy

OPE ADETAYO
■ Lagos (Nigeria)

Lagos taxi driver Adegbola Isaac went to the gas station twice last weekend. Each time, the price in the Nigerian city had climbed further and hit 1,350 naira (USD 0.99) per litre, a nearly 35 per cent increase since the Iran war started. That's wiped out most of his daily profit. "It is hitting hard," Isaac said.

Like many people across the world, Isaac is one of millions across Africa who are reeling from the economic impacts of the faraway conflict in the Middle East, which began February 28 with joint US-Israeli strikes on Iran.

For many Africans, the fuel price hike because of the



Strait of Hormuz being largely closed off worsens the hardships they already struggle with in some of the world's poorest households.

The latest shock also isn't

isolated. Africa is hurting again from another global crisis it had no part in starting. From the COVID-19 pandemic to the war in Ukraine and now the Middle East

conflict, the world's fastest-growing continent - with a population rivaling China and India - is at the painful end of ripple effects that include a global scramble for critical resources like fuel and fertiliser. With the majority of African countries being net importers of refined oil products, the impact has been swift, leading to rising retail fuel prices in Africa and associated increases in the costs of most goods and services.

Experts say African countries are critically integrated into global economies and are exposed to global shocks because of their dependence on major economies.

The United Nations on Friday said it is pursuing a way

to allow fertiliser to resume safe transit through the Strait of Hormuz, hoping it would build confidence in wider diplomatic efforts around the Iran war.

Africa is the epicentre of crises According to a 2025 report by the UN Trade and Development, or UNCTAD, which describes Africa as "the epicentre of overlapping global crises," more than half of the continent's imports and exports are with five non-African countries. All of Kenya's fuel comes from the Middle East, particularly from the United Arab Emirates, with its fuel retailers saying 20 per cent of the country's outlets are already affected. Uganda's fuel stock was initially projected to last a few weeks. (AP)

Pope Leo visits Monaco; urges citizens to use faith, wealth for good

PAOLO SANTALUCIA AND NICOLE WINFIELD ■ Monaco

Pope Leo XIV on Saturday urged residents of the cosmopolitan Mediterranean principality of Monaco to use their wealth, influence and Catholic faith for good, especially to uphold Catholic teaching on protecting the sanctity of life.

Leo made a one-day trip to the glitzy enclave, becoming the first pope to visit Monaco since Pope Paul III came in 1538. As a cannon boomed, Prince Albert and Princess Charlene met Leo at the Monaco heliport, just down the coast from the marina - home to the yachts of the rich and famous.

At the palace, members of the royal family stood in the courtyard waiting for Leo, the women dressed in black and with lace

head coverings. Charlene wore white - a protocol privilege granted by the Vatican to Catholic royal sovereigns when meeting popes, known in diplomatic terms as "le privilege du blanc."

In his opening greeting from the palace balcony, Leo urged Monaco to use its wealth, influence and "gift of smallness" for good.

It was important, he said, "especially at a historical moment when the display of power and the logic of oppression are harming the world and jeopardising peace." Speaking in French, Leo urged Monaco's people to use their faith and be "always ready to protect every human life with love, at any time and in any condition, so that no one is ever excluded from the table of fraternity."

Monaco is one of the few European countries where Catholicism is the official state religion. Prince Albert recently refused a proposal to legalise abortion, citing the important role Catholicism plays in Monaco society.

The decision was largely symbolic, since abortion is a constitutional right in France, which surrounds the coastal principality of 2.2 sq km.

But in refusing to allow it in Monaco, Albert joined other European Catholic royals who have taken a similar stand over the years to uphold Catholic doctrine on an increasingly secular continent.

When Pope Francis visited Belgium in 2024, he announced he was putting the late King Baudouin on the path to possi-



Pope Leo XIV, Princess Charlene of Monaco and Prince Albert II of Monaco appear at the Gallery of Hercules balcony of the Prince's Palace in Monaco-Ville Monaco

ble sainthood because he abdicated for a day in 1990 rather than approve legislation to legalise abortion.

A coastal playground for the rich and famous, Monaco is renowned as much for its tax-friendly incentives and Formula 1 Grand Prix as its glamorous royal family. The son of the late American actress Grace Kelly, Albert spoke in perfect, unaccented English when he greeted Leo at the heliport. Leo was heard noting that he landed three minutes late. Leo's one-day visit includes a meeting with Monaco's Catholic community in the Cathedral and Mass in the sports stadium.

Monaco's population of 38,000 is heavily Catholic and also multinational, with only a fifth of the population actually citizens of the principality. (AP)



BRIEFLY

Lebron and Bronny connect on first father-son assist



LeBron James literally passed it on to the next generation on Friday night. The top scorer in NBA history recorded the league's first father-son assist when he passed to Bronny James for a 3-pointer in the second quarter of the Los Angeles Lakers' game against Brooklyn. "That was a special moment for us two, and a lot more to come down the road," Bronny said after the Lakers beat the Nets 116-99. The Lakers' father-and-son duo played meaningful minutes together for the second straight game when the Lakers returned from a successful road trip to host the struggling Nets. Bronny James was on court with his father for nearly 4 1/2 minutes after they checked in together to start the second quarter. Both generations scored during their sequence together, with LeBron making a driving layup before he exchanged passes on the next possession with Bronny, who hit his 3-pointer from a step behind the line. "Not taking it for granted, just being in the moment of us being on the floor once again," LeBron said. "That's two games back-to-back, playing meaningful minutes, and him also making another play. I got doubled, and he was able to fake the pass to the corner and then knock down the 3. Definitely a cool moment for us, and also for the family." While discussing his latest chance to play with his father, Bronny flashed back to a pleasant father-son memory - for him, at least. "Last time I played him 1-on-1, I don't know if this story has came out, but he broke a backboard at our house in Miami," Bronny said with a grin.

Antonelli, Russell 1-2 on the pole for Japanese Grand Prix



Mercedes driver Kimi Antonelli took the pole for Sunday's Formula 1 Japanese Grand Prix, just two weeks after he led qualifying and won the first race of his career in China. Antonelli's top qualifying time Saturday was 1 minute, 28.778 seconds on the 5.8-kilometer Suzuka circuit. Teammate George Russell will start alongside him. Russell won in Australia in the first race of the season and also took the pole, the start of Mercedes' early dominance in 2026. McLaren's Oscar Piastri, who has yet to start a race this season, will start alongside Charles Leclerc of Ferrari in the second row, and Lando Norris of McLaren starts on row three next to Lewis Hamilton of Ferrari.. Two weeks ago in China, neither McLaren car took part in the race because of electrical problems. And in Australia, Piastri sat out after crashing his car before the race even started. Four-time champion Max Verstappen of Red Bull will start 11th after struggling and complaining on his radio about his car. "I think there is something wrong with the car, mate. It was completely undrivable," he said. Saturday's qualifying was run on a sunny spring day with the same predicted for Sunday.

Iran's judiciary threatens to seize property of Sardar Azmoun

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Tehran

Iran's judiciary has threatened to seize the property of national soccer star Sardar Azmoun, two semiofficial news agencies said Friday. The star is on a list of 16 individuals seen as government critics and whose assets judicial authorities in the northern province of Golestan plan to confiscate, according to the Fars news agency.

The 31-year-old Azmoun played for Iran at the past two World Cups and his 57 career goals for Team Melli, in 91 games, is second most on its all-time list. Azmoun failed to be picked this month for warmup games ahead of the World Cup, and he currently seems unlikely to be taken to the tournament where Iran is



Netherlands. All have direct family ties to Morocco that allow them within FIFA rules to change national eligibility, typically when players have not played a senior competitive game for the first country they represented.

Spain, Germany win in pre-World Cup friendlies

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ London

Mikel Oyarzabal scored two impressive goals in Spain's 3-0 win over Serbia, and Florian Wirtz scored two and made two more as Germany twice came from behind to beat Switzerland 4-3 in entertaining pre-World Cup friendlies on Friday. In other games, Ben White scored on his recall to the England side and then gave away a penalty in stoppage time as England drew 1-1 with Uruguay, while the Netherlands overcame Norway 2-1 in Amsterdam. White was a controversial selection by England coach Thomas Tuchel, four years

after walking out on his teammates in the middle of the last World Cup. The Arsenal defender replaced Fikayo Tomori with 21 minutes left in a dull match on Friday and his appearance was greeted with some boos from the 80,000 fans present at Wembley. "He needs to take it on the chin," Tuchel said. "We will always protect him and hopefully we can put it behind (us) because he is ready to write some new chapters and we are ready to give him the chance, so hopefully everyone can move on and accept it." However, White was in the right place at the right time 10 minutes from time to give England the lead after



Cole Palmer's corner was flicked on and White poked the ball in at the far post for what will surely be one of the easiest goals of his career. Uruguay did not have a

shot on goal and that looked like being the winner, only for White to clip Federico Vinas in the box as the clock ticked past 90 minutes. The referee pointed to the

Iran's soccer team honours victims of school strike

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Antalya (Turkey)

Players held small backpacks as Iran's national soccer team used a match against Nigeria on Friday to honour the victims of a deadly missile strike on an elementary school. More than 165 people were killed, most of them children, when a Feb. 28 strike, likely launched by the US, hit the school in southern Iran. Neither the United States nor Israel has accepted responsibility for the attack, which has come under staunch criticism from the United Nations and human rights groups. The US military is investigating and has said it would never target civilians. During the



national anthem on Friday, the Iranian team honoured the memory of the slain children by placing small pink and purple school backpacks in front of them. Video of the ceremony also showed the players wearing black armbands in remembrance of those killed since the war began. The match was played in Antalya, southern

Turkey. Nigeria won 2-1 in a game that was a World Cup tuneup for Iran, ahead of the tournament being co-hosted by the United States, Mexico and Canada. The Islamic Republic's team is scheduled to play three group-stage matches in June in the US. The Iranian ambassador in Mexico City has said the country asked

FIFA to move those three games to Mexico after US President Donald Trump discouraged the team from attending, citing safety concerns. The Iranian government and soccer officials have said they do not want to boycott the World Cup but that it is not possible for the national team to go to the US because of military attacks on Iran by Israel and US. FIFA President Gianni Infantino has dampened Iran's attempts to move its matches, saying global soccer's governing body wants the tournament "to go ahead as scheduled." Separately on Friday, Iran's judiciary threatened to seize the property of soccer player Sardar Azmoun, two semiofficial news agencies said.

2026 World Cup: Mexico's iconic Azteca Stadium set to reopen

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Mexico City

Felix Aguirre admits he's been having trouble sleeping these last few months. On the eve of the reopening of the iconic Azteca Stadium, and with some work still to be done, the stadium director won't be able to relax until kickoff on Saturday night. After being closed since May 2024 for renovations in preparation for the 2026 World Cup, the stadium where Pele's Brazil and Diego Maradona's Argentina won the World Cup in 1970 and 1986, respectively, will again open its doors to fans for a friendly match between Mexico and Portugal. It will be a crucial test for

Aguirre and all the workers who have been racing against the clock in recent weeks to get the stadium ready, not just for that match but also for the World Cup opener on June 11, when Mexico plays South Africa.

"We're ready:" "It's true that I've had trouble sleeping thinking about the project and making sure it's the best it can be," Aguirre told *The Associated Press*. "Today I can tell you that we've done it and we're ready." The AP was given access to the stadium on Thursday when work appeared to still be underway in various areas, including the new locker rooms, where the smell of paint is noticeable. According to Aguirre, there



are currently 2,200 workers on the project, working 24 hours a day. With the renovations, the stadium, officially renamed Banorte, increased its capacity from 83,000 to 87,500 spectators. In addition, new seats, a new sound system with 250 speakers, two video

screens, new locker rooms, and a hybrid pitch were installed, among other improvements. To increase capacity, a lounge area located in the lower and central part of the stadium was removed. "At some point we tore down the lower stands to put in boxes and

spot after a video review and Federico Valverde converted for Uruguay to leave the scores level. It was the first goal that England has conceded in seven games and the decision left the coach and players furious, with Tuchel declaring it "not a penalty." Harry Maguire shared that opinion and was even more upset about the referee's lack of action in dealing a rash challenge by Ronaldo Araujo on Phil Foden. Maguire told broadcaster ITV, "You don't see tackles like that and not get red cards." **Brilliant Wirtz downs Switzerland:** In Basel, Germany won for the sixth time in a row thanks largely to the brilliance of Liverpool's

Wirtz. Germany looked shaky at the back and went behind in the 17th minute when Dan Ndoye cut in from the left and crashed a shot past Oliver Baumann from a tight angle. Germany leveled nine minutes later when Jonathan Tah headed home Wirtz's cross from the left but Breel Embolo put Switzerland ahead again in the 41st minute with a diving header after Baumann hesitated to leave his line. Once again, Wirtz brought Germany back into the game, when, on the stroke of halftime, his flighted pass carved open the Swiss defense and allowed Serge Gnabry to lift the ball over 'keeper Gregor Kobel.

Raphinha out for 5 weeks with hamstring injury

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Barcelona

Barcelona forward Raphinha will be out for approximately five weeks and miss Champions League quarterfinal games against Atletico Madrid after injuring his right hamstring while playing for Brazil in a friendly against France. Five-time champion Brazil starts its World Cup campaign against Morocco on June 13. "Raphinha has a right hamstring injury, as confirmed by medical tests carried out by the Brazilian Football Federation (CBF) following the discomfort he experienced during the Brazil v. France match in Boston on



Thursday," Barcelona said in a statement on Friday. "The player is returning to Barcelona to begin the appropriate treatment. The estimated recovery time is five weeks."

some lounges that weren't nice, now we're bringing back those stands and that's returning to the original Azteca," Aguirre said. The stadium located south of Mexico City will host five World Cup games next summer. Opened in 1966, Azteca has undergone several renovations — the last one to accommodate NFL games in 2016. "There were many areas for improvement, but some things we were obsessed with were enhancing the fan experience. To achieve this, we improved the audio, video, and internet, but we also improved the restrooms, entrances and exits, and everything related to the overall experience," Aguirre said. "It's

somewhat subjective, but I think we achieved it." **All about soul:** Aguirre was given a clear brief to follow. "Another thing we wanted was for it not to lose its soul," Aguirre said. "This is a historic building that is part of the city; we couldn't disrespect its essence. We simply had to enhance it, preserve its soul, and provide fans with a better experience." The exterior remains a familiar sight to fans. Debris can still be seen in some places, and there will be no car parking available for supporters for Saturday's game. Authorities have asked fans to use public transportation or shuttles that will depart from public locations throughout the capital.

US can win World Cup: Mauricio Pochettino tells soccer players

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Marietta (USA)

Mauricio Pochettino told American soccer players they can achieve what almost no one thinks is possible: win the World Cup. "Why not us? Why not us? Why not us?" he said Friday. "We need to really believe that we can be there. We need to dream." Ahead of friendlies against Belgium on Saturday and Portugal on Tuesday, Pochettino publicly repeated a message he delivered directly to players when they reported to camp this week. "Dreams," he added, "inspire reality." The US hasn't reached the



World Cup semifinals since the initial tournament in 1930 and hasn't advanced to the quarterfinals since 2002. Since then, the Americans were knocked out in the round of 16 in 2010, 2014 and 2022, were eliminated in the group

stage in 2006 and failed to qualify in 2018. Only eight nations have won a World Cup: Brazil (five titles), Germany and Italy (four each), Argentina (three), France and Uruguay (two apiece), and England and Spain (one each).

Morocco picks Diop, Bounida among 7 cleared by FIFA to change nationality

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Geneva

Morocco got FIFA permission to select Fulham defender Issa Diop and Ajax midfielder Rayane Bounida among seven players recruited this month by the 2022 World Cup semifinalist ahead of the next edition in North America and 16 in total since last March. The 29-year-old Diop was a France youth and under-21 international and Bounida is among six players aged 20 or under changing eligibility this month to represent Morocco after playing youth games for Belgium or the



Netherlands. All have direct family ties to Morocco that allow them within FIFA rules to change national eligibility,

typically when players have not played a senior competitive game for the first country they represented.

Sinner continues his winning streak in Miami Open

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Miami Gardens (USA)

Jannik Sinner sat out the Miami Open a year ago as he served a three-month suspension after testing positive for a banned substance. Now the 24-year-old Italian is on the verge of winning his second Miami Open title in three years and becoming the first male to win the "Sunshine Double" since Roger Federer in 2017. The second-ranked Sinner roared into the Miami Open final with a 6-3, 7-6 (7-4) win over No. 4 Alexander Zverev on Friday night at Hard Rock Stadium. "Coming here and trying to produce some good tennis was my main goal,



and standing here again in the final means very much to me," Sinner said. "It has been an incredible swing and I couldn't be better. I'm very happy." Sinner, who served 15 acs, has beaten Zverev seven straight times and has won a record 32 straight sets at an ATP Masters 1000. A

hardcourt dynamo, Sinner captured the first leg of the Sunshine Double on March 15 when he topped Daniel Medvedev in Indian Wells. Sinner will be a heavy favorite when he faces 21st-seeded Jiri Lehecka in Sunday's final. Sinner has won 11 straight matches in

Miami dating to 2024. He captured the 2024 Miami Open but wasn't allowed to defend his title. Nevertheless, Zverev was the crowd favorite, particularly drawing loud cheers on points he won in the second set. When the 6-foot-6 German got up a break point leading 4-3 in the second set, the stadium was awash in noise. But Zverev couldn't pull it off, hitting a backhand into the net as Sinner escaped. In the second-set tiebreaker, Sinner lost the first point but pounded two straight aces to lead 2-1 and soon it was over after a Zverev service return sailed long. Sinner notched his first-set break at 2-1. Off a long rally,

he came in and smashed an overhead winner for break point, then looped a lovely forehand winner down the line to make it 3-1. Sinner has a 3-0 career record against Lehecka, beating him last at the 2025 French Open. Lehecka advanced to the biggest ATP final of his rising career by routing 28th seed Arthur Fils 6-2, 6-2 in the early semifinal. Lehecka's Czech countryman, Jakub Mensik, won the Miami Open last year. Lehecka will make his first appearance in an ATP Masters 1000 final. "Today was a great match," Lehecka said. "Definitely brought me a lot of confidence going into the Sunday final.

Devdutt, Kohli, Duffy star in RCB's six-wicket win over SRH

G UNNIKRISHNAN
■ Bengaluru

Devdutt Padikkal's 26-ball-61 crusted with class and Virat Kohli's masterly unbeaten half-century powered Royal Challengers Bengaluru to a dominant six-wicket victory over Sunrisers Hyderabad in the IPL 2026's season-opening match here on Saturday.

Padikkal and Kohli (69 not out, 38b) stitched 101 runs off a mere 45 balls for the second wicket stand, lending meat to RCB's successful chase of 202 in just 15.4 overs. The hosts finished at 203/4 to start their title defence in spectacular style.

After Phil Salt was jettisoned early, Kohli and Padikkal, in particular, treated

the Chinnaswamy crowd to a brilliant batting exhibition. Their approach to batting was as different as chalk and cheese. Padikkal was all wrists, feet and thunderous cuts while Kohli dished out his favourite drives, shots on the 'V' and the money shot - the swat flick.

Padikkal oozed the left-hander's class even while plundering 6, 4, 6 off pacer David Payne and later while biffing spinner Harsh Dubey for a 4 and 6 off successive deliveries.

The Karnataka batter fetched his fifty off just 21 balls with a four off Harshal Patel. Kohli brought out his swat, a shot with minimum feet movement and shot arm-thrown, against pacers Jaydev

Unadkat and Eshan Malinga as runs flowed thick and fast - team 50 came in fourth over, Power Play produced 76 and 100 cascaded in just 8.1 overs. But the free-flowing alliance was snapped when Padikkal was holed out to Heinrich Klaasen, who had earlier spilled Kohli on 28 off RCB alumni Harshal, at long-on.

Kohli soon reached his half-century off 33 balls with a single off left-arm seamer Payne. Skipper Rajat Patidar did his bit for a smooth chase, waltzing to a 12-ball 31.

The consecutive dismissals of Patidar and Jitesh Sharma were just minor speed-breakers in an otherwise easy journey, laced by Kohli's sequence of 6, 4, 4, 4 off



Royal Challengers Bengaluru's Virat Kohli plays a shot during an IPL 2026 T20 cricket match between Royal Challengers Bengaluru and Sunrisers Hyderabad at the M Chinnaswamy Stadium in Bengaluru on Saturday

Harshal. Earlier, stand-in captain Ishan Kishan smashed a blazing fifty as Sunrisers resisted Jacob Duffy's excellent spell but only managed a slightly below-par 201 for nine.

Kishan (80, 38b, 8x4, 5x6) and his 97-run stand with Heinrich Klaasen (31) for the fourth wicket was the core of SRH innings.

But the match had a rather different start once Patidar asked Hyderabad to bat first on a pitch that was deprived of top-flight cricket for nearly 10 months.

The pitch would have been a rather unknown commodity and chasing was a better option in that context.

Duffy's spell (4-0-22-3) vindicated that thought too.

The Kiwi pacer used his height well to generate considerable bounce off the track and Abhishek Sharma (7) looked frustrated not being able to free his arm despite carving Duffy for a six over backward point.

The left-hander, who has always been uncomfortable against short balls, soon fell to his frustrations as his awkward pull off Duffy ended in the big gloves of Jitesh Sharma.

Earlier, RCB had burned a DRS review for caught behind appeal against Abhishek off Duffy in the very first over.

Travis Head and Nitish Kumar Reddy too failed to control their pull shots off Duffy as SRH slipped to 29 for three in 4.2 overs. (PTI)

Nelly Korda hits her stride and builds 2-shot lead in Phoenix

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Phoenix (USA)

Nelly Korda was just as good in the tougher afternoon conditions on Friday, posting a 7-under 65 for the lowest 36-hole score of her LPGA Tour career and building a two-shot lead at the halfway point of the Ford Championship.

Korda missed an opportunity late to stretch her lead a little more when she missed a 2-foot birdie putt on the par-5 17th.

But this was not a day to complain on the Cattail course at Whirlwind Golf Club. She followed a great opening round — something Lydia Ko failed to do — with

a steady diet of birdie chances and a smooth, confident stroke with the putter.

"I have left a couple shots out there at the end," Korda said. "But I'm playing really solid golf, and when I do make a mistake, I try not to let it faze me too much."

She was at 16-under 128, two shots ahead of a familiar face. Hyo Joo Kim, the defending champion in Phoenix, won last week at the Founders Cup by holding off Korda in the final hour. Korda missed a short putt on the 17th hole Sunday that thwarted hopes of a second straight win to start the year.

Kim, who opened with a 61, overcame a mistakes early to post a 69. Saturday



will be the fourth straight round for Korda and Kim to play in the same group.

"Just getting sick of each other now," Korda said with a laugh. "Yeah, she's playing such solid golf. At the end of the day that's something that motivates me to want to stay with her at that level. We're just going back and forth, so it's nice. At the end of the day we're competitors, but we are very friendly. I've always enjoyed playing with her. I'm always mesmerised by her putting."

Ko shot a 60 in morning

conditions of the first round and doesn't feel as though she played that much differently — except the putts turned away at the last second or burned the edge. She made so many putts in her opening round, and only enough on Friday for a 71 that left her three shots behind along with Jenny Bae (65) and Minami Katsu (66).

The final hole summed up her day - a good drive, a good approach, and a 12-foot putt that good all the way until it peeled away to the right.

"I just didn't really hole many putts today," Ko said. "It's obviously harder to get closer to the pins just playing in the afternoon and the greens being a little firmer. I

think I struggled with a couple of the short ones. But that's golf, right? I can't control everything. Yesterday was I think more of the surprise I think just shooting a score like that."

She still found herself right in the mix and Ko figures everything will balance out. "I feel like my game is trending in the right direction," she said.

Asterisk Talley, the 17-year-old amateur, had a 65 and was in the group six shots behind at 10 under. Talley will be going to the home of the Masters next week to compete in the Augusta National Women's Amateur, which she had a chance to win last year.

Commemorative plaque unveiled at MCA museum

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

A commemorative plaque was unveiled by former BCCI and ICC president Sharad Pawar at the MCA Museum here to mark the birth centenary of former India player Polly Umrigar.

The plaque pays tribute to the legend, who played 59 Tests between 1948 and 1962 and captained India in eight of them, and who also served the game with distinction as both a player and an administrator. "Polly Umrigar's contribution to Indian cricket is truly monumental, and it is



our privilege to honour his legacy in his birth centenary year," said MCA president Ajinkya Naik. "This commemorative installation at the MCA Sharad Pawar Cricket Museum is a tribute to his remarkable achievements and enduring influence on the game," he added.

Gary surges to a 3-shot lead at Houston Open



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Houston (USA)

Gary Woodland felt a weight lifted from speaking publicly about his mental health struggles, and he looked freer than ever Friday with a 7-under 63 in the Houston Open to build a three-shot lead going into the weekend at Memorial Park.

Woodland sounded more pleased with not getting down about one bad swing than his finish of three straight birdies that allowed him to build some separation. He was at 13-under 127, three ahead of Nicolai Hjuggaard (62) and Jackson Suber (63) on a comfortable day of good scoring for most everyone.

Brooks Koepka was an exception. Coming off a 75 marred by three double bogeys in the first round, Koepka had a triple bogey on the par-3 second hole, his 11th of the day. He shot 69 to miss the cut for the second time since his return from LIV Golf.

Woodland wasn't dialled in off the tee, hitting only five fairways, but Memorial Park has enough room to let it fly and he was rarely out of

position. He finished off his round with a wedge to 3 feet on the par-5 16th, a 15-foot birdie on the 17th and a 12-foot birdie on the 18th.

But what stuck with him was a tee shot he yanked into the water left of the 13th fairway, leading to a penalty drop and ultimately having to make a 4-foot putt to escape with bogey.

"I was proud of myself because what Randy Smith, my coach, calls an oops. I had a bad swing there on 13, and I've hit it so well the last couple days, I didn't let that bother me," Woodland said. "I told myself to forget about it and move on, and I was able to do that. That was a big change for me to let that go and keep doing what I've been doing the last couple days."

The 2019 US Open champion has been playing a well-rounded game, in control of his swing and confident on the greens after he realised his alignment was off and changed his putter to help.

Mostly, he feels big support and greater comfort following his decision to publicly talk about his battle with post-traumatic stress disorder.

Pant's openness to feedback helps in positive environment: Mitchell Marsh

KUSHAN SARKAR
■ New Delhi

Mitchell Marsh has heaped praise on Rishabh Pant's leadership, saying the skipper's openness to suggestions has been a key factor behind the positive environment within the Lucknow Super Giants (LSG) camp. LSG have two international captains in Marsh and Aiden Markram.

"It's just about contributing as best you can, being the best support possible for Rishabh. He's a great young guy who leads his team really well. He's always open to feedback, suggestions, and takes on board whatever you say," Marsh told PTI in an interview.

"We've got some really good leaders within the

group, which you need. And for me, it's about contributing where needed."

Emphasising his own approach, Marsh underlined that consistency and team impact remain his primary focus. "Just staying consistent with the way I prepare. Last year was obviously a good year for me personally in terms of my consistency. But the main thing for me is just, how can I impact this team positively and contribute to us winning as many games as possible."

Marsh also pointed to the role played by team owner Sanjiv Goenka and Pant in fostering a positive atmosphere. "It's been fantastic. Yeah, personally, last year felt very well looked after by the franchise. It feels no different this year. There's a lot of care



within our group and hopefully we can take that atmosphere and show people how much it means to play for LSG." On his on-field and off-field partnership with Markram, Marsh said the camaraderie developed naturally over time, with the duo also delivering strongly with the bat last season. Marsh

scored 627 runs and Markram contributing 445 runs in IPL 2025. "I absolutely loved my time last year with Aiden. We've obviously played against each other a lot in the past. And it's not until you're in the same team that you get to know someone. "And obviously, when you go in together, you need to have a

strong relationship both on the field and off the field. Last year showed that we became good friends off the field and were able to be a consistent partnership for this franchise."

Explaining their approach at the top of the order, Marsh stressed adaptability over rigid targets. "You know that some games, you're going to get off to a fine start. I think we had a few really big power plays last year. But you play the situation. "And you obviously try and have as much impact as you can and get us off to the best start possible. But yeah, we're not focused on necessarily a number."

Marsh also expressed confidence in the team's preparation. "Look, we've got a great coaching setup this year. Obviously, a few per-

sonnel changes, but I think as a coaching group, they've been great in helping the whole squad prepare for the first game, prepare for the tournament.

Reflecting on conditions at their home venue, Marsh recalled last season's batting-friendly surfaces at the Ekana Stadium. "Yeah, I actually thought the wicket last year was beautiful. We had multiple 200 scores here. And it was nice to be able to, I guess, play seven games at home and understand the conditions. "It's obviously a bigger ground than quite a few in India, which is probably why there's a few lower scores. "But the ground and the wicket itself last year was fantastic and I expect it to be the same this year," Marsh concluded. (PTI)

My only aim is to win matches: Angkrish

DEVARCHIT VARMA
■ Mumbai

Mumbai and Kolkata Knight Riders' batter Angkrish Raghuvanshi says he judges his performances with how his team fares while he keeps working on multiplying his skills as a top order-batter and wicketkeeper.

In a team which has New Zealand's Tim Seifert and uncapped Indian Tejasvi Dahiya as specialist wicket-keepers, Raghuvanshi's skills behind the wickets could be handy for Kolkata Knight Riders who like other teams will be challenged to find their right combination in early stages of the Indian Premier League. "My Mumbai T20 team needed me to keep and so I said why not?



It's a new challenge and I enjoyed it a lot and I've been practicing it quite a bit and we'll see what happens with it," Raghuvanshi told PTI in an exclusive interview.

With competition for spots in Indian teams across formats intensifying and specialist batters like Yashasvi Jaiswal and Tilak Varma also working on their bowling skills constantly, Raghuvanshi is in for the tough battle too. But he does not want to look at the competition just yet.

"I don't really think about that too much. I just think about improving my own game as much as I can," he said. "But yeah, it's a very dynamic game and so I'm always working on, along with my batting, my fielding skills and my wicket-keeping skills also. I'm just trying to improve day by day and learn and get as better as I can," Raghuvanshi added. (PTI)

Andhra Pradesh women win T10 cricket championship for deaf



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Gurugram

Andhra Pradesh women edged past a spirited Delhi side by five runs to clinch the 7th IDCA Women's T10 National Cricket Championship for the Deaf in a low-scoring encounter here.

Batting first, Andhra Pradesh posted 73 for 4. Delhi put up a strong fight in reply but

could only manage 68 for 4 in their allotted overs.

D Kanthamma of Andhra Pradesh was named both Player of the Match and Player of the Series for her performance. The Indian Deaf Cricket Association (IDCA) is supported by the BCCI and is recognised by the Deaf International Cricket Council and the Asian Deaf Cricket Association.

Praggnanandhaa braces for tough challenge as Candidates set to begin

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Paphos (Cyprus)

Grandmaster Rameshbabu Praggnanandhaa, India's sole representative in the Open section of the eight-player elite field, faces a challenging task as the Candidates Tournament gets underway on Sunday.

The event, which will determine over the course of a fortnight the challenger to reigning world champion D Gukesh in the next World Championship match later this year, will feature eight players competing in a double round-robin format.

Each player will face every other participant twice, and the one with the highest



total points will earn the right to compete for the world title. Going by recent form, American GM Fabiano Caruana appears to be the favourite, ahead of compatriot Hikaru Nakamura, who qualified through his rating. Dutch Grandmaster Anish Giri has also been in good form and is one to watch; if he gets going, he will be a formidable contender.

Wei Yi of China, Javokhir Sindarov of Uzbekistan, Andrey Esipenko, and Matthias Bluebaum are the other four players in what is likely to be one of the most keenly contested and widely followed tournaments of the year. For Praggnanandhaa, the lead-up to the Candidates

has not been entirely smooth. However, the Indian should feel refreshed after a well-deserved long break since the Tata Steel Chess Tournament in February, the young Grandmaster has not played any competitive chess and has instead been preparing for this event with his team. After an impressive 2025, in which he qualified for the Candidates by finishing as the top performer on the FIDE circuit, the latter part of the year saw an unusual dip in Praggnanandhaa's form, a trend that continued into the Tata Steel Masters earlier this year.

The Indian will be hoping to turn the tide and make things fall as per his scheme.

The dark horse of the event is the youngest participant, Sindarov, who surprised everyone by winning the Chess World Cup in Goa late last year. Sindarov possesses both the acumen and the fighting spirit to go the distance, and although this is his first Candidates appearance, the Uzbek will be raring to go.

Wei Yi can be tricky but much would depend on how many games he wins. Along with Giri, the Chinese is a great defender and known for his solidity. Esipenko may not be considered a major threat in this field, but he remains a dangerous opponent on his day. Meanwhile, the lowest-ranked participant, Bluebaum, is clearly

the outsider, though he has been a consistent performer.

In the women's section, former women's world champion Tan Zhongyi of China has an edge over others but things could get tricky here as well.

Following the withdrawal of two-time world rapid champion Koneru Humpy due to security concerns, Anna Muzychuk — last year's Norway Chess winner — has replaced the Indian. However, all eyes will be on Divya Deshmukh, who won the Women's World Cup in 2025. R. Vaishali is the other Indian in the fray and she is known to be a fearless warrior who only craves for victories.



The Breathing Mirror

As we celebrated World Theatre Day: the last place where we truly feel human again. It is a raw, physical riot against our cold, digital isolation, says SAKSHI PRIYA

An entire lifetime ago, Thornton Wilder managed to perfectly pin down this exact feeling. He looked at the theatre as the absolute greatest of all art forms, simply because it stands as the most immediate, visceral way one person can actually share the raw experience of being human with somebody else. That was long before we started losing entire nights glued to the living room furniture. We scroll blindly through digital feeds, desperate for human contact. We tap a filtered picture of someone we do not even know and call it a community. Meanwhile, we completely ignore the original room built specifically for shared emotion. Look back at the Greeks to see how it is supposed to work. They lacked screens. They physically carved massive stone arenas right out of the dirt and rock. Then thousands of them packed in tight under the open sky just to watch a story unfold in real time. It served as a civic duty and a massive festival at the same time. Actors wore huge masks to throw their voices to the top tiers. The whole city shut down just to feel something together.

Sitting across from veteran director Arvind Gaur on World Theatre Day, you quickly realise he operates on this exact frequency. He told me that despite our shrinking digital attention spans, the physical stage remains the most accurate mirror we have for our social and political reality. Gaur insists that the canvas is actually growing because the youth are flooding into the medium



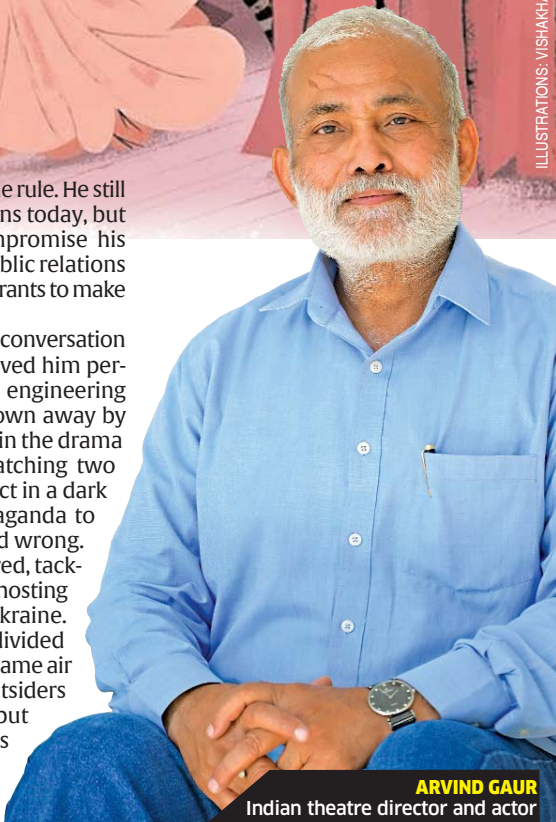
Theatre has the power of direct communication with the audience. Screens are virtual, indirect. On stage, there is this energy exchange between the two which is immediate and impactful. Cinema needs many tropes like close ups and atmospheric music to have that effect, which an actor can have through simple gestures and expressions, on stage.

— SOHAILA KAPUR (Indian theatre director and actor)

to open up the dreams of the next generation. He refuses to keep his work locked inside overpriced halls. Gaur shared how his group takes performances directly into slums and college courtyards to force conversations that society wants to ignore. He spoke passionately about a play called *Ajivika* that actively convinced families to stop sending their daughters into domestic labour. Instead, his theatre group trained thousands of these young girls as commercial taxi drivers across Delhi and Jaipur. His street plays also became the quiet backbone of massive social movements, mobilising thousands of angry youths during the Nirbhaya protests without a single act of violence breaking out on the streets because the raw emotion was channelled into the performance.

Yet the system constantly throws up barricades to silence this kind of raw truth. Gaur recounted a gruelling eight-month fight against archaic British licensing laws that forced actors to pay a thousand rupees and secure police passports just to perform a simple play. He relentlessly argued with authorities and wrote legal articles until the government finally scrapped the rule. He still fights against heavy tax burdens today, but he absolutely refuses to compromise his morals by taking corporate public relations jobs or restrictive government grants to make his life easier.

The most striking part of our conversation was hearing how the stage saved him personally. Gaur was an angry engineering dropout who felt entirely thrown away by society until he found a home in the drama world. He explained how watching two people tear into a bitter conflict in a dark room strips away daily propaganda to leave a stark sense of right and wrong. The stage keeps him anchored, tackling everything from internet ghosting to the brutality of the war in Ukraine. Theatre physically forces a divided audience to breathe the exact same air and face their shared flaws. Outsiders might see a humble art form, but Arvind Gaur proves it remains the last space capable of taking fractured strangers and quietly making them human again.



ARVIND GAUR Indian theatre director and actor

THE ORIGINAL ROOM

Gaur believes theatre is the greatest art form because of its “immediacy.” In an era of thumb-numbing scrolls, theatre is the original shared room. “People claim the audience is shrinking because of social media,” he says, leaning in. “I don’t buy it.” He points to a recent show of Court Martial where 150 people were turned away at the door. If the story matters, the people show up. It’s that simple. Theatre has always been a mirror to society — social, political, economic. You cannot separate the play from the people.



PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

A fierce modern rebellion

Back in 2007, a quiet search for the last remaining needles saved a dying art from a certain death

SAKSHI PRIYA

Five centuries ago, women across the plains of rural Punjab began counting threads, relying entirely on their eyes and hands to build complex floral embroidery from scratch without the use of tracing stencils or stamps. Born in a region that experienced as much brutal conflict as grand celebration, this craft known as Phulkari slowly became a quiet language of resistance and resilience for the women who carefully stitched it.

That exact fifteenth-century technique is currently experiencing a vibrant revival in New Delhi, as The Nabha Foundation and HMEI bring the ‘Phulkari of Punjab’ showcase to the National Crafts Museum. Walking through the exhibition space, visitors find rare, breathtaking Baghs displayed alongside generations-old shawls and dupattas, offering a stunning visual history where the true heartbeat of the event remains the rural artisans themselves.

Following the early philanthropic vision of Princess Jeet Nabha Khemka, the Foundation began a dedicated effort back in 2007 to track down artisans and save the authentic darn-stitch method before it vanished entirely. What began as a quiet rescue effort for a fading art form has blossomed into a self-sustaining livelihood programme, with Executive Director Shubhra Singh noting that over 400 women from marginalised households across Punjab currently earn a dignified living while their artistry catches global attention.

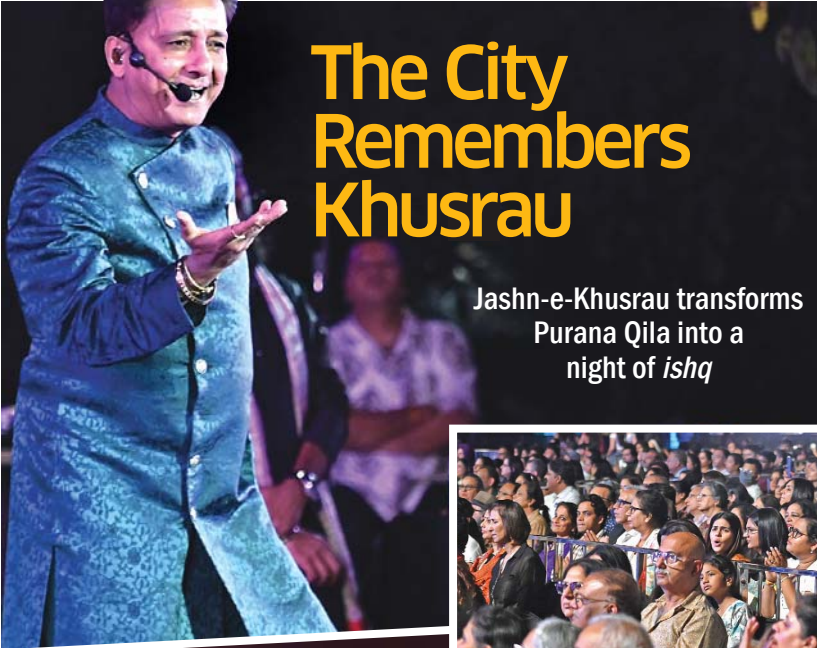
The runway segment pushed those traditional

boundaries even further when designer Pratima Pandey introduced a collaborative collection called *Marzi*, a word that translates to choice and fierce independence. Pandey played around with grids and spaces to capture different stories while bending the old rules entirely, sending women down the ramp wearing silhouettes traditionally reserved for menswear.

Sheer Chanderi skirts brought a gentle flow to the structured cropped jackets, while an aboriginal-style saree and a retro knee-length dhoti offered a clear nod to the classic lungi.

The rural women practising this craft daily remain the absolute core of the showcase as lifting a deeply historical tradition and grounding it firmly on a modern runway. Seeing these ancient threads effortlessly own a contemporary runway leaves you wondering exactly what other forgotten cultural stories are out there waiting to be unspooled.

YET THE NEEDLES KEEP MOVING IN PUNJAB. THESE OLD THREADS ARE CHANGING CONTEMPORARY FASHION. IT FORCES AN OBVIOUS QUESTION. WHAT OTHER FORGOTTEN STORIES ARE WAITING TO BE UNSPOOLED?



Jashn-e-Khusrau transforms Purana Qila into a night of *ishq*



but cannot touch. This Safar-e-Ishq is a journey through the dark toward a light only the seekers see. Inside these massive walls, the city noise dies. A single, rhythmic pulse takes over. The sun dips below the fort. The energy on the ground stays red hot. Sanjukta Sinha claimed the stage first. Her Kathak was a lightning strike right against the old ruins. Her feet hit the floor

TEAM VIVA

Delhi dirt has a long memory. It stores eight hundred years of Sufi prayers right in its grain. These jagged red rocks at Purana Qila have seen empires fall. They have seen kings turn to dust. But the music of Amir Khusrau stayed. The quiet grace of Nizamuddin Auliya never left. For twenty-six years, Muzaffar Ali has curated this experience to keep the flame alive, presented by the Rumi Foundation. Jahan-e-Khusrau feels like a raw, physical connection. It joins the person in the crowd to something much older. The modern world outside the gates feels small now.

The story this year is the *Steed of Longing*. Think of a horse. It is a heart that cannot stay still. A soul galloping toward a love it feels

with power. It forced thousands to hold their breath. Her white silk garment was a whirlwind. A flash against the dark shadows. Then Lakhwinder Wadali brought the rough grain of Punjab. His voice carries an ancient weight. He sang of the saints. The notes dissolved into the night. The stillness died when Sukhwinder Singh took over. The second *Chaiyya Chaiyya* hit, the rules broke. People stood up. They forgot the chairs. His voice made the ancient fort gates vibrate. Pure, raw joy.

The peak happens tonight. Rajasthan desert dust lands on stage with Jasu Khan Bisu. The air waits for the heavy weight of Hans Raj Hans. For the grace of Manjari Chaturvedi. Soon, Shivani Varna pulls the city’s history into the light through her dance. Then comes Satinder Sartaaj. The poet from Hoshiarpur. He carries the wisdom of old masters in his throat. His voice hits the soul first. Then the ears. He sings of the inward path. Of the horse that never stops running toward love. The air in the Qila tonight is different. It is the sound of a story coming home.

Na raasta maloom hai, na manzil ki fikar hai, Bas ishq ki lau hai, aur tera hi zikar hai. The road is unknown. The destination is forgotten. Only the fire of love remains.

The man who made the world listen



PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

TEAM VIVA

For decades, Ustad Zakir Hussain completely controlled how the world understood Indian classical music. He played with a raw complexity that connected continents. He marked generations permanently. Now, that immense weight of silence rests over Sunder Nursery in New Delhi. The Kiran Nadar Museum of Art launched ‘The Way Forward’. Over three days, the entire event settled into a deep, quiet space of memory.

MT Aditya Srinivasan conceptualised this gathering. He worked for years as the live sound engineer for Shakti, so he understood the man behind the music better than most. That sense of direct connection runs through the entire programme. Crowds spend their time standing in silence before Dayanita Singh’s photography. Her images strip away the fame to reveal a tired, laughing, hardworking artist in his green room. Over the last two evenings, Pt Yogesh Samsi and Ranjit Barot brought a fierce energy to the

stage that left the ground beneath the audience humming.

Today, the festival moves towards its final, quiet conclusion. Visitors gather this afternoon to watch Sumantra Ghosal’s documentary, *The Speaking Hand*, which offers a rare glimpse into the maestro’s journey. Later this evening, Anantha R Krishnan leads the ‘Mellow Rhythms’ performance. He steers a soft, careful musical exchange alongside Charumathi Raghuraman and Ramana Balachandran.

Shobana Chandrakumar eventually takes the stage to shut down the festival. Her closing Bharatanatyam piece exists solely as a final nod to the maestro. The maestro is gone. But that restless, brilliant timing pushes through the air with every strike of the drum. If the music still moves like he did, is he really gone at all? Or is the whole gathering just part of a pulse that started decades ago and refuses to end?

KUMARI GAUTAMI ARYA DURING ‘TAAL VANDANA’ BY PT YOGESH SAMSI DURING THE WAY FORWARD



IN TRENDS



BTS RECLAIMS THE THRONE

TEAM VIVA

After a four-year military hiatus, the kings of K-pop are completely dominating the globe again. BTS paralyzed central Seoul last weekend with their massive *Arirang* comeback show. The guys pulled over 100,000 fans to Gwanghwamun Square. Millions more caught the historic Netflix livestream. So, why are they breaking the internet right now? Their new album moved an insane four million copies on day one. The lead single, “Swim,” is currently topping the charts. Honestly, it goes way beyond the music. Financial experts are already buzzing about “BTSnomics,” predicting their upcoming world tour could generate billions. Their cultural grip is clearly stronger than ever.



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Bureaucracy is not an obstacle to democracy but an inevitable complement to it.
— Joseph A Schumpeter

...the Civil reforms for Indian Public Services

As rapid technological change, rising citizen expectations, and evolving policy challenges continue to reshape governance, the need to reform India’s civil services has never been more urgent. Long regarded as the steel frame of governance, the civil services today face criticism for inefficiencies, rigid structures, and a growing disconnect with grassroots realities. A comprehensive reform plan – spanning recruitment, training, career management, and systemic restructuring – must be undertaken to create a more responsive, accountable, and future-ready administrative machinery

India’s civil services system, once celebrated for its meritocratic rigour and administrative depth, is now confronting structural and functional challenges. From an examination process that rewards rote learning to a career progression system that often fails to align talent with roles, the cracks are increasingly visible. The experience of aspirants, the preparedness of officers, and the efficiency of governance outcomes all point to the need for a holistic overhaul.

Reform the selection process

At the heart of the issue lies the current recruitment mechanism. The civil services examination, conducted by the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC), has long been criticised for its overemphasis on theoretical knowledge and memorisation. While academic rigour is essential, governance in the real world demands a wider array of competencies – practical decision-making, ethical reasoning, leadership, and emotional intelligence. Aspirants often spend four to six years preparing for the examination, with the average age of entry steadily rising above 28. This prolonged preparation cycle not only delays entry into public service but also diverts youthful energy into a narrow examination-focused pursuit. Moreover, the recruitment process itself can stretch up to 18 months, further delaying the induction of fresh talent.

Experts suggest a shift towards a multi-dimensional evaluation system. Incorporating situational judgment tests, role-playing exercises, and psychometric assessments could help gauge a candidate’s aptitude for real-world administrative challenges. Simulated assessment centres replicating governance dilemmas may provide deeper insights into decision-making abilities. Additionally, reforms such as a unified candidate management system - integrating various stages from application to appointment – and the use of emerging technologies like blockchain for document verification could significantly streamline the recruitment cycle, reducing delays and uncertainty.

Aspirant experience

Another pressing concern is the mismatch between candidate preferences and service allocation. Only a small percentage of candidates secure their desired services, leading to dissatisfaction and, in some cases, repeated attempts even after selection. This not only burdens the system but also results in inefficient utilisation of human resources.

The psychological toll on aspirants is equally significant. Years of preparation, coupled with uncertain outcomes, often lead to stress, disillusionment, and a sense of failure. The “all-or-nothing” mindset - where elite services such as the IAS, IPS, and IFS are seen as the only worthwhile goals – further narrows career aspirations. To address these issues, policymakers are advocating a more flexible and aspirant-friendly approach. A two-tier examination system with service-specific components could better align candidate interests with job roles. Introducing lateral movement within services after a few years of experience would also allow officers to recalibrate their career paths. Equally important is the need to recognise UPSC preparation as a valuable learning experience.

There is a need to dismantle and shun all the nomenclatures that Bharath has inherited from colonial masters. When the Government of India led by Prime Minister Narendra Modi has moved ahead with renaming the most powerful PMO as Sewa Teerth, PM residence as Lok Kalyan Marg, Rajpath as Kartavya Path and Central Secretariat as Kartvya Bhawan, Raj Bhawan as Lok Bhawan and above all a New Parliament as Sansad Bhawan, it is time to change the name of all services aligned with prevalent accountability as “Indian Public Service”

REMARKS BY A FORMER CABINET SECRETARY

Certification mechanisms and structured career counselling could open alternative pathways for aspirants, ensuring that their efforts are not rendered futile. Psychological support systems and public awareness campaigns highlighting the importance of all public services can help reshape perceptions and reduce undue pressure.

Change the nomenclature

There is a need to dismantle and discard the nomenclature inherited from colonial rule. The Government of India has already taken steps in this direction by renaming the PMO as *Sewa Teerath*, the Prime Minister’s residence address as Lok Kalyan Marg, Rajpath as Kartavya Path, the Central Secretariat as Kartavya Bhawan, and Raj Bhawan as Lok Bhawan.

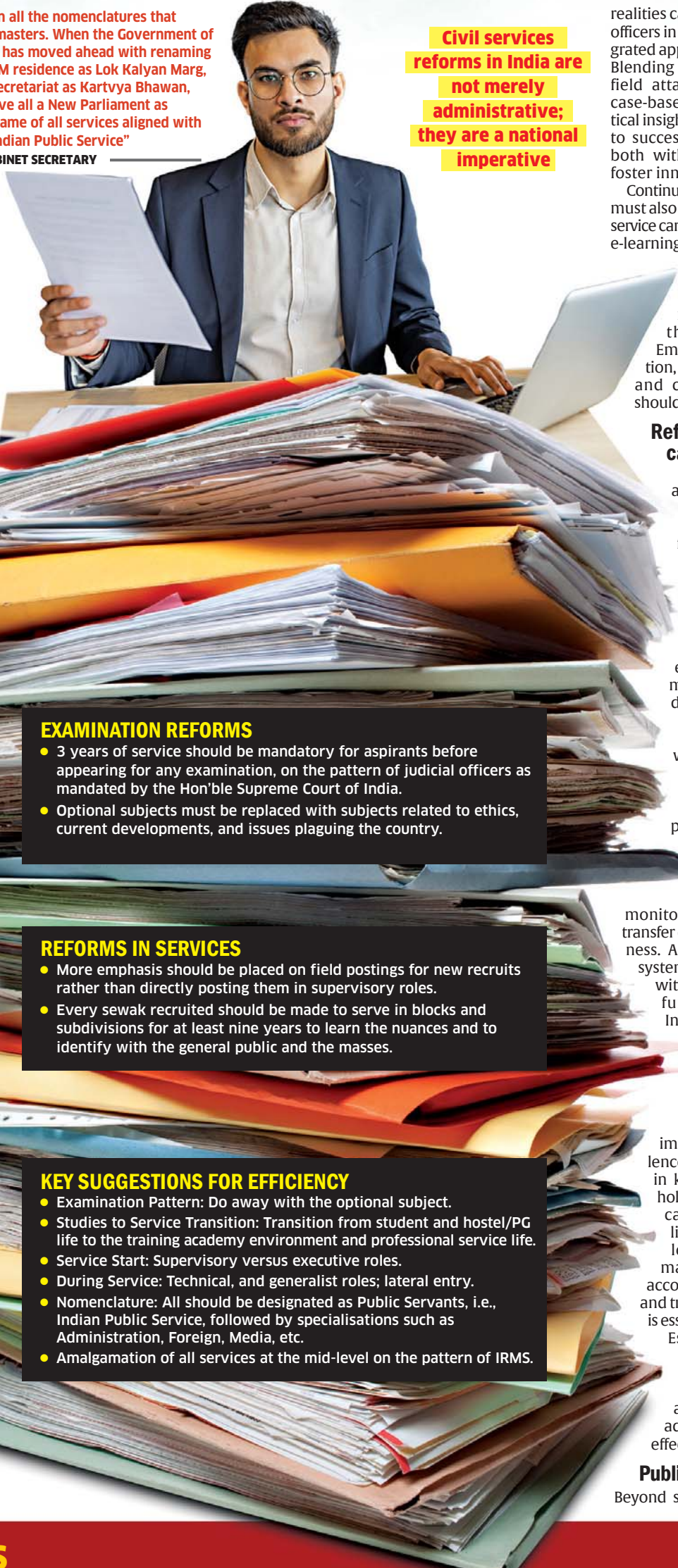
Under the Constitution of India, there are three categories of services:

- A. All India Services
- B. Central Civil Services
- C. Military Services

The most important examination conducted by the Union Public Service Commission is the Civil Services Examination, which traces its origins to the Imperial Civil Service. Through this examination, officers are selected for around 23 services. The Commission also conducts separate pan-India examinations to recruit engineers, economists, and statisticians; intriguingly, these roles are not formally classified as part of the civil services. Under the Indian Penal Code, immunity is granted to public servants for acts performed in good faith, while no such explicit immunity is extended to civil servants as a distinct category. This raises an important question: is it time to revisit and rename these services to reflect contemporary accountability structures? One possible approach could be to replace the traditional nomenclature with “Indian Public Service,” followed by the relevant field or area of expertise, and to redefine officers as *sewaks*, emphasizing service over authority.

Strengthening training

The transition from selection to service is another area ripe for reform. Current training modules are often criticised for being overly theoretical, with limited exposure to real-world challenges. This gap between classroom learning and field



Civil services reforms in India are not merely administrative; they are a national imperative

EXAMINATION REFORMS

- 3 years of service should be mandatory for aspirants before appearing for any examination, on the pattern of judicial officers as mandated by the Hon’ble Supreme Court of India.
- Optional subjects must be replaced with subjects related to ethics, current developments, and issues plaguing the country.

REFORMS IN SERVICES

- More emphasis should be placed on field postings for new recruits rather than directly posting them in supervisory roles.
- Every *sewak* recruited should be made to serve in blocks and subdivisions for at least nine years to learn the nuances and to identify with the general public and the masses.

KEY SUGGESTIONS FOR EFFICIENCY

- Examination Pattern: Do away with the optional subject.
- Studies to Service Transition: Transition from student and hostel/PG life to the training academy environment and professional service life.
- Service Start: Supervisory versus executive roles.
- During Service: Technical, and generalist roles; lateral entry.
- Nomenclature: All should be designated as Public Servants, i.e., Indian Public Service, followed by specialisations such as Administration, Foreign, Media, etc.
- Amalgamation of all services at the mid-level on the pattern of IRMS.

realities can hinder the effectiveness of officers in their early years. A more integrated approach to training is essential. Blending academic instruction with field attachments, internships, and case-based learning can provide practical insights into governance. Exposure to successful administrative models, both within India and abroad, can foster innovation and adaptability.

Continuous professional development must also become a cornerstone of civil service careers. Regular refresher courses, e-learning modules, and mentorship programmes involving senior and retired officers can ensure that officers remain updated and effective throughout their tenure. Emphasis on technology adoption, data-driven decision-making, and citizen-centric governance should be central to these initiatives.

Reforming posting and career management

One of the most contentious aspects of civil service functioning is the system of postings and transfers. Frequent transfers, often influenced by political or bureaucratic considerations, disrupt continuity and undermine accountability. Officers are sometimes assigned roles that do not align with their skills or expertise, leading to suboptimal outcomes. Reforms in this domain must prioritise transparency and meritocracy. Fixed tenure norms, coupled with performance-based evaluations, can provide stability and encourage long-term planning. Mandatory field postings before higher administrative assignments would ensure that officers gain grassroots experience.

The use of technology to monitor performance and inform transfer decisions can reduce arbitrariness. A robust cadre management system that matches officers’ skills with departmental needs would further enhance efficiency. Insulating the posting process from undue political interference remains a critical, albeit challenging, objective.

Issue of officiating roles
A less discussed but equally important issue is the prevalence of officiating appointments in key positions. When officers hold important posts in an acting capacity, it often results in limited authority and a lack of long-term vision. Decision-making becomes cautious, and accountability is diluted. Timely and transparent filling of vacancies is essential to address this problem. Establishing strict timelines for regular appointments and empowering officers in interim roles with adequate authority can help maintain administrative continuity and effectiveness.

Public service ethos

Beyond structural reforms, there is a

pressing need to transform the mindset within the bureaucracy. A rule-bound, procedure-driven approach often overshadows the larger goal of public service. Resistance to change, lack of empathy, and limited citizen engagement continue to be areas of concern. Reducing the academic burden of optional subjects in the examination and placing greater emphasis on general studies and essays could help level the playing field and focus on broader competencies. Training programmes must actively inculcate values of empathy, integrity, and service orientation. Innovative and citizen-friendly initiatives should be recognised and rewarded. Mechanisms such as 360-degree feedback – including inputs from citizens and stakeholders – can provide a more holistic assessment of an officer’s performance. Expanding e-governance platforms and facilitating direct interaction between officers and citizens can further strengthen accountability and responsiveness.

Aligning bureaucracy with policy priorities

The relationship between political leadership and the bureaucracy is another critical dimension. At times, the administrative machinery is perceived as slow or misaligned with government priorities, leading to delays in policy implementation. Bridging this gap requires structured engagement. Regular orientation sessions on policy priorities, joint task forces for key initiatives, and real-time monitoring through technology dashboards can enhance coordination. Clear key performance indicators (KPIs) linked to government goals can foster an outcome-oriented culture. Strengthening inter-departmental coordination mechanisms will also be crucial in addressing complex, cross-sectoral challenges.

Systemic and structural change

Finally, broader systemic reforms are necessary to address deep-rooted inefficiencies. Over-centralisation and rigid hierarchies often stifle innovation and delay decision-making. Decentralising authority and empowering lower-level officials can improve responsiveness and foster innovation. Simplifying procedures through digitalisation and e-governance can reduce delays and enhance transparency. Granting greater autonomy to specialised agencies, within a framework of accountability, can improve efficiency and expertise. Public-private partnerships offer another avenue for innovation in service delivery. Additionally, leveraging the experience of retired civil servants through structured engagement frameworks can provide valuable insights in policy-making, training, and advisory roles.

The road ahead

Civil services reforms in India are not merely an administrative necessity - they are a national imperative. As governance challenges become more complex and citizen expectations continue to rise, the need for a dynamic, responsive, and ethical bureaucracy is paramount. The proposed reforms, while ambitious, are both timely and achievable. They require political will, institutional commitment, and a willingness to embrace change.

A special Pioneer feature, with inputs from senior bureaucrats and retired government officials

TIME TO REVAMP THE CIVIL SERVICES

The recruitment age for the Civil Services has increased steadily over the years and is now above 28. In contrast, most students complete their undergraduate studies at around 21 or 22. As a result, many aspirants spend an additional four to six years preparing for the examination, sometimes alongside further studies. This raises an important question: can candidates be required to gain two to three years of work experience before attempting the Civil Services?
Recently, the Hon’ble Supreme Court of India mandated

that advocates must have three years of court experience before becoming eligible for appointment as judicial officers. On similar lines, such a provision could be considered for the Civil Services as well. Successful candidates are entrusted with implementing policies and programmes of both the Union and State governments. They also perform a wide range of responsibilities, including administrative, judicial, magisterial, and quasi-judicial functions.
Each year, nearly one million applicants compete for around

1,000 posts across various ministries and departments of the Government of India, resulting in a selection rate of just 0.1 per cent. There are approximately 36 organised services under the Government of India, of which 28 recruit officers through the Civil Services Examination annually. The entire recruitment cycle—from the release of the notification to the joining of officers in their respective academies—takes over one and a half years. Moreover, many successful candidates who do not secure

their preferred service reappear in subsequent attempts until they either obtain it or exhaust their chances. In reality, only about 30 per cent of selected candidates are fully satisfied with their allocation. This leads to an increased burden on the recruitment system, inefficient use of valuable human resources due to repeated preparation, and staffing gaps in departments. It also leaves many candidates with a lingering sense of dissatisfaction or failure that can persist throughout their lives.

KEY LEGAL AND CONDUCT RULES

- All India Services (Conduct) Rules, 1968: Govern IAS, IPS, and IFS officers, mandating absolute integrity, honesty, and politeness in public dealings.
- Central Civil Services (Conduct Rules, 1964: Applies to most other central civil servants,

focusing on high ethical standards.

- Constitutional Provisions: Articles 310 (Doctrine of Pleasure) and 311 (safeguards against arbitrary dismissal) define tenure, while Article 312 provides for the creation of All India Services.

“YOU HAVE EVERYTHING YOU NEED FOR
COMPLETE PEACE AND TOTAL
HAPPINESS RIGHT NOW”
— WAYNE W DYER

Strong Indian representation marks Bangladesh’s 56th Independence day celebrations in New Delhi

Bangladesh’s 56th Independence and National Day celebrations at its High Commission in the capital witnessed a significant and high-profile turnout from the Indian establishment, underlining the depth and importance of bilateral ties.

The event saw the prominent presence of Minister of State for External Affairs Kirti Vardhan Singh, along with Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri. Senior officials from the Ministry of External Affairs, including a Joint Secretary and official spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal, were also in attendance, reflecting strong institutional engagement from India’s foreign policy establishment.

The gathering brought together a diverse cross-section of India’s political and diplomatic community. Members of Parliament from multiple political parties attended the event, signalling bipartisan recognition of Bangladesh’s importance as a regional partner. The diplomatic corps was well represented, with several envoys and senior diplomats from various countries joining the celebrations.

Adding to the significance of the evening was the notable presence of the media. A large number of journalists and news organisations covered the event, capturing both the ceremonial aspects and the broader diplomatic messaging.

The strong turnout from India’s political leadership, bureaucracy, diplomatic community, and media served to reinforce the central theme of the evening: the enduring and multifaceted partnership between India and Bangladesh. Observers noted that such visible engagement reflects not only shared history but also a forward-looking commitment to deepen cooperation across sectors.

As Bangladesh marked over five decades of independence, the scale and stature of participation at the New Delhi event highlighted the continued relevance of the relationship in shaping regional stability, connectivity, and shared prosperity.

The High Commission of Bangladesh in New Delhi hosted a solemn yet forward-looking celebration to mark the country’s 56th Independence and National Day, bringing together diplomats, political leaders, officials, cultural figures, and friends of Bangladesh. The event blended remembrance of a painful past with a confident vision for the future anchored in democracy, regional cooperation, and enduring ties with India. The ceremony began with a heartfelt tribute to the martyrs of the 1971 Liberation War, a defining chapter in South Asian history. Bangladesh’s independence was born



ASHOKE RAJ

out of a nine-month struggle marked by immense human suffering and resistance against the Pakistani military regime.

Speakers paid homage to the countless men and women who sacrificed their lives, endured atrocities, and stood firm for dignity, identity, and sovereignty. The role of the Mukti Bahini—the guerrilla resistance force—was highlighted, along with the critical support extended by India during the war. Particular mention was made of Ziaur Rahman, who issued the Declaration of Independence on behalf of the nation. The sacrifices of 1,668 Indian soldiers who lost their lives on Bangladeshi soil were also remembered with deep gratitude, underscoring a shared history forged in struggle.

A key highlight of this year’s celebration was the strong and high-level representation from the Indian establishment, reflecting the importance New Delhi attaches to its relationship with Dhaka. The event emphasised the “unique and multidimensional” relationship between Bangladesh and India—one that transcends political and economic ties to encompass deep cultural and

INDIA HIGHLIGHTS ENDURING PARTNERSHIP AT BANGLADESH’S 56TH INDEPENDENCE DAY

India underscored its deep-rooted and evolving partnership with Bangladesh at the 56th Independence Day celebrations hosted by High Commissioner Riaz Hamidullah. Minister of State for External Affairs Kirti Vardhan Singh said, “The Liberation War of 1971 and the sacrifices made remain a shared legacy that continues to guide our partnership based on trust, shared values, and commitment to peace and prosperity.” Referring to the Bangladesh Liberation War, he highlighted growing cooperation in connectivity, trade, and development, while welcoming leadership under Tarique Rahman.

historical connections.

From literature and cinema to science and music, the shared heritage of the two nations was celebrated through references to iconic figures such as Rabindranath Tagore, Kazi Nazrul Islam, Satyajit Ray, and Ravi Shankar.

The historic Concert for Bangladesh was recalled as a pivotal moment that drew global attention to the liberation struggle, reframing it from a regional conflict to a humanitarian crisis. The address highlighted Bangladesh’s recent national elections, where approximately 76 million citizens participated in what was described as a peaceful and participatory democratic exercise.

In the lead-up to the polls, high-level exchanges between India and Bangladesh reinforced bilateral goodwill. India’s External Affairs Minister

Subrahmanyam Jaishankar attended the funeral of former Prime Minister Khaleda Zia in Dhaka, while Indian leaders including Rajnath Singh and Om Birla participated in key ceremonial engagements. Bangladesh’s current leadership, under Prime Minister Tarique Rahman, has articulated a “Bangladesh First” vision, while reaffirming a pragmatic and mutually respectful partnership with India.

Bangladesh reiterated its commitment to strengthening ties with India based on equality, mutual trust, and shared benefits. In a recent message to Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Prime Minister Rahman emphasised the importance of advancing bilateral engagement in ways that deliver tangible benefits to people on both sides of the border.



Economic cooperation remains a cornerstone of the relationship. While official bilateral trade stands at around \$12 billion, broader economic exchanges are estimated to reach up to \$30 billion annually, reflecting deep interdependence.

Beyond numbers, the emphasis is increasingly on people-to-people connections, youth aspirations, and region-

al development. With median ages of 27 in Bangladesh and 28 in India, the demographic alignment offers significant opportunities for collaboration in education, innovation, and employment. Amid global uncertainties, both nations expressed a shared commitment to uphold principles of open regionalism and multilateralism. The speech stressed that sensitive issues—whether related to trade, security, or natural resources—should be addressed with sincerity and transparency.

Bangladesh’s societal openness and democratic culture were also highlighted. Despite political contestation, the recent electoral process saw a convergence of public priorities around peace, stability, rule of law, and development—rather than religious divides.

The evening concluded on a poignant note with a tribute to Assamese music icon Zubeen Garg, who had expressed a wish to perform the national anthems of both countries—each penned by Tagore—at the event. His passing was mourned as a loss not just to Assam, but to the broader cultural fabric of the region.

His vision of transcending divisions through shared ecology, rivers, and human connection resonated deeply with the event’s theme.

As Bangladesh steps into its 56th year of independence, the message from New Delhi was clear: the future lies in cooperation, inclusivity, and shared growth.

The writer is an Associate Editor (Foreign Affairs) at The Pioneer

How American courts are rewriting the rules for Big Tech and children

Within 48 hours, the legal landscape governing social media and children shifted in ways that will take years to fully understand and verify. On March 24, 2026, a Santa Fe jury ordered Meta to pay US\$375 million for violating New Mexico’s consumer protection laws. The next day, a Los Angeles jury found Meta and Google’s YouTube negligent in the design of their platforms, awarding almost \$6 million in damages to a single plaintiff.

The dollar figures are drawing headlines, but a \$375 million penalty against a company worth \$1.5 trillion is a rounding error. Fines without structural change are more akin to licensing fees than accountability. The question of whether these verdicts will produce real changes to the products that millions of children use every day is more consequential than the jury awards.

Meta and Google have signalled they will appeal, and in the meantime, Instagram, Facebook and YouTube will continue to operate exactly as they did before the verdicts. The verdicts against Meta pave the way for hundreds or even thousands of similar cases.

Consumer protection

Most coverage framing the New Mexico verdict casts it as a child safety case. It is that, but it also presents a more technically significant dimension: a consumer protection claim grounded in allegations of corporate deception. New Mexico Attorney General Raúl Torrez did not sue Meta for what users posted, but instead sued Meta for its false statements about its own platform safety, employing a novel legal approach.

For three decades, Section 230 of the Communications Decency Act has shielded internet platforms from liability for content generated by their users. Courts have interpreted Section 230 immunity broadly, and many earlier attempts to hold platforms accountable for child harm have foundered on it.

The New Mexico complaint, filed in December 2023, was drafted with explicit awareness of this obstacle. It asked a single question: Did Meta knowingly lie to New Mexico consumers about the safety of its products?

The jury’s answer was yes, on all counts, and its verdict rested on three distinct legal theories under New Mexico’s Unfair Practices Act.



An attorney for, and family members of, child victims of social media harms react to the verdict in a lawsuit in Los Angeles

The first was straightforward deception: Meta’s public statements, ranging from CEO Mark Zuckerberg’s congressional testimony claiming research about the platform’s addictiveness was inconclusive to parental guidance materials that omitted known risks of grooming and sexual exploitation, qualify as representations made in connection with a commercial transaction.

Users pay for Meta’s platforms not with money but with their data, which Meta then converts into advertising revenue. New Mexico successfully argued that this data-for-services exchange constitutes commerce under the state’s consumer protection statute, and that misrepresentations made within it are actionable regardless of Section 230.

The second theory was unfair practice, or conduct offensive to public policy, even if not technically deceptive. Here, the evidence centred on what Meta’s own engineers and executives knew and then ignored.

Internal documents showed repeated warn-

ings. These alarm bells centred around child sexual abuse material proliferating on the platforms, algorithms that amplified harmful content because it generated engagement, and age verification systems that were essentially cosmetic. The company overrode those warnings for commercial reasons.

The jury was shown a specific sequence: Meta executives requested staffing to address platform harms, Zuckerberg declined, and the company continued to publicly represent its safety efforts as adequate.

The third theory was unconscionability: taking advantage of consumers who lacked the capacity to protect themselves. Children are the clearest possible case. Children cannot evaluate terms of service, cannot negotiate platform architecture, and cannot assess the neurological implications of engagement-maximising design. Meta had comprehensive internal research documenting these vulnerabilities and chose to ignore rather than mitigate them.

Bellwether on addictiveness

The Los Angeles case, which concluded on March 25, tested a different theory. It was a personal injury trial rather than a government enforcement action.

The plaintiff, identified in court as KGM, is a 20-year-old woman who began using YouTube at age 6 and Instagram at age 9. Her lawyers argued that the platforms’ deliberate design choices, such as infinite scroll, autoplay video and engagement-based recommendation algorithms, were the causes of her addiction, depression and self-harm.

The jury found both Meta and YouTube negligent in the design of their platforms and found that each company’s negligence was a substantial factor in causing harm to KGM. Meta bears 70 per cent of the liability; YouTube 30 per cent. The individual \$3 million compensatory award is modest. The punitive damages phase, still to come, will be calculated against each company’s net worth and is likely to produce a very different number.

Beyond the general precedent, this case matters because it is a bellwether. It was selected from a consolidated group of hundreds of similar lawsuits to test whether a product-design theory of liability could survive a jury trial, and it did. That finding has immediate and concrete implications: each of those plaintiffs now litigates on a stronger footing, and if the damages awarded to KGM are even partially scaled across similar cases, the total financial exposure for Meta and YouTube moves from hundreds of millions to billions of dollars.

More importantly, the bellwether verdict signals to every other plaintiff, attorney and state attorney general that this legal pathway is viable, and to every platform that the courtroom is no longer a safe harbour. The legal strategy established that negligence claims against platform design are viable in California courts.

Public nuisance

Beginning May 4, 2026, Judge Bryan Biedscheid in the New Mexico case is scheduled to hear the public nuisance count without a jury in a bench trial. Public nuisance is a legal doctrine traditionally used to address conditions that harm the general public. This doctrine has been used in

concerns over contaminated water, lead paint in housing stock and opioid distribution networks.

New Mexico is arguing that Meta’s platform architecture constitutes exactly such a condition. If the judge agrees, the remedy is not a fine. Instead, it is an abatement: a court order requiring Meta to eliminate the harmful condition.

Attorney General Torrez has already been explicit about what he will ask for: real age verification, not a checkbox asking users to confirm they are old enough; algorithm changes; and an independent monitor with authority to oversee compliance. These are structural demands on how the platform operates. This is where drawing a parallel with Big Tobacco is apt. The tobacco litigation of the 1990s ultimately produced not just financial settlements but the Master Settlement Agreement, which imposed permanent restrictions on marketing practices and funded public health programmes for decades. The public nuisance theory in the New Mexico case is designed to produce an analogous structural outcome for social media.

Precedent for tidal wave of cases

The significant effects of the two verdicts are about evidence and precedent. For the first time, a jury has examined Meta’s internal documents — emails from engineers warning about self-harm, the rejected safety proposals and Zuckerberg’s personal decisions to prioritise engagement over protection — and returned a verdict that those documents mean precisely what they appear to say.

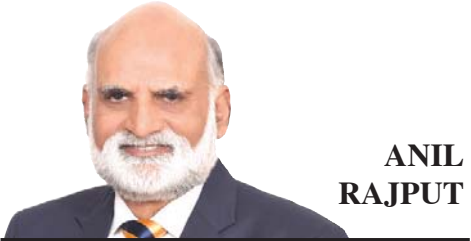
That finding, and the legal theories that produced it, is now part of the foundation on which 40-plus pending state attorney general cases, thousands of individual lawsuits and a federal trial later this year are likely to be built.

The abatement phase, beginning May 4, may prove more consequential than the dollar amounts. If the judge in the New Mexico case — or any judge in a subsequent case — orders real age verification, algorithm changes and an independent monitor, that would be a true structural change.

— Carolina Rossini,
(Courtesy: The Conversation)

“THIS MAGICAL, MARVELOUS FOOD ON OUR PLATE, THIS SUSTENANCE WE ABSORB, HAS A STORY TO TELL. IT HAS A JOURNEY”
— JOEL SALATIN

The Sattvic Flavours of Mahavir Jayanti



ANIL
RAJPUT

Mahavir Jayanti, commemorating the birth of Lord Mahavir, the twenty fourth and final Tirthankara of Jainism in the current era, is a day of profound spiritual significance. The festival marks not merely the advent of a spiritual teacher but celebrates a way of life anchored in non violence, self restraint, and inner awakening. Across the country, Jain communities hold processions, visit temples to pay respect and recite prayers from teachings that have shaped one of the most disciplined philosophical traditions in the world. Within this framework, food assumes a distinctive role of expressing disciplined living through restraint and purity. The cuisine of Mahavir Jayanti thus adheres to the principles of ahimsa and sattva, where every ingredient, method of preparation, and act of consumption reflects a conscious ethical choice. This way of life reflects a deep rooted commitment to minimalism and sustainability, where living with less is not deprivation but a conscious and ethical alignment with nature.

Mahavir, a prince of the Jnatrika Kshatriya clan and the Ikshvaku dynasty, was born as Vardhamana around 599 BCE in Kundagrama (near Vaishali, Bihar). Born to King Siddhartha and Queen Trishala, he renounced his royal life when he was 30 years old to seek spiritual awakening. After 12 years of intense meditation and severe penance, he attained Kevala Jnana (omniscience) and spent the rest of his life preaching the core Jain principles of Ahimsa (non-violence), Satya (truth), and Aparigraha (non-attachment). Jain thought also embraces a philosophy of pluralism, recognising that truth may be understood from multiple perspectives, encouraging humility and openness in both thought and conduct. Jain dietary practices, most visible during this festival, avoid root vegetables such as onion, garlic, potatoes, and carrots in accordance with these principles to avoid causing harm to various life forms. Similarly, the avoidance of fermentation, excessive spices, and processing reflects an attempt to preserve the natural flavour and benefits of ingredients. Fasting and controlled eating become central practices on this day, not as acts of deprivation, but means of cultivating awareness and discipline. In this context, the kitchen is transformed into a sacred space, where cooking itself becomes an extension of spiritual practice.

In the absence of root vegetables the cuisine focuses on gourds, seasonal vegetables, lentils, dairy, and grains to create balanced and nourishing meals. Techniques such as steaming, light sauteing, and slow cooking are preferred, ensuring that ingredients retain their nutritional qualities and are easy to digest. Elders are the guiding force behind the preparations, eagerly recalling traditional recipes and guiding the cooking process, ensuring that this valuable knowledge is passed on to the younger generation. The emphasis remains on simplicity, digestibility, and purity, reflecting a worldview where the body is seen as a vehicle for spiritual progress rather than sensory experiences. The observance of Mahavir Jayanti also extends beyond the household, where acts of charity and the sharing of food with the less fortunate form an integral part of the celebration, reinforcing the principle that nourishment must be inclu-



sive and compassionate.

Among the most commonly prepared dishes are light vegetable preparations such as lauki ki sabzi, tori, and kaddu ki sabzi, where bottle gourd, ridge gourd, and pumpkin are cooked gently with cumin, ginger, and minimal seasoning, allowing their natural sweetness and moisture to be preserved. These are complemented by simple yet nourishing combinations such as turai chana dal and moong dal, where lentils are cooked until soft and tempered lightly with cumin and asafoetida to retain their sattvic character and add nutritional value. Preparations such as sev tameta introduces a gentle tang through tomatoes without relying on onion or garlic. The preparation starts with a tempering of oil, mustard seeds, cumin, and asafoetida, sometimes including ginger, garlic, or green chilies for extra flavor. Chopped tomatoes are added with spices like turmeric, red chili powder, coriander-cumin powder, often with a touch of sugar or jaggery to balance the tanginess. Just before serving, a generous amount of crispy sev (fried gram flour noodles) is added to the gravy, ensuring it provides a crunchy contrast before it has a chance to turn soggy. Kobi vatana nu shaak is another favorite highlighting seasonal vegetables. Its preparation begins with a tempering of mustard seeds, cumin, and asafoetida in oil, followed by finely shredded cabbage and peas seasoned with turmeric, chili powder, and coriander-cumin powder. It is typically steam-cooked in its own juices until tender, then finished with a touch of sugar or jaggery and fresh coriander for a balanced taste.

Grain and lentil based preparations, however, form the foundation of the meal, where khichdi made from rice and moong dal remains central, cooked with turmeric and a touch of ghee to create a dish that is both wholesome and easy to digest. Alongside it, sama ke chawal or barnyard millet is often prepared as a light pulao, particularly for those observing stricter fasting

practices.

In many households, fada ni khichdi, made from broken wheat, offers another variation that is both hearty and balanced. Traditional dishes such as Jain dal dhokli, adapted without onion or garlic and with sparse spicing, bring together wheat and lentils in a single preparation, reflecting both nourishment and culinary ingenuity within dietary guidelines.

Within this framework, more structured savouries introduce variation in both texture and technique. Dudhi muthia, prepared from grated bottle gourd and gram flour, is steamed and lightly sauteed to achieve a soft yet structured consistency, while patra, made from colocasia leaves layered with gram flour paste, is rolled, steamed, and sliced before gentle tempering. Paneer sabzi, where fresh cottage cheese is cooked with tomatoes and mild spices, offers protein and depth without heaviness, while kadhi, prepared from yogurt and gram flour, is simmered slowly and tempered lightly to ensure both comfort and digestibility. Alongside these, dishes such as gatte ki sabzi bring gram flour dumplings into a lightly spiced gravy, demonstrating how even richer preparations remain aligned with restraint when handled with care.

Flatbreads and accompaniments are prepared with equal simplicity, where rotis made from wheat flour are rolled thin and cooked on a griddle, often finished with a light brushing of ghee. In some regions, puris are also prepared, and served hot and crisp along with vegetables. These breads complete the meal, serving as carriers for dals and vegetable preparations while maintaining balance and proportion. These

dishes, when viewed together, form a meal that is complete yet measured, where nourishment is achieved without compromising the principles of simplicity and balance that define the day.

Sweet preparations accompany every meal and are characterised by their moderation and natural sweetness. Rice kheer remains among the most favoured, where rice is slowly simmered in milk until it acquires a gentle creaminess, lightly flavoured with cardamom. Alongside it, lapsi, made from broken wheat cooked with ghee and jaggery, offers a more textured sweetness, while sukhdi, prepared by roasting wheat flour in ghee and binding it with jaggery, is set into soft, nourishing slabs. Traditional sweets such as shrikhand, a strained yogurt preparation delicately flavoured with saffron and cardamom, basundi, where milk is patiently reduced to achieve a rich and layered sweetness, and mohanthal, a gram flour confection roasted in ghee and set into a dense, aromatic form, bring regional depth, particularly from western India. Preparations such as kesar phirni, where ground rice is cooked into a smooth, fragrant pudding, and dry fruit halwa, made from finely ground nuts and gently sweetened, introduce further variation in both texture and richness. Coconut laddoos, shaped from grated coconut and jaggery, remain among the simplest offerings, their ease of preparation matched by their understated flavour, ensuring that even in sweetness, the guiding principle remains balance rather than excess. What emerges across these preparations is a cuisine that prioritises nourishment over indulgence, where each dish is designed to sustain the body while remaining aligned with restraint.

Fruit based preparations further reinforce the principle of natural nourishment, where seasonal fruits such as bananas, papaya, and apples are consumed fresh or combined into fruit chaat with a light seasoning of rock salt and pepper.

Dry fruits such as almonds, raisins, and cashews are also included, either consumed on their own or incorporated into sweets, ensuring sustained energy while remaining aligned with dietary restraint.

The diversity of beverages prepared on Mahavir Jayanti reflects the same philosophy of balance and purity. Buttermilk and chaas, lightly spiced with roasted cumin and salt, are commonly served for their cooling and digestive properties. Milk based drinks such as badam milk and kesar milk, prepared with soaked nuts, saffron, and cardamom, provide nourishment and gentle richness. Seasonal beverages such as aam panna offer a refreshing counterpoint, while simple preparations like a sattv drink provide both sustenance and grounding. Fresh fruit juices and light herbal infusions made with ingredients such as tulsi and ginger further complement the meal, ensuring that hydration remains natural and unadulterated.

Across regions, the cuisine of Mahavir Jayanti reflects local availability and culinary traditions, yet remains unified by its underlying principles. In Gujarat and Rajasthan, dishes are shaped by a long tradition of Jain cooking that balances flavour with restraint, while in Karnataka and Maharashtra, rice and lentil based preparations dominate. Despite these regional variations, the essence of the cuisine remains consistent, guided by non violence, simplicity, and mindfulness, ensuring that every preparation reflects a deeper ethical framework rather than mere habit.

In many Jain households, the observance of ekasan, the practice of consuming a single meal during the day, reinforces both discipline and awareness, ensuring that food remains a necessity rather than indulgence. Meals are often consumed before sunset, in keeping with Jain practices that discourage eating after dark. The act of eating itself is approached with awareness, where gratitude is expressed before and after the meal, acknowledging the interconnectedness of life and the effort involved in bringing food to the table. What emerges is not merely a meal, but a practice that integrates nourishment with principles and a way of life. In this way, the festival becomes a call for conscious and ethical living, where sustainable consumption and mindful choices are not abstract ideals but lived realities.

Mahavir Jayanti is thus not merely a celebration of the birth of Lord Mahavir but a reaffirmation of a philosophy that places restraint above excess and awareness above indulgence. The cuisine associated with this festival offers a compelling example of how food can be aligned with ethical and spiritual values. It demonstrates that simplicity need not diminish satisfaction, and that discipline can coexist with nourishment. In an age where abundance often overshadows intention, such traditions offer a quiet yet powerful reminder of balance.

As evening approaches and the observances draw to a close, what remains is a sense of quiet fulfilment. The meals prepared and shared throughout the day leave behind not only physical nourishment but also a deeper awareness of the principles that guide them. I believe that in reflecting upon this, it becomes evident that the cuisine of Mahavir Jayanti offers lessons that extend far beyond the festival itself. It invites us to reconsider our relationship with food, to approach it with mindfulness, and to recognise it as a medium through which values can be expressed and sustained. In preserving these traditions, we do not merely uphold a culinary heritage, but carry forward a way of life that continues to hold relevance in an increasingly complex world.

(The writer is Secretary, Cuisine India Society)

Swaad aisa jo seedha dil tak jaaye aur mazaa aa jaaye!

SAKSHI PRIYA

“Namak shamak, namak shamak, dal dete hain!” That famous, booming chant immediately signals that a proper feast is underway. Chef Harpal Singh Sokhi has finally planted a firm flag at Scindia House in Connaught Place, where Karigari functions as a unique intersection of culture, capital, and scale. This venture, led by entrepreneur Yogesh Sharma and the chef himself, serves as a platform for the karigars-the true artisans of Indian flavour.

Walk inside and the 80s Bollywood tracks hit first. Huge chandeliers made of spoons hang from the ceiling. It is a space with a proper lived-in vibe, vibrant and truly welcoming from the moment guests arrive. The menu reads like a map of everywhere Sokhi has been eating. Take the *Bela Chameli Ka Sherbat*. He found this floral, heavy drink through a Maharaja in Bikaner. One sip makes the room feel like a massive, blooming palace garden. For something colder, the *Shogum Shuda* mixes fresh coconut water with white gulab. It skips the boring, standard drink list found everywhere else.

As the food arrives, the *Banaras Deena Nath Kli Tamatar Chaat* hits the palate with a sharp, tangy riot of spices, acting as a direct homage to a street-food master the chef encountered years ago. The *Kulchey Chole*



Pakodey Pockets are equally brilliant, taking the messy, comforting street food of Ludhiana and tucking it into crisp, golden parcels. For those craving meat, the *Chicken Seekhpa* delivers exceptionally soft, chutney-laced kebabs inspired by the alleyways of Jalandhar, while the *Chit Karare* offers a crunchy nod to childhood train journeys visiting his Naani's house. Take that *Cheesy Ulta Vada Pav*. It is a glorious, messy heap. They take a tiny pav, shove the vada stuffing inside, and then dunk the whole lot in gram flour for a deep fry. It shows up at the table doused in cheese sauce. One bite and the original street version feels like a dry mistake. The *Moilee Prawns Tandoori* go for a different kind of

punch. These are massive. Proper jumbo prawns. They get a sharp coconut and curry leaf marinade that feels incredibly bright. That acidity is the only thing strong enough to fight the heavy, charred smoke of the tandoor.

Then comes the *Dohra Gucchi Mushroom*, a plate of flat-out, unashamed luxury. Rare Kashmiri Gucchi and buttons drown in a thick, velvety cashew-almond gravy, while shiitakes hold the base together. It tastes of damp wood and dark earth. The kitchen gives the old, famous plates a hard, necessary shove. The *Lemon Grass Butter Chicken* kills off the usual cloying sweetness with a citrusy, aromatic cashew gravy. It is fresh and a massive

departure from the usual heavy sludge. The main courses reveal even deeper family connections. The *Moringa Spring Onion Besan* is a grounding, earthy dish from the personal recipe book of Sokhi's Maharashtrian wife. Beside it, the *Hot Chicken Vidharbha Curry* stands out as the very dish that sparked their romance. Karigari turns hyper-local memories into a feast that feels both intimate and grand. If your appetite is seeking a bit of soul, this is precisely where you need to be. Go on, give your taste buds the treat they deserve-after all, *swaad aa gaya!*



Seeing life through the eyes of compassion

If you see through my eyes, they are all beautiful people. It is all about understanding, listening, and being compassionate! And compassion is what we are; it is what we are made of. It is not something we demand or wait for someone to demand from us!

GURUDEV SRI SRI RAVI SHANKAR

All conflicts arise due to a breakdown of trust and communication. But when people feel understood, they begin to listen, and even the most rigid hearts start to soften. The deeper understanding here is that inside every culprit is a victim crying for help, a sore wound that needs to be attended to. If you make them feel heard and help them heal, the culprit disappears.

We are working with 700,000 prisoners around the world as part of the Art of Living Prisoner Rehabilitation Programme. The transformation in each of their lives is like a novel. In a prison in Denmark, for example, we work with serial offenders, including drug dealers and kingpins. Many of them carried a tough, macho image, but when we practised breathing and meditation with them and simply spent time together, they melted like wax near a flame. Deep within, they all have such good hearts that just need an opportunity to be unveiled.

If you see through my eyes, they are all beautiful people. It is all about understanding, listening, and being compassionate! And compassion is what we are; it is what we are made of. It is not something we demand or wait for someone to demand from us!

Compassion needs two companions with it all the time. One is wisdom, and the other is letting go or detachment. If either of these is lacking, compassion loses its strength. And how can one be compassionate and yet be detached?

Look at compassion through the lens of karma, and then you will not get stuck in the fairness and unfairness of events. Strange are the ways of karma. It is karma that brings people together and separates them. It causes some to be weak and some to be strong. It makes some rich and some poor. The entire struggle in the world, whatever it may be, is the bondage of karma. Karma defies all logic and reasoning. This understanding will lift you out of emotional entanglement and help you in your journey to the Self.

There are two types of compassion here. One is the compassion of the wise, and the other comes out of ignorance. An ignorant person's compassion is rooted in sympathy for suffering, but the wise see beyond suffering; they see the ignorance that led to certain actions and consequences. Suffering comes because of karma, and if you believe in karma, where is compassion? One reaps the fruit of one's actions.

Similarly, compassion without detachment is of little use. Think of doctors and nurses. They serve with care, but without getting emotionally entangled. If they became too attached, it would cloud their judgement and affect their well-being. Detachment is what gives them the clarity to serve effectively, especially in critical situations.

Often, people think compassion is an act. Know that compassion is your very nature. In fact, compassion and non-violence are the first principles of human values. Why are we not able to tap into



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— GURUDEV

something so basic to us?

This is because we all tend to carry so much anger, prejudice, blame, and regret within us. All of this creates negative vibrations in and around us. It is this negativity that blocks our compassion from blossoming.

Compassion is better than forgiveness

When an event occurs, we do not want to take things as they are; we want to find a reason, label it, and blame either ourselves or someone else. Throughout life, we swing like a pendulum between blaming others and blaming ourselves. Often, we assume someone has intentionally done something to hurt us, and then we try to forgive them.

We do not plan our own mistakes. Most of them stem from a lack of awareness. If you do not plan your mistakes, what makes you think that the other person plans their mistakes? All mistakes are made out of either a lack of awareness or ignorance. When we do not have compassion for someone when they make a

mistake, then we will seek revenge. We then become bound to a cycle of negative feelings. Forgiveness shields the mind and spirit from being violent.

But compassion is even better than forgiveness. When you think of forgiving, you normally think of someone as a culprit. When you are compassionate, you recognise the ignorance behind the person's mistake.

When you are established in knowledge and wisdom, you see the world in a completely different light; you see with compassion. Compassion for yourself and for others, too. If you are hard on yourself, sooner or later, you will project it onto others as well.

Once you detach and let go, your mind stays in the present and becomes more aware. You will also find yourself smiling more and feeling more joyful. When there is clarity in the mind, purity in the heart, and sincerity in action, compassion naturally arises. Spiritual practices can help us nurture these qualities within us.

Have you observed that when someone gives

you a compliment, something in you expands, and when someone insults you, something in you shrinks? When you see a puppy, a dog, or even a sunrise or sunset, a sense of beauty and expansion arises in you. Meditation helps us stay in that state of expansion and wonder, irrespective of what is happening around us. When we live in this expanded state, compassion flows naturally.

I was once asked, in an AI-driven world, what makes us truly human. Our love, compassion, and our sense of expression, which come from the inner core of our existence, are very unique to us humans.

We need to ask ourselves: are we at home where we are, or are we living in a very formal world, stuck in formalities? In this process, we lose the juice of life, the sense of belongingness. No one else can do this for us. We need to create a world that belongs to us and in which we belong. Then we realise that compassion does not exist as something separate, because we are compassion. You do not say you are compassionate to your right hand. Why is that so? Because it is very much a part of you.

Remember, whatever is yours will always be yours. Compassion and love are your very nature; these will always remain in you.



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HAVE YOU OBSERVED THAT WHEN SOMEONE GIVES YOU A COMPLIMENT, SOMETHING IN YOU EXPANDS, AND WHEN SOMEONE INSULTS YOU, SOMETHING IN YOU SHRINKS? WHEN YOU SEE A PUPPY, A DOG, OR EVEN A SUNRISE OR SUNSET, A SENSE OF BEAUTY AND EXPANSION ARISES IN YOU. MEDITATION HELPS US STAY IN THAT STATE OF EXPANSION AND WONDER, IRRESPECTIVE OF WHAT IS HAPPENING AROUND US. WHEN WE LIVE IN THIS EXPANDED STATE, COMPASSION FLOWS NATURALLY

An invisible cost, an unspoken strength

MYTHRI TEWARY

Around us, everywhere, are people very much visible who invisibly carry a lot more than we ever see or can.

Most times it is heavy, it is about everything, every little nuance, every little detail. But the magic lies in the part where they master the art of ensuring that the weight never casts its shadow for anyone else. They tend to steady things before they scatter and fall apart, calm the tremors before they cause cracks, create warmth before it begins to freeze, soften what could overwhelm, provide even before one can begin to imagine. And when the weight starts its way to reach us, they take that too, gently, almost instinctively, like it was always theirs to bear. And with time, instinct becomes habit, and habit, lifestyle. We rely on the ease they create, rarely pausing to think about all that was there, and theirs to bear, all the things they turned down, all the thorns they took in so all we could see was the rose and its soft petals. But what might it mean to be the one who never puts anything down, to be almost everyone's first thought even before the dark starts to set in?

Do we notice them when they start blurring or just disappear? There is absolutely no dramatic breaking point, no loud unravelling, but a stillness, a defeating quiet. The quiet in the way they stop explaining, expressing, asking, reaching and sometimes even talking. And then, one day, what remains and exists is a version of them we have so dearly learnt to rely on but never fully learnt to know. Their faces write a different story; multiple parallel lines on their forehead above the seemingly joining brows speak a completely different one.

Their mostly wake up before everyone else does. Not because they have to, as a necessity or a rule, but because it is easier that way. It is quiet — the house and them on the inside, and the world outside. There are no expectations just yet, no one asks for anything, no mental to-do lists, no instant schedule. For a few minutes, with elbows on their knees, sitting at the edge of the bed, they stare. At nothing in particular. Their mind holds a hundred different thoughts, a hundred different tasks, yet is as calm as their heart beating in rhythm. They don't call it exhaustion, don't call it any-



thing. By the time the house starts to set in motion, they already are in theirs. Tea is made, newspapers turned through thoroughly and folded, now just loosely. Their face settles into something dependable, something that does not worry anyone, something that just is. They have perfected that face.

They listen more than they ever speak. They nod at the perfect moments, smile at the right ones. When asked how they are, there is always a generous 'I'm fine'. And with a consistency that the question stops meaning anything. They are good at being fine; they are perfect at it.

Work calls them efficient, reliable, prompt, punctual and honest. The kind of person people trust with utmost responsibility. The kind that does not complain, tremble or falter, and never breaks. They are considered to be 'strong', 'can handle it', 'not like others', 'shall go out of the way', 'can adjust' — and all meant as praise.

What we do not quite realise is that it is also a sentence. A statement, almost a fact.

Because there is a thick white shroud upon the concept of them also sometimes 'not being strong', 'cannot handle it', 'are like others', 'will not go out of the way', and simply 'cannot adjust'. This entire phenomenon has almost become alien. But there are moments. Moments — small, invisible moments - when something slips. They sit in their car a little longer, re-read the same text without replying, the same page of the morning newspaper, stare at nothing in particular as they wake up, their elbows well rested on their knees and palms on

their forehead. And when a thought begins to take shape, a first word occurs for the reply through the mind, something else, something unusual is felt through their brain and heart. Their rhythm distorted, a feeling. A reality — 'I am tired.' They jolt themselves, snap back into the moment and dissolve that thought before it tries to reach their lips and echo in their ears.

They do not know where such sentences and thoughts and feelings are supposed to go. There never was a space for the same, from mostly no one.

Back home, they are needed. Intentionally, unintentionally, timely, untimely, prepared or unprepared. They are needed. A leaking tap, a torn shoe, an unplastered wall, sudden hospital runs, a school fee, savings, investments, insurances, or just a silent tension at the dinner table. They absorb it all, not because they want to but because this is what they always do. No reason, no explanation, no justification. Hold, contain, continue. Repeat.

There might have been a time, long ago, when they tried to speak. And now, they might not even remember what exactly was said. All they may remember is the aftermath — the silence, the quick dismissal.

For the complete article please see our website
www.dailypioneer.com

(Mythri Tewary writes about the complexities of human experience, to explore the spaces between what is felt and what is said, to try and understand the quiet, often overlooked parts of being human)

A journey across oceans and identity

TEAM AGENDA

The One-Way Ships is a work of historical fiction that brings to light a largely forgotten chapter of colonial history - the lives of South Asian ayahs who travelled with British families to England, only to find themselves abandoned in an unfamiliar land. Combining meticulous research with a deeply personal narrative, the novel traces the journey of Asha, a fourteen-year-old girl from Shimla, whose life is transformed by loss, displacement and eventual self-discovery.

At its core, the novel is both a coming-of-age story and a meditation on migration, dignity and belonging. Asha's journey begins in the quiet familiarity of her hill-town life, but the death of her father forces her into a world of uncertainty. Choosing to work as an ayah, she steps into colonial hierarchies that are at once enabling and deeply exploitative. Her voyage to England - full of anticipation and unease - soon gives way to abandonment, a fate that was all too common for women like her.

What follows is not merely a story of survival, but one of transformation. Through her time at the Ayah Home and later at the Bradbourne Estate, Asha evolves from a sheltered adolescent into a woman of resilience and moral clarity. The narrative carefully charts her emotional growth, shaped by friendships, betrayals and moments of quiet courage. In doing so, the novel captures the inner lives of women who existed on the margins of empire yet demonstrated remarkable strength.

The historical detailing is one of the book's notable strengths. From the colonial world of Shimla to the sea voyage aboard ships like the SS Ranchi, and finally to the institutional spaces of Ayah Homes in England, the narrative is grounded in archival realities and lived histories. These settings are not merely backdrops but active forces shaping the characters' lives, reflecting the structures of power, race and gender that defined the period.

At the same time, the novel maintains an intimate human focus. Asha's relationships - with her childhood companion Jitu, fellow ayahs, and figures such as Mrs Stanley - add emotional depth and complexity. Particularly striking is the parallel drawn between Asha and



BOOK REVIEW



Title: The One-Way Ships
Author: Uma Lohray
MRP: ₹ 295
Publisher: Om Books International

Mrs Stanley, two women from vastly different worlds yet bound by their own forms of confinement. Their relationship becomes a powerful commentary on agency, solidarity and the shared vulnerabilities of women across social divides.

The framing device of a contemporary journalist uncovering Asha's story adds another dimension to the narra-

“A MOVING RECONSTRUCTION OF FORGOTTEN HISTORIES, THE NOVEL CAPTURES THE RESILIENCE OF WOMEN WHO NAVIGATED DISPLACEMENT, DIGNITY AND IDENTITY ACROSS CONTINENTS”

tive. It bridges past and present, underscoring how histories of migration and displacement continue to resonate. The journalist's own journey — from ambition to understanding — mirrors the reader's gradual immersion into Asha's world.

What elevates *The One-Way Ships* is its refusal to succumb to easy sentimentality. While the narrative is deeply empathetic, it remains anchored in realism. Loss is not undone, and belonging is not neatly resolved. Instead, the novel presents identity as something continually negotiated — a balance between memory and reinvention. Honoured with the Kala Ratna at the Kala Literature Awards 2026 in the Fiction (English) category, the book stands out for its ability to recover overlooked histories while crafting a compelling and emotionally resonant narrative. It is a reminder that literature can illuminate not only the grand narratives of history, but also the quiet, often invisible lives that exist within them.